

Hamlet

William Shakespeare · 1603

Standard Ebooks edition (modern text drawing on the 1604–05 Second Quarto and the 1623 First Folio)

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

Common Core edition (standards shown for this framework only)

21 scene lessons plus 2 seminar day(s), a test day and an essay day: 26 class days of 90 minutes, 5 a week (block schedule), 6 weeks
Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

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Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson 1: introduction (author, context, reception, overview)
4. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–21), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
5. Whole-book test and answer key
6. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Hamlet survives in three early texts: the First Quarto (1603), the Second Quarto (1604–05) and the First Folio (1623). The reading text is the Standard Ebooks edition, a conflated modern text divided into the conventional 20 scenes plus the cast list. The year shown is the first printing; the play was probably written about 1599–1601. Cite act, scene and line from this edition.

Content note for teachers: Murder, a ghost, feigned and real madness, suicidal thoughts ('To be, or not to be'), Ophelia's possible suicide, sexual wordplay, and multiple on-stage deaths; Hamlet's treatment of Ophelia and Gertrude deserves critical discussion. See the scene notes and the safe-messaging script.

Grades: Grades 11–12 (also 10 with support; scales to graduate via rigor levels). Excerpt-based support track: these plays are above the grades 6–8 text-complexity band, so Middle School prompts work from teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 6. **Class days:** 26 × 90 minutes (21 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does Hamlet suggest about revenge and justice?
- What does Hamlet suggest about action and delay?
- What does Hamlet suggest about appearance and reality?
- What does Hamlet suggest about death and mortality?
- What does Hamlet suggest about corruption and the state?

Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the play.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

Standards: Common Core

RL.7.2, RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.7.1, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4

Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org

Assessments: Daily scene quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-book test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Scene lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	*Introduction: author, context and reception* Dramatis Personae Act I, Scene I Act I, Scene II Act I, Scene III	5 × 90 min (450 min)	*revenge and justice* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Scene quizzes in the app • Introduction: author, context and reception • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt
2	Act I, Scene IV *Socratic seminar on revenge and justice* Act I, Scene V Act II, Scene I Act II, Scene II	5 × 90 min (450 min)	*action and delay* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Scene quizzes in the app • Socratic seminar on revenge and justice • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt
3	Act III, Scene I Act III, Scene II Act III, Scene III Act III, Scene IV Act IV, Scene I	5 × 90 min (450 min)	*appearance and reality* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Scene quizzes in the app • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt
4	Act IV, Scene II Act IV, Scene III *Socratic seminar on action and delay* Act IV, Scene IV Act IV, Scene V	5 × 90 min (450 min)	*death and mortality* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Scene quizzes in the app • Socratic seminar on action and delay • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt
5	Act IV, Scene VI Act IV, Scene VII Act V, Scene I Act V, Scene II *Whole-book test (90 minutes)*	5 × 90 min (450 min)	*corruption and the state* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Scene quizzes in the app • Whole-book test (90 minutes) • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Whole-book test and final essay

6	*Final essay workshop and submission*	1 × 90 min (90 min)	*revenge and justice* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Scene quizzes in the app • Final essay workshop and submission • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Whole-book test and final essay

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: Introduction to Hamlet

Author biography

William Shakespeare was baptized in Stratford-upon-Avon on 26 April 1564, the son of John Shakespeare, a glover and town official, and Mary Arden. He probably attended Stratford's grammar school, married Anne Hathaway in 1582, and had three children: Susanna and the twins Hamnet and Judith (Hamnet died aged eleven in 1596). By the early 1590s he was an actor and playwright in London; from 1594 he was a sharer in the Lord Chamberlain's Men, who built the Globe theatre in 1599 and became the King's Men when James VI of Scotland became James I of England in 1603. He wrote or co-wrote about 38 plays and the Sonnets, and died in Stratford on 23 April 1616. Seven years later his fellow actors John Heminges and Henry Condell published 36 of his plays in the First Folio (1623).

Historical and cultural context

Hamlet was probably written between about 1599 and 1601, after Julius Caesar, for the Lord Chamberlain's Men at the Globe; Richard Burbage played the prince. Its story goes back to the Danish chronicle of Saxo Grammaticus (the tale of Amleth, written around 1200), retold in French by François de Belleforest (1570). An earlier English Hamlet play, now lost and often called the "Ur-Hamlet," was on stage by 1589, when Thomas Nashe joked about it. Revenge tragedy was a popular genre, following Thomas Kyd's The Spanish Tragedy (c. 1587). The play draws on live questions of its time: Protestant doubts about purgatory and ghosts (Hamlet studies at Wittenberg, Luther's university), the duty and danger of revenge, and succession, since Elizabeth I was old and had no heir.

Publication and reception, then and now

Hamlet survives in three early texts: a short First Quarto (1603), a long Second Quarto (1604–05) and the First Folio (1623), which differ in many lines and in whole passages. Modern editions, including the reading text here, combine them. It is Shakespeare's longest play.

Then: It was popular at once: the Cambridge scholar Gabriel Harvey wrote in the margin of a book that it pleased "the wiser sort," and the First Quarto's title page says it had been acted in London and at Cambridge and Oxford. After 1660 it remained one of the most performed tragedies; the Romantic writers Goethe and Coleridge made Hamlet's divided mind the centre of interpretation.

Now: Hamlet is perhaps the most performed and written-about play in the world. Readings have been psychological (Freud and Ernest Jones's Oedipal theory), political, feminist (Ophelia's madness and silencing) and existential. Films include Laurence Olivier's (1948), Grigori Kozintsev's (1964) and Kenneth Branagh's (1996); Disney's The Lion King (1994) borrows its plot. Lines such as "To be, or not to be" and "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark" are part of everyday English.

Overview (spoiler-free)

Prince Hamlet returns to Denmark for his father's funeral and finds his uncle Claudius on the throne, married to his mother Gertrude. Guards on the castle walls have seen a ghost that looks like the dead king. What the ghost tells Hamlet, and what Hamlet does and fails to do about it, is the play.

Main themes

- revenge and justice: the Ghost demands revenge; is it a duty, a crime or both?
- action and delay: why does Hamlet wait? Thought, conscience, doubt, or circumstance?
- appearance and reality: "seems" versus "is"; feigned madness, spying and plays within plays.
- death and mortality: from the Ghost to the gravediggers, what death means and what it makes of us.
- corruption and the state: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark."

Why it matters

Hamlet is the great play about thinking: about how hard it is to know the truth, to act rightly when you are unsure, and to live with grief, anger and doubt. Its questions about revenge, mental health, family loyalty and political corruption remain urgent, and its language is the most quoted in English.

Spoilers · teacher only

The Ghost says Claudius murdered him and demands revenge. Hamlet feigns madness, rejects Ophelia, and stages a play (The Mousetrap) that confirms Claudius's guilt. He spares Claudius at prayer, then kills Polonius, hidden behind a curtain, by mistake. Claudius sends Hamlet to England to be executed; Hamlet escapes, sending Rosencrantz and Guildenstern to their deaths. Ophelia goes mad and drowns. Laertes returns for revenge, and Claudius plots a rigged fencing match with a poisoned blade and poisoned wine. Gertrude drinks the poison; Laertes and Hamlet are both wounded with the poisoned blade; Hamlet kills Claudius and dies in Horatio's arms. Fortinbras of Norway takes the throne.

Lesson plan (90 minutes)

> **0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)**
>
> *Before we open Hamlet: Is revenge ever justified? Write for five minutes about a time when you wanted to "get even," and what you did.*
> **Prompt:** Before we open Hamlet: Is revenge ever justified? Write for five minutes about a time when you wanted to "get even," and what you did.

> **8–18 min · Key terms · I do (10 min)**
>
> *revenge tragedy (a play driven by a quest for vengeance, ending in many deaths); soliloquy (a speech alone revealing thoughts); aside; foil (a character who highlights another by contrast: Laertes and Fortinbras for Hamlet); feigned madness (pretended insanity, an "antic disposition"); play within a play; regicide (killing a king).*

18–28 min · Mini-lecture: author, context, reception · I do (10 min)

About the author. William Shakespeare was baptized in Stratford-upon-Avon on 26 April 1564, the son of John Shakespeare, a glover and town official, and Mary Arden. He probably attended Stratford's grammar school, married Anne Hathaway in 1582, and had three children: Susanna and the twins Hamnet and Judith (Hamnet died aged eleven in 1596). By the early 1590s he was an actor and playwright in London; from 1594 he was a sharer in the Lord Chamberlain's Men, who built the Globe theatre in 1599 and became the King's Men when James VI of Scotland became James I of England in 1603. He wrote or co-wrote about 38 plays and the Sonnets, and died in Stratford on 23 April 1616. Seven years later his fellow actors John Heminges and Henry Condell published 36 of his plays in the First Folio (1623). The world of the book. Hamlet was probably written between about 1599 and 1601, after Julius Caesar, for the Lord Chamberlain's Men at the Globe; Richard Burbage played the prince. Its story goes back to the Danish chronicle of Saxo Grammaticus (the tale of Amleth, written around 1200), retold in French by François de Belleforest (1570). An earlier English Hamlet play, now lost and often called the "Ur-Hamlet," was on stage by 1589, when Thomas Nashe joked about it. Revenge tragedy was a popular genre, following Thomas Kyd's The Spanish Tragedy (c. 1587). The play draws on live questions of its time: Protestant doubts about purgatory and ghosts (Hamlet studies at Wittenberg, Luther's university), the duty and danger of revenge, and succession, since Elizabeth I was old and had no heir. Publication and reception. Hamlet survives in three early texts: a short First Quarto (1603), a long Second Quarto (1604–05) and the First Folio (1623), which differ in many lines and in whole passages. Modern editions, including the reading text here, combine them. It is Shakespeare's longest play. Then: It was popular at once: the Cambridge scholar Gabriel Harvey wrote in the margin of a book that it pleased "the wiser sort," and the First Quarto's title page says it had been acted in London and at Cambridge and Oxford. After 1660 it remained one of the most performed tragedies; the Romantic writers Goethe and Coleridge made Hamlet's divided mind the centre of interpretation. Now: Hamlet is perhaps the most performed and written-about play in the world. Readings have been psychological (Freud and Ernest Jones's Oedipal theory), political, feminist (Ophelia's madness and silencing) and existential. Films include Laurence Olivier's (1948), Grigori Kozintsev's (1964) and Kenneth Branagh's (1996); Disney's The Lion King (1994) borrows its plot. Lines such as "To be, or not to be" and "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark" are part of everyday English.

28–40 min · I do: the book in one passage · I do (12 min)

“Something is rotten in the state of Denmark” (Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus (speech 27)). Marcellus's line after the Ghost appears: the play's diagnosis of a corrupt state.

> *Something is rotten in the state of Denmark* *(Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus (speech 27))*

Think-aloud: “Something is rotten in the state of Denmark” (Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus (speech 27)). Marcellus's line after the Ghost appears: the play's diagnosis of a corrupt state.

40–55 min · We do: overview and themes · We do (15 min)

What the book is about (no spoilers): Prince Hamlet returns to Denmark for his father's funeral and finds his uncle Claudius on the throne, married to his mother Gertrude. Guards on the castle walls have seen a ghost that looks like the dead king. What the ghost tells Hamlet, and what Hamlet does and fails to do about it, is the play. Themes to track: revenge and justice: the Ghost demands revenge; is it a duty, a crime or both? action and delay: why does Hamlet wait? Thought, conscience, doubt, or circumstance? appearance and reality: "seems" versus "is"; feigned madness, spying and plays within plays. death and mortality: from the Ghost to the gravediggers, what death means and what it makes of us. corruption and the state: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark."

55–70 min · You do: reading journal · You do (15 min)

Set up a reading journal: one page per theme with a prediction and a question. Theme page "action and delay": Prediction: Hamlet will hesitate because he is not sure the Ghost is honest. Question: is thinking too much a weakness or a strength?
Task: Set up a reading journal for Hamlet: one page per theme, each with a prediction and a question.
Exemplar: Theme page "action and delay": Prediction: Hamlet will hesitate because he is not sure the Ghost is honest. Question: is thinking too much a weakness or a strength?

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)

Why does Hamlet still matter? Hamlet is the great play about thinking: about how hard it is to know the truth, to act rightly when you are unsure, and to live with grief, anger and doubt. Its questions about revenge, mental health, family loyalty and political corruption remain urgent, and its language is the most quoted in English.
Anchor question: Why might Hamlet still be taught today?
Facilitation: Hamlet is the great play about thinking: about how hard it is to know the truth, to act rightly when you are unsure, and to live with grief, anger and doubt. Its questions about revenge, mental health, family loyalty and political corruption remain urgent, and its language is the most quoted in English.

80–87 min · Exit ticket · You do (7 min)

Name one historical or literary context that helps explain something in Hamlet. Answer: Examples: revenge tragedy conventions (ghost, delay, feigned madness, bloody end); Protestant doubts about ghosts and purgatory (Hamlet tests the Ghost); Elizabeth's lack of an heir (succession and Fortinbras).
Exit ticket: Name one historical or literary context that helps explain something in Hamlet.
Answer: Examples: revenge tragedy conventions (ghost, delay, feigned madness, bloody end); Protestant doubts about ghosts and purgatory (Hamlet tests the Ghost); Elizabeth's lack of an heir (succession and Fortinbras).

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)

Tomorrow we begin reading: Dramatis Personae.

Teacher notes · sources: Folger Shakespeare Library, "Shakespeare's life" (https://www.folger.edu/explore/shakespeares-life/); Shakespeare Birthplace Trust, "William Shakespeare" (https://www.shakespeare.org.uk/explore-shakespeare/shakespedia/william-shakespeare/); Folger Shakespeare Library, "Hamlet" (https://www.folger.edu/explore/shakespeares-works/hamlet/); Royal Shakespeare Company, "Hamlet: about the play" (https://www.rsc.org.uk/hamlet/about-the-play); British Library, "Hamlet: the First Quarto (1603)" (https://www.bl.uk/collection-items/hamlet-first-quarto-1603); Saxo Grammaticus, Gesta Danorum, Book III (Amleth) (https://www.gutenberg.org/); Britannica, "Hamlet" (https://www.britannica.com/topic/Hamlet-by-Shakespeare)

Flags (verify before teaching):

- The date (about 1599–1601) is a scholarly inference; Q1 (1603) gives a terminus.
- Gabriel Harvey's note cannot be dated exactly; scholars date it between 1598 and 1601.
- Any link between Hamlet and Shakespeare's son Hamnet (died 1596) is speculation; present it as such if raised.

Lesson 2: Dramatis Personae

Focus: the court of Denmark

Teacher only · spoilers

The cast list centres on the Danish court at Elsinore: King Claudius; Queen Gertrude; Hamlet, 'son to the late, and nephew to the present king'; the lord chamberlain Polonius and his children Laertes and Ophelia; Hamlet's friend Horatio; courtiers including Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and Osric; officers and soldiers; players; two gravediggers; Fortinbras, prince of Norway; and the Ghost of Hamlet's father.

Background: Elsinore (Helsingør) was a real Danish castle (Kronborg) controlling the sound between Denmark and Sweden; English actors had performed there in the 1580s. Shakespeare's story comes from Saxo Grammaticus's Danish chronicle via Belleforest.

Significance: The list shows three sons with dead fathers (Hamlet, Laertes, Fortinbras) and a court thick with courtiers and spies, the structure on which the tragedy runs.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
If someone close to you remarried soon after a death in the family, how might you feel? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to corruption and the state because....
Prompt: If someone close to you remarried soon after a death in the family, how might you feel?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to corruption and the state because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: the court is full of courtiers, officers and spies.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: messengers — people who carry messages; attendants — servants who wait on a person of rank; sailors — seamen; foreknowing — knowing in advance; harrows — distresses deeply; tears at.
Words: messengers: people who carry messages · attendants: servants who wait on a person of rank · sailors: seamen · foreknowing: knowing in advance · harrows: distresses deeply; tears at

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Elsinore (Helsingør) was a real Danish castle (Kronborg) controlling the sound between Denmark and Sweden; English actors had performed there in the 1580s. Shakespeare's story comes from Saxo Grammaticus's Danish chronicle via Belleforest. The list shows three sons with dead fathers (Hamlet, Laertes, Fortinbras) and a court thick with courtiers and spies, the structure on which the tragedy runs. Characterization: Hamlet is "son to the late, and nephew to the present king": his whole conflict in one line. Setting: "Scene: Denmark": a single kingdom, a court, a castle. Structure: Foils in the cast: Laertes (son to Polonius) and Fortinbras (prince of Norway) are sons with fathers to avenge, like Hamlet. Watch for the Ghost: listed last, after the attendants: the dead king haunts the bottom of the cast list and the top of the plot.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "Gertrude, queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet" (Dramatis Personae, speech (speech 0)). Gertrude's two roles. That is characterization at work: Hamlet is "son to the late, and nephew to the present king": his whole conflict in one line.

> *Gertrude, queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet (Dramatis Personae, speech (speech 0))*

Think-aloud: I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "Gertrude, queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet" (Dramatis Personae, speech (speech 0)). Gertrude's two roles. That is characterization at work: Hamlet is "son to the late, and nephew to the present king": his whole conflict in one line.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Hamlet's father is dead and his uncle is king. Expected link: corruption and the state. Ask: How does this line connect to corruption and the state? Expected: The court is full of courtiers, officers and spies. (Hamlet's divided position.)

> *Hamlet, son to the late, and nephew to the present king (Dramatis Personae, speech (speech 0))*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Hamlet's father is dead and his uncle is king. Expected link: corruption and the state.
Ask: How does this line connect to corruption and the state?
Expected answer: The court is full of courtiers, officers and spies. (Hamlet's divided position.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)

Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).

Annotate the scene for characterization, setting (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about the court of Denmark? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Dramatis Personae develops the idea of the court of Denmark. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and setting shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: The cast list announces Hamlet's problem: he belongs to two kings. When the text says “Gertrude, queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet” (Dramatis Personae, speech (speech 0)), it shows this directly. He is "son to the late, and nephew to the present king," and Gertrude is "queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet," so loyalty to his father and to the court are already in conflict.

Task: Annotate the scene for characterization, setting (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about the court of Denmark? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Dramatis Personae develops the idea of the court of Denmark. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and setting shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)

Exemplar: The cast list announces Hamlet's problem: he belongs to two kings. When the text says “Gertrude, queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet” (Dramatis Personae, speech (speech 0)), it shows this directly. He is "son to the late, and nephew to the present king," and Gertrude is "queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet," so loyalty to his father and to the court are already in conflict.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)

Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.

Anchor question: If someone close to you remarried soon after a death in the family, how might you feel? Ask students to find the other sons in the list (Laertes, Fortinbras) and predict how they will mirror Hamlet.

Anchor question: If someone close to you remarried soon after a death in the family, how might you feel?

Facilitation: Ask students to find the other sons in the list (Laertes, Fortinbras) and predict how they will mirror Hamlet.

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)

Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).

Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about the court of Denmark? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: The cast list announces Hamlet's problem: he belongs to two kings. (“Gertrude, queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet”, Dramatis Personae, speech (speech 0)). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about the court of Denmark? Support it with one short quotation.

Answer: Model answer: The cast list announces Hamlet's problem: he belongs to two kings. (“Gertrude, queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet”, Dramatis Personae, speech (speech 0)). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

> **87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)**
> Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
> *Today we saw how characterization shapes the court of Denmark. Key takeaway: the court is full of courtiers, officers and spies.*

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Characterization:** Hamlet is "son to the late, and nephew to the present king": his whole conflict in one line.
- **Setting:** "Scene: Denmark": a single kingdom, a court, a castle.
- **Structure:** Foils in the cast: Laertes (son to Polonius) and Fortinbras (prince of Norway) are sons with fathers to avenge, like Hamlet.

Themes and how they develop

- **corruption and the state:** the court is full of courtiers, officers and spies.

Symbols and motifs

- **the Ghost:** listed last, after the attendants: the dead king haunts the bottom of the cast list and the top of the plot.

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “Hamlet, son to the late, and nephew to the present king” (Dramatis Personae, speech (speech 0)) Hamlet's divided position.
- “Gertrude, queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet” (Dramatis Personae, speech (speech 0)) Gertrude's two roles.
- “Fortinbras, prince of Norway” (Dramatis Personae, speech (speech 0)) Another prince who has lost a father.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: The cast list announces Hamlet's problem: he belongs to two kings.
Evidence: “Gertrude, queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet” (Dramatis Personae, speech (speech 0))
Reasoning: He is "son to the late, and nephew to the present king," and Gertrude is "queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet," so loyalty to his father and to the court are already in conflict.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history

messengers (noun)	people who carry messages	*Lords, ladies, officers, soldiers, sailors, messengers, and other attendants*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
attendants (noun)	servants who wait on a person of rank	*Lords, ladies, officers, soldiers, sailors, messengers, and other attendants*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
sailors (noun)	seamen	*Lords, ladies, officers, soldiers, sailors, messengers, and other attendants*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
foreknowing (noun)	knowing in advance	*If thou art privy to thy country's fate, Which, happily, foreknowing may avoid, O, speak!*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
harrows (verb)	distresses deeply; tears at	*Most like: it harrows me with fear and wonder.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
eruption (noun)	an outbreak of trouble	*In what particular thought to work I know not; But in the gross and scope of my opinion, This bodes some strange eruption to our state.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
combated (verb)	battle or contend against in or as if in a battle	*As thou art to thyself: Such was the very armour he had on When he the ambitious Norway combated; So frown'd he once, when, in an angry parle, He smote the sledded Polacks on the ice. 'Tis strange.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
invulnerable (adjective)	immune to attack; impregnable	*We do it wrong, being so majestical, To offer it the show of violence; For it is, as the air, invulnerable, And our vain blows malicious mockery.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. If someone close to you remarried soon after a death in the family, how might you feel?
2. Where does characterization appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with revenge and justice?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. Which characters are listed as courtiers? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Voltimand, Cornelius, Rosencrantz, Guildenstern, Osric and a gentleman.
2. Who is king of Denmark at the start? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Claudius
3. What is Hamlet's relation to the king? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Nephew
4. Whose children are Laertes and Ophelia? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Polonius's
5. Who is Fortinbras? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Prince of Norway
6. Where is the play set? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Denmark
7. Retell the three most important events of “Dramatis Personae” in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: The cast list centres on the Danish court at Elsinore: King Claudius; Queen Gertrude; Hamlet, 'son to the late, and nephew to the present king'; the lord chamberlain Polonius and his children Laertes and Ophelia; Hamlet's friend Horatio; courtiers including Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and Osric; officers and soldiers; players; two gravediggers; Fortinbras, prince of Norway; and the Ghost of…
8. Who is on stage in “Dramatis Personae”, and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does “Dramatis Personae” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: “Lords, ladies, officers, soldiers, sailors, messengers, and other attendants” What does “messengers” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: messengers: people who carry messages.

Inferential / analytical

1. Why might Shakespeare include two other sons who have lost fathers? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: As foils to compare responses to loss and revenge.
2. What does “Dramatis Personae” suggest about the court of Denmark? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: The list shows three sons with dead fathers (Hamlet, Laertes, Fortinbras) and a court thick with courtiers and spies, the structure on which the tragedy runs.
3. Find one example of characterization in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
4. How does the setting in this scene shape what we understand about the court of Denmark? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Look for where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The cast list announces Hamlet's problem: he belongs to two kings. Useful evidence: “Hamlet, son to the late, and nephew to the present king” (Dramatis Personae, speech (speech 0)): Hamlet's divided position. On setting: "Scene: Denmark": a single kingdom, a court, a castle. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. In the passage that begins “Claudius, king of Denmark”, why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in “Dramatis Personae”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: The cast list centres on the Danish court at Elsinore: King Claudius; Queen Gertrude; Hamlet, 'son to the late, and nephew to the present king'; the lord chamberlain Polonius and his children Laertes and Ophelia; Hamlet's friend Horatio; courtiers including Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and Osric;…
7. As the opening scene, what does “Dramatis Personae” set up that the rest of Hamlet will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The cast list announces Hamlet's problem: he belongs to two kings. Useful evidence: “Gertrude, queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet” (Dramatis Personae, speech (speech 0)): Gertrude's two roles. On structure: Foils in the cast: Laertes (son to Polonius) and Fortinbras (prince of Norway) are sons with fathers to avenge, like Hamlet. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The cast list announces Hamlet's problem: he belongs to two kings. Useful evidence: “Fortinbras, prince of Norway” (Dramatis Personae, speech (speech 0)): Another prince who has lost a father. On characterization: Hamlet is "son to the late, and nephew to the present king": his whole conflict in one line. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. The bell-ringer asked: “If someone close to you remarried soon after a death in the family, how might you feel?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does structure appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with revenge and justice? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: Look for how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The cast list announces Hamlet's problem: he belongs to two kings. Useful evidence: “Hamlet, son to the late, and nephew to the present king” (Dramatis Personae, speech (speech 0)): Hamlet's divided position. On structure: Foils in the cast: Laertes (son to Polonius) and Fortinbras (prince of Norway) are sons with fathers to avenge, like Hamlet. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. What does placing the Ghost at the end of the list suggest? [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A reasoned reading of its marginal but powerful position.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The cast list announces Hamlet's problem: he belongs to two kings. Useful evidence: “Gertrude, queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet” (Dramatis Personae, speech (speech 0)): Gertrude's two roles. Theme link: the court is full of courtiers, officers and spies. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

2. A critic might argue: “The list shows three sons with dead fathers (Hamlet, Laertes, Fortinbras) and a court thick with courtiers and spies, the structure on which the tragedy runs.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The cast list announces Hamlet's problem: he belongs to two kings. Useful evidence: “Fortinbras, prince of Norway” (Dramatis Personae, speech (speech 0)): Another prince who has lost a father. Theme link: the court is full of courtiers, officers and spies. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The cast list announces Hamlet's problem: he belongs to two kings. Useful evidence: “Hamlet, son to the late, and nephew to the present king” (Dramatis Personae, speech (speech 0)): Hamlet's divided position. On characterization: Hamlet is "son to the late, and nephew to the present king": his whole conflict in one line. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

4. You are directing “Dramatis Personae”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of the court of Denmark. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The cast list announces Hamlet's problem: he belongs to two kings. Useful evidence: “Gertrude, queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet” (Dramatis Personae, speech (speech 0)): Gertrude's two roles. On structure: Foils in the cast: Laertes (son to Polonius) and Fortinbras (prince of Norway) are sons with fathers to avenge, like Hamlet. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. Write three questions of your own about “Dramatis Personae”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The cast list announces Hamlet's problem: he belongs to two kings. Useful evidence: “Fortinbras, prince of Norway” (Dramatis Personae, speech (speech 0)): Another prince who has lost a father. Theme link: the court is full of courtiers, officers and spies. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Connect this scene to action and delay: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The cast list announces Hamlet's problem: he belongs to two kings. Useful evidence: “Hamlet, son to the late, and nephew to the present king” (Dramatis Personae, speech (speech 0)): Hamlet's divided position. Theme link: the court is full of courtiers, officers and spies. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Is the characterization in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The cast list announces Hamlet's problem: he belongs to two kings. Useful evidence: “Gertrude, queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet” (Dramatis Personae, speech (speech 0)): Gertrude's two roles. On characterization: Hamlet is "son to the late, and nephew to the present king": his whole conflict in one line. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. Compare how “Dramatis Personae” treats the court of Denmark with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The cast list announces Hamlet's problem: he belongs to two kings. Useful evidence: “Fortinbras, prince of Norway” (Dramatis Personae, speech (speech 0)): Another prince who has lost a father. Theme link: the court is full of courtiers, officers and spies. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. Predict what “Act I, Scene I” will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The cast list announces Hamlet's problem: he belongs to two kings. Useful evidence: “Hamlet, son to the late, and nephew to the present king” (Dramatis Personae, speech (speech 0)): Hamlet's divided position. Theme link: the court is full of courtiers, officers and spies. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about the court of Denmark? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The cast list announces Hamlet's problem: he belongs to two kings. Useful evidence: “Gertrude, queen of Denmark, and mother to Hamlet” (Dramatis Personae, speech (speech 0)): Gertrude's two roles. Theme link: the court is full of courtiers, officers and spies. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Characterization:** look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Setting**: where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling
- Also notice **Structure**: how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does

Chapter quiz

1. Who is king of Denmark at the start?
   A. Fortinbras
   B. Polonius
   C. Claudius
   D. Old Hamlet

2. What is Hamlet's relation to the king?
   A. Cousin
   B. Brother
   C. Son
   D. Nephew
3. Whose children are Laertes and Ophelia?
   A. Gertrude's
   B. Horatio's
   C. Claudius's
   D. Polonius's
4. Who is Fortinbras?
   A. Prince of Norway
   B. A Danish courtier
   C. A gravedigger
   D. An actor
5. Where is the play set?
   A. Poland
   B. Norway
   C. England
   D. Denmark
6. In the line “Lords, ladies, officers, soldiers, sailors, messengers, and other attendants”, what does “messengers” most nearly mean?
   A. servants who wait on a person of rank
   B. seamen
   C. knowing in advance
   D. people who carry messages
7. In the line “Lords, ladies, officers, soldiers, sailors, messengers, and other attendants”, what does “attendants” most nearly mean?
   A. people who carry messages
   B. seamen
   C. knowing in advance
   D. servants who wait on a person of rank

Answer key: 1. C (Claudius); 2. D (Nephew); 3. D (Polonius's); 4. A (Prince of Norway); 5. D (Denmark); 6. D (people who carry messages); 7. D (servants who wait on a person of rank)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.3, W.7.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this play is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Dramatis Personae,” how does Shakespeare show the court of Denmark? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes

two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the characterization you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In Dramatis Personae, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of the court of Denmark? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the characterization in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Dramatis Personae develops the idea of the court of Denmark. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and setting shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Dramatis Personae (where it begins, turns and ends) and its characterization shape the reader's understanding of the court of Denmark. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Dramatis Personae suggests about the court of Denmark. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's characterization and setting), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses characterization in Dramatis Personae to complicate the reader's understanding of the court of Denmark. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate Dramatis Personae within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of the court of Denmark responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read Dramatis Personae alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of the court of Denmark follows or bends those conventions, using the characterization as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Dramatis Personae and its treatment of the court of Denmark. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's characterization and setting, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads Dramatis Personae as evidence for a larger claim about the court of Denmark in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads Dramatis Personae as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of the court of Denmark. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *Lords, ladies, officers, soldiers, sailors, messengers, and other attendants*

   As used in the text, what does the word “sailors” most nearly mean?

   A. seamen

   B. battle or contend against in or as if in a battle

   C. an outbreak of trouble

   D. immune to attack; impregnable

2. *Claudius, king of Denmark*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “Dramatis Personae”?

   A. Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players

   B. The Ghost's revelation

   C. The court of Denmark

   D. Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia

SAT key: 1. A (seamen); 2. C (The court of Denmark)

Lesson 3: Act I, Scene I

Focus: the Ghost on the battlements

Teacher only · spoilers

At midnight on the battlements of Elsinore the sentries Bernardo and Marcellus show Horatio a ghost in the armour of the dead King Hamlet. It will not speak to him. Horatio explains Denmark's war preparations: young Fortinbras of Norway wants to recover lands his father lost to old Hamlet. The Ghost returns, vanishes at cockcrow, and they decide to tell young Hamlet.

Background: Elizabethans disagreed about ghosts: Catholics could believe in souls returning from purgatory; many Protestants held that apparitions were devils in disguise. Horatio, a scholar, is a sceptic.

Significance: The opening creates uncertainty and political menace, and makes the Ghost a sign of disorder in the state.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

> **0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)**
> Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
> *What makes a story's opening scene frightening? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to corruption and the state because....*
> **Prompt:** What makes a story's opening scene frightening?
> **Sentence starters:** I think… because… · This connects to corruption and the state because…
> **Strong response:** A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong.

> **8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)**
> Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
> *Today's words: foreknowing — knowing in advance; harrows — distresses deeply; tears at; eruption — an outbreak of trouble; combated — battle or contend against in or as if in a battle; invulnerable — immune to attack; impregnable.*
> **Words:** foreknowing: knowing in advance · harrows: distresses deeply; tears at · eruption: an outbreak of trouble · combated: battle or contend against in or as if in a battle · invulnerable: immune to attack; impregnable

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Elizabethans disagreed about ghosts: Catholics could believe in souls returning from purgatory; many Protestants held that apparitions were devils in disguise. Horatio, a scholar, is a sceptic. The opening creates uncertainty and political menace, and makes the Ghost a sign of disorder in the state. Setting: Midnight, cold, on the battlements: "'Tis bitter cold, / And I am sick at heart." Foreshadowing: The Ghost appears in armour; Horatio fears it bodes "some strange eruption to our state." Structure: The play opens with a question, "Who's there?", from the wrong man (the sentry on duty should ask). Watch for disease and rot: Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: "this relief much thanks: 'tis bitter cold, / And I am sick at heart" (Act I, Scene I, Francisco (speech 8)).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "Who's there" (Act I, Scene I, Bernardo (speech 1)). The first line: a play of questions. That is setting at work: Midnight, cold, on the battlements: "'Tis bitter cold, / And I am sick at heart."

> *Who's there* (Act I, Scene I, Bernardo (speech 1))

Think-aloud: I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "Who's there" (Act I, Scene I, Bernardo (speech 1)). The first line: a play of questions. That is setting at work: Midnight, cold, on the battlements: "'Tis bitter cold, / And I am sick at heart."

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Horatio thinks the Ghost is a warning of political trouble. Expected link: corruption and the state. Ask: How does this line connect to corruption and the state? Expected: Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong. (Horatio's reading of the Ghost.)

> *This bodes some strange eruption to our state* (Act I, Scene I, Horatio (speech 46))

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Horatio thinks the Ghost is a warning of political trouble. Expected link: corruption and the state.
Ask: How does this line connect to corruption and the state?
Expected answer: Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong. (Horatio's reading of the Ghost.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the scene for setting, foreshadowing (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about the Ghost on the battlements? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act I, Scene I develops the idea of the Ghost on the battlements. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of setting and foreshadowing shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. When the text says "This bodes some strange eruption to our state" (Act I, Scene I, Horatio (speech 46)), it shows this directly. The play begins "Who's there?" in the dark, a sentry says "I am sick at heart," and Horatio fears the Ghost "bodes some strange eruption to our state."
Task: Annotate the scene for setting, foreshadowing (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about the Ghost on the battlements? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act I, Scene I develops the idea of the Ghost on the battlements. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of setting and foreshadowing shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. When the text says "This bodes some strange eruption to our state" (Act I, Scene I, Horatio (speech 46)), it shows this directly. The play begins "Who's there?" in the dark, a sentry says "I am sick at heart," and Horatio fears the Ghost "bodes some strange eruption to our state."

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: What makes a story's opening scene frightening? Why begin with soldiers rather than kings?
Anchor question: What makes a story's opening scene frightening?
Facilitation: Why begin with soldiers rather than kings?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about the Ghost on the battlements? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. ("This bodes some strange eruption to our state", Act I, Scene I, Horatio (speech 46)). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about the Ghost on the battlements? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. ("This bodes some strange eruption to our state", Act I, Scene I, Horatio (speech 46)). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

> **87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)**
> Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
> *Today we saw how setting shapes the Ghost on the battlements. Key takeaway: Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong.*

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Setting:** Midnight, cold, on the battlements: "'Tis bitter cold, / And I am sick at heart."
- **Foreshadowing:** The Ghost appears in armour; Horatio fears it bodes "some strange eruption to our state."
- **Structure:** The play opens with a question, "Who's there?", from the wrong man (the sentry on duty should ask).

Themes and how they develop

- **corruption and the state:** Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong.

Symbols and motifs

- **disease and rot:** Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: “this relief much thanks: ’tis bitter cold, / And I am sick at heart” (Act I, Scene I, Francisco (speech 8)).
- **poison and ears:** Old Hamlet was poisoned through the ear; lies poured into ears, and poison returns at the end. In this scene: “Sit down awhile; / And let us once again assail your ears, / That are so fortified against our story / What we have two” (Act I, Scene I, Bernardo (speech 26)).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “Who’s there” (Act I, Scene I, Bernardo (speech 1)) The first line: a play of questions.
- “tis bitter cold, / And I am sick at heart” (Act I, Scene I, Francisco (speech 8)) Mood: cold and unease.
- “This bodes some strange eruption to our state” (Act I, Scene I, Horatio (speech 46)) Horatio's reading of the Ghost.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state.
Evidence: “This bodes some strange eruption to our state” (Act I, Scene I, Horatio (speech 46))
Reasoning: The play begins "Who's there?" in the dark, a sentry says "I am sick at heart," and Horatio fears the Ghost "bodes some strange eruption to our state."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
foreknowing (noun)	knowing in advance	*If thou art privy to thy country's fate, Which, happily, foreknowing may avoid, O, speak!*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
harrows (verb)	distresses deeply; tears at	*Most like: it harrows me with fear and wonder.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
eruption (noun)	an outbreak of trouble	*In what particular thought to work I know not; But in the gross and scope of my opinion, This bodes some strange eruption to our state.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
combated (verb)	battle or contend against in or as if in a battle	*As thou art to thyself: Such was the very armour he had on When he the ambitious Norway combated; So frown'd he once, when, in an angry parle, He smote the sledded Polacks on the ice. 'Tis strange.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
invulnerable (adjective)	immune to attack; impregnable	*We do it wrong, being so majestical, To offer it the show of violence; For it is, as the air, invulnerable, And our vain blows malicious mockery.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
partisan (noun)	a long-handled spear with a broad blade	*Shall I strike at it with my partisan?*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
martial (adjective)	military; warlike	*Thus twice before, and jump at this dead hour, With martial stalk hath he gone by our watch.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
needful (adjective)	necessary	*Do you consent we shall acquaint him with it, As needful in our loves, fitting our duty?*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. What makes a story's opening scene frightening?
2. Where does setting appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with action and delay?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What is the first line of the play? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: 'Who's there?'
2. Where does the scene take place? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: The battlements at Elsinore
3. Whom does the Ghost resemble? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: The dead King Hamlet
4. Who is the sceptic brought to see the Ghost? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Horatio
5. What does Fortinbras want? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: To recover lands his father lost
6. When does the Ghost vanish? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: At cockcrow
7. Retell the three most important events of "Act I, Scene I" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: At midnight on the battlements of Elsinore the sentries Bernardo and Marcellus show Horatio a ghost in the armour of the dead King Hamlet. It will not speak to him. Horatio explains Denmark's war preparations: young Fortinbras of Norway wants to recover lands his father lost to old Hamlet. The Ghost returns, vanishes at cockcrow, and they decide to tell young Hamlet.
8. Who is on stage in "Act I, Scene I", and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does "Act I, Scene I" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: "If thou art privy to thy country's fate, Which, happily, foreknowing may avoid, O, speak!" What does "foreknowing" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: foreknowing: knowing in advance.

Inferential / analytical

1. Why does Horatio think the Ghost appears? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: It bodes some strange eruption to the state.
2. What does "Act I, Scene I" suggest about the Ghost on the battlements? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: The opening creates uncertainty and political menace, and makes the Ghost a sign of disorder in the state.
3. Find one example of setting in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Look for where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling.
4. How does the foreshadowing in this scene shape what we understand about the Ghost on the battlements? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: Look for hints, warnings or images that point to later events.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. Useful evidence: "Who's there" (Act I, Scene I, Bernardo (speech 1)): The first line: a play of questions. On foreshadowing: The Ghost appears in armour; Horatio

fears it bodes "some strange eruption to our state." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. In the passage that begins “I’ll cross it, though it blast me.”, why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in “Act I, Scene I”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: At midnight on the battlements of Elsinore the sentries Bernardo and Marcellus show Horatio a ghost in the armour of the dead King Hamlet. It will not speak to him. Horatio explains Denmark's war preparations: young Fortinbras of Norway wants to recover lands his father lost to old Hamlet. The…
7. How does “Act I, Scene I” build on “Dramatis Personae”? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. Useful evidence: “tis bitter cold, / And I am sick at heart” (Act I, Scene I, Francisco (speech 8)): Mood: cold and unease. On structure: The play opens with a question, "Who's there?", from the wrong man (the sentry on duty should ask). Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. Useful evidence: “This bodes some strange eruption to our state” (Act I, Scene I, Horatio (speech 46)): Horatio's reading of the Ghost. Theme link: Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. The bell-ringer asked: “What makes a story's opening scene frightening?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does structure appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with action and delay? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: Look for how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. Useful evidence: “Who’s there” (Act I, Scene I, Bernardo (speech 1)): The first line: a play of questions. On structure: The play opens with a question, "Who's there?", from the wrong man (the sentry on duty should ask). Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Why open with guards rather than royalty? [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A judgment about atmosphere and perspective.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. Useful evidence: “tis bitter cold, / And I am sick at heart” (Act I, Scene I, Francisco (speech 8)): Mood: cold and unease. Theme link: Denmark prepares for war with

Norway; something is wrong. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

2. A critic might argue: “The opening creates uncertainty and political menace, and makes the Ghost a sign of disorder in the state.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. Useful evidence: “This bodes some strange eruption to our state” (Act I, Scene I, Horatio (speech 46)): Horatio's reading of the Ghost. Theme link: Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. Useful evidence: “Who’s there” (Act I, Scene I, Bernardo (speech 1)): The first line: a play of questions. Theme link: Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

4. You are directing “Act I, Scene I”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of the Ghost on the battlements. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. Useful evidence: “tis bitter cold, / And I am sick at heart” (Act I, Scene I, Francisco (speech 8)): Mood: cold and unease. On structure: The play opens with a question, "Who's there?", from the wrong man (the sentry on duty should ask). Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. Write three questions of your own about “Act I, Scene I”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. Useful evidence: “This bodes some strange eruption to our state” (Act I, Scene I, Horatio (speech 46)): Horatio's reading of the Ghost. Theme link: Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Connect this scene to appearance and reality: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. Useful evidence: “Who’s there” (Act I, Scene I, Bernardo (speech 1)): The first line: a play of questions. Theme link: Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Is the setting in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. Useful evidence: “tis bitter cold, / And I am sick at heart” (Act I, Scene I, Francisco (speech 8)): Mood: cold and unease. On setting: Midnight, cold, on the battlements: "'Tis bitter cold, / And I am sick at heart." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. Compare how “Act I, Scene I” treats the Ghost on the battlements with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. Useful evidence: “This bodes some strange eruption to our state” (Act I, Scene I, Horatio (speech 46)): Horatio's reading of the Ghost. Theme link: Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. Predict what “Act I, Scene II” will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. Useful evidence: “Who’s there” (Act I, Scene I, Bernardo (speech 1)): The first line: a play of questions. On foreshadowing: The Ghost appears in armour; Horatio fears it bodes "some strange eruption to our state." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about the Ghost on the battlements? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The opening scene establishes a mood of fear and uncertainty that spreads to the whole state. Useful evidence: “tis bitter cold, / And I am sick at heart” (Act I, Scene I, Francisco (speech 8)): Mood: cold and unease. Theme link: Denmark prepares for war with Norway; something is wrong. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Setting:** look for where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Foreshadowing**: hints, warnings or images that point to later events
- Also notice **Structure**: how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does

Chapter quiz

1. Where does the scene take place?
   A. A ship
   B. A graveyard

C. The battlements at Elsinore

D. The throne room

2. Whom does the Ghost resemble?

A. Fortinbras

B. Polonius

C. The dead King Hamlet

D. Claudius

3. Who is the sceptic brought to see the Ghost?

A. Laertes

B. Hamlet

C. Horatio

D. Osric

4. What does Fortinbras want?

A. To join Hamlet

B. To become king of England

C. To marry Ophelia

D. To recover lands his father lost

5. When does the Ghost vanish?

A. At cockcrow

B. When Hamlet arrives

C. At noon

D. At midnight

6. In the line "If thou art privy to thy country's fate, Which, happily, foreknowing may avoid, O, speak!", what does "foreknowing" most nearly mean?

A. an outbreak of trouble

B. distresses deeply; tears at

C. knowing in advance

D. battle or contend against in or as if in a battle

7. In the line "Most like: it harrows me with fear and wonder.", what does "harrows" most nearly mean?

A. an outbreak of trouble

B. battle or contend against in or as if in a battle

C. distresses deeply; tears at

D. knowing in advance

Answer key: 1. C (The battlements at Elsinore); 2. C (The dead King Hamlet); 3. C (Horatio); 4. D (To recover lands his father lost); 5. A (At cockcrow); 6. C (knowing in advance); 7. C (distresses deeply; tears at)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.3, W.7.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this play is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Act I, Scene I,” how does Shakespeare show the Ghost on the battlements? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the setting you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In Act I, Scene I, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of the Ghost on the battlements? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the setting in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act I, Scene I develops the idea of the Ghost on the battlements. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of setting and foreshadowing shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act I, Scene I (where it begins, turns and ends) and its setting shape the reader's understanding of the Ghost on the battlements. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act I, Scene I suggests about the Ghost on the battlements. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's setting and foreshadowing), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses setting in Act I, Scene I to complicate the reader's understanding of the Ghost on the battlements. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate Act I, Scene I within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of the Ghost on the battlements responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read Act I, Scene I alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of the Ghost on the battlements follows or bends those conventions, using the setting as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act I, Scene I and its treatment of the Ghost on the battlements. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's setting and foreshadowing, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads Act I, Scene I as evidence for a larger claim about the Ghost on the battlements in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads Act I, Scene I as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of the Ghost on the battlements. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *In what particular thought to work I know not; But in the gross and scope of my opinion, This bodes some strange eruption to our state.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “eruption” most nearly mean?

   A. an outbreak of trouble

   B. necessary

   C. military; warlike

   D. a long-handled spear with a broad blade

2. *I’ll cross it, though it blast me. Stay, illusion! If thou hast any sound, or use of voice, Speak to me: If there be any good thing to be done, That may to thee do ease and grace to me, Speak to me: Cock crows. If thou art privy to thy country’s fate, Which, happily, foreknowing may avoid, O, speak! Or if thou hast uphoarded in thy life Extorted treasure in the womb of earth, For which, they say, you spirits oft walk in death, Speak of it: stay, and speak! Stop it, Marcellus.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “Act I, Scene I”?

   A. 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene

   B. Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia

   C. The Ghost on the battlements

   D. Polonius spies on Laertes

SAT key: 1. A (an outbreak of trouble); 2. C (The Ghost on the battlements)

Lesson 4: Act I, Scene II

Focus: Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief

Content note (suicidal thoughts): Hamlet wishes his flesh would melt and regrets that God forbids 'self-slaughter.' Use the safe-messaging script; focus on grief and what Hamlet is reacting to.
Student preview: A grieving character wishes he could die. Support is available if this is hard to read.
Suggested language: "What has made Hamlet feel this way?"
Safe messaging: Discuss the character's despair and what the text does with it; do not dwell on methods. Before the lesson, remind students that support is available and how to reach the counselor. Check in privately with any student who seems affected and follow your school's referral protocol. **Share with students:** If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today. Let a counselor know in advance that this scene is being taught.

Teacher only · spoilers

Claudius addresses the court: he has married Gertrude, sends ambassadors to Norway, and lets Laertes return to France but asks Hamlet, still in black, not to go back to university at Wittenberg. Alone, Hamlet wishes he could die and condemns his mother's marriage within two months. Horatio and the guards tell him of the Ghost; he resolves to watch that night.

Background: Marrying a dead brother's widow was considered incest by the Church of England (Leviticus). Wittenberg was Luther's university.

Significance: The scene contrasts Claudius's public polish with Hamlet's private disgust and grief.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
How long should grief last? Who decides? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to appearance and reality because.... Content note before we start: A grieving character wishes he could die. Support is available if this is hard to read. If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today.
Prompt: How long should grief last? Who decides?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to appearance and reality because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'"

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: tenable — kept close; held secret; retrograde — contrary; opposed; yesternight — last night; methinks — it seems to me; tenders — offers (of love).
Words: tenable: kept close; held secret · retrograde: contrary; opposed · yesternight: last night · methinks: it seems to me · tenders: offers (of love)

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Marrying a dead brother's widow was considered incest by the Church of England (Leviticus). Wittenberg was Luther's university. The scene contrasts Claudius's public polish with Hamlet's private disgust and grief. Characterization: Claudius is a smooth politician; Hamlet is in mourning black and bitter. Diction / vocabulary: Hamlet's first line is a pun: "A little more than kin, and less than kind." Structure: First soliloquy: "O, that this too too solid flesh would melt." Watch for disease and rot: Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: "fie! 'tis an unweeded garden, / That grows to seed; things rank and gross in nature / Possess it merely. That it should come" (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 19)).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "A little more than kin, and less than kind" (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 8)). Hamlet's first words, a bitter pun. That is characterization at work: Claudius is a smooth politician; Hamlet is in mourning black and bitter.

> *A little more than kin, and less than kind* (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 8))

Think-aloud: I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "A little more than kin, and less than kind" (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 8)). Hamlet's first words, a bitter pun. That is characterization at work: Claudius is a smooth politician; Hamlet is in mourning black and bitter.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Appearance versus reality. Look at the craft: Hamlet's first line is a pun: "A little more than kin, and less than kind." Ask: How does this line connect to appearance and reality? Expected: "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'" (Appearance versus reality.)

> *Seems, madam! nay, it is; I know not "seems* (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 14))

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Appearance versus reality. Look at the craft: Hamlet's first line is a pun: "A little more than kin, and less than kind."
Ask: How does this line connect to appearance and reality?
Expected answer: "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'" (Appearance versus reality.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the scene for characterization, diction / vocabulary (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act I, Scene II develops the idea of Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and diction / vocabulary shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs. When the text says "O, that this too too solid flesh would melt" (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 19)), it shows this directly. He tells his mother "I know not 'seems,'" and alone wishes "this too too solid flesh would melt," condemning her: "Frailty, thy name is woman!"
Task: Annotate the scene for characterization, diction / vocabulary (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act I, Scene II develops the idea of Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and diction / vocabulary shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs. When the text says "O, that this too too solid flesh would melt" (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 19)), it shows this directly. He tells his mother "I know not 'seems,'" and alone wishes "this too too solid flesh would melt," condemning her: "Frailty, thy name is woman!"

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: How long should grief last? Who decides? Is Hamlet fair to Gertrude?
Anchor question: How long should grief last? Who decides?
Facilitation: Is Hamlet fair to Gertrude?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs. ("O, that this too too solid flesh would melt", Act I, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 19)). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs. ("O, that this too too solid flesh would melt", Act I, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 19)). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

> **87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)**
> Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
> *Today we saw how characterization shapes Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief. Key takeaway: "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'"*

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Characterization:** Claudius is a smooth politician; Hamlet is in mourning black and bitter.
- **Diction / vocabulary:** Hamlet's first line is a pun: "A little more than kin, and less than kind."
- **Structure:** First soliloquy: "O, that this too too solid flesh would melt."

Themes and how they develop

- **appearance and reality:** "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'"

Symbols and motifs

- **disease and rot:** Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: “fie! ’tis an unweeded garden, / That grows to seed; things rank and gross in nature / Possess it merely. That it should come” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 19)).
- **poison and ears:** Old Hamlet was poisoned through the ear; lies poured into ears, and poison returns at the end. In this scene: “hear your enemy say so, / Nor shall you do mine ear that violence, / To make it truster of your own report / Against” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 27)).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “A little more than kin, and less than kind” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 8)) Hamlet's first words, a bitter pun.
- “Seems, madam! nay, it is; I know not “seems” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 14)) Appearance versus reality.
- “O, that this too too solid flesh would melt” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 19)) First soliloquy.
- “Frailty, thy name is woman” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 19)) Hamlet on Gertrude.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs.
Evidence: “O, that this too too solid flesh would melt” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 19))
Reasoning: He tells his mother "I know not 'seems,'" and alone wishes "this too too solid flesh would melt," condemning her: "Frailty, thy name is woman!"

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word		In context	

	Definition (in this sentence)		Word history
tenable (adjective)	kept close; held secret	*I pray you all, If you have hitherto conceal'd this sight, Let it be tenable in your silence still; And whatsoever else shall hap to-night, Give it an understanding, but no tongue: I will requite your loves.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
retrograde (adjective)	contrary; opposed	*For your intent In going back to school in Wittenberg, It is most retrograde to our desire: And we beseech you, bend you to remain Here, in the cheer and comfort of our eye, Our chiefest courtier, cousin, and our son.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
yesternight (noun)	last night	*My lord, I think I saw him yesternight.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
methinks (verb)	it seems to me	*My father!—methinks I see my father.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
tenders (noun)	offers (of love)	*He hath, my lord, of late made many tenders Of his affection to me.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
primrose (adjective)	flowery and pleasant (the easy path)	*But, good my brother, Do not, as some ungracious pastors do, Show me the steep and thorny way to heaven; Whiles, like a puff'd and reckless libertine, Himself the primrose path of dalliance treads, And recks not his own rede.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
dalliance (noun)	idle, flirtatious play	*But, good my brother, Do not, as some ungracious pastors do, Show me the steep and thorny way to heaven; Whiles, like a puff'd and reckless libertine, Himself the primrose path of dalliance treads, And recks not his own rede.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
entertainment (noun)	an activity that is diverting and that holds the attention	*Those friends thou hast, and their adoption tried, Grapple them to thy soul with hoops of steel; But do not dull thy palm with entertainment Of each new-hatch'd, unfledged comrade.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. How long should grief last? Who decides?
2. Where does characterization appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with appearance and reality?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22,

23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What does Hamlet say about the funeral baked meats? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: They coldly furnished forth the marriage tables.
2. Whom has Claudius married? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Gertrude
3. Where does Hamlet want to go? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Wittenberg
4. Where is Laertes allowed to go? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: France
5. How long after the funeral was the marriage? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Less than two months
6. What does Hamlet wear? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Black mourning clothes
7. Retell the three most important events of "Act I, Scene II" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Claudius addresses the court: he has married Gertrude, sends ambassadors to Norway, and lets Laertes return to France but asks Hamlet, still in black, not to go back to university at Wittenberg. Alone, Hamlet wishes he could die and condemns his mother's marriage within two months. Horatio and the guards tell him of the Ghost; he resolves to watch that night.
8. Who is on stage in "Act I, Scene II", and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does "Act I, Scene II" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: "I pray you all, If you have hitherto conceal'd this sight, Let it be tenable in your silence still; And whatsoever else shall hap to-night, Give it an understanding, but no tongue: I will requite your loves." What does "tenable" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: tenable: kept close; held secret.

Inferential / analytical

1. How does Claudius try to win Hamlet over? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: He calls him his son and heir and urges him to stop mourning.
2. What does "Act I, Scene II" suggest about Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: The scene contrasts Claudius's public polish with Hamlet's private disgust and grief.
3. Find one example of characterization in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
4. How does the diction / vocabulary in this scene shape what we understand about Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: Look for precise or unusual word choices and their connotations.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs. Useful evidence: "A little more than kin, and less than kind" (Act I, Scene II,

Hamlet (speech 8)): Hamlet's first words, a bitter pun. On diction / vocabulary: Hamlet's first line is a pun: "A little more than kin, and less than kind." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. In the passage that begins “If it assume my noble father’s person, I’ll speak to it, though hell itself should gape And bid me hold my peace.”, why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in “Act I, Scene II”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Claudius addresses the court: he has married Gertrude, sends ambassadors to Norway, and lets Laertes return to France but asks Hamlet, still in black, not to go back to university at Wittenberg. Alone, Hamlet wishes he could die and condemns his mother's marriage within two months. Horatio and the…
7. How does “Act I, Scene II” build on “Act I, Scene I”? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs. Useful evidence: “Seems, madam! nay, it is; I know not “seems” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 14)): Appearance versus reality. On structure: First soliloquy: "O, that this too too solid flesh would melt." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs. Useful evidence: “O, that this too too solid flesh would melt” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 19)): First soliloquy. On characterization: Claudius is a smooth politician; Hamlet is in mourning black and bitter. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. The bell-ringer asked: “How long should grief last? Who decides?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does structure appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with appearance and reality? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: Look for how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs. Useful evidence: “Frailty, thy name is woman” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 19)): Hamlet on Gertrude. On structure: First soliloquy: "O, that this too too solid flesh would melt." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Is Hamlet's anger at Gertrude justified? Argue. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A reasoned view.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust

at a court that performs. Useful evidence: “A little more than kin, and less than kind” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 8)): Hamlet's first words, a bitter pun. Theme link: "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'" Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

2. A critic might argue: “The scene contrasts Claudius's public polish with Hamlet's private disgust and grief.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs. Useful evidence: “Seems, madam! nay, it is; I know not “seems” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 14)): Appearance versus reality. Theme link: "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'" Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs. Useful evidence: “O, that this too too solid flesh would melt” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 19)): First soliloquy. On characterization: Claudius is a smooth politician; Hamlet is in mourning black and bitter. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

4. You are directing “Act I, Scene II”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs. Useful evidence: “Frailty, thy name is woman” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 19)): Hamlet on Gertrude. On structure: First soliloquy: "O, that this too too solid flesh would melt." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. Write three questions of your own about “Act I, Scene II”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs. Useful evidence: “A little more than kin, and less than kind” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 8)): Hamlet's first words, a bitter pun. Theme link: "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'" Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Connect this scene to death and mortality: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs. Useful evidence: “Seems, madam! nay, it is; I know not “seems” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 14)): Appearance versus reality. Theme link: "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'" Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Is the characterization in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs. Useful evidence: “O, that this too too solid flesh would melt” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 19)): First soliloquy. On characterization: Claudius is a smooth politician; Hamlet is in mourning black and bitter. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. Compare how “Act I, Scene II” treats Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs. Useful evidence: “Frailty, thy name is woman” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 19)): Hamlet on Gertrude. Theme link: "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'" Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. Predict what “Act I, Scene III” will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs. Useful evidence: “A little more than kin, and less than kind” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 8)): Hamlet's first words, a bitter pun. Theme link: "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'" Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's first speeches show that his grief is also disgust at a court that performs. Useful evidence: “Seems, madam! nay, it is; I know not “seems” (Act I, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 14)): Appearance versus reality. Theme link: "Seems, madam! nay it is; I know not 'seems.'" Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Characterization:** look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Diction / vocabulary**: precise or unusual word choices and their connotations
- Also notice **Structure**: how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does

Chapter quiz

1. Whom has Claudius married?

   A. Ophelia

   B. A Norwegian princess

C. Gertrude

D. Hamlet's sister

2. Where does Hamlet want to go?

A. France

B. England

C. Norway

D. Wittenberg

3. Where is Laertes allowed to go?

A. Wittenberg

B. England

C. France

D. Poland

4. How long after the funeral was the marriage?

A. Five years

B. A year

C. Less than two months

D. A week

5. What does Hamlet wear?

A. Rags

B. Black mourning clothes

C. A crown

D. Armour

6. In the line "I pray you all, If you have hitherto conceal'd this sight, Let it be tenable in your silence still; And whatsoever else shall hap to-night, Give it an understanding, but no tongue: I will requite your loves.", what does "tenable" most nearly mean?

A. it seems to me

B. kept close; held secret

C. last night

D. contrary; opposed

7. In the line "For your intent In going back to school in Wittenberg, It is most retrograde to our desire: And we beseech you, bend you to remain Here, in the cheer and comfort of our eye, Our chiefest courtier, cousin, and our son.", what does "retrograde" most nearly mean?

A. contrary; opposed

B. it seems to me

C. kept close; held secret

D. last night

Answer key: 1. C (Gertrude); 2. D (Wittenberg); 3. C (France); 4. C (Less than two months); 5. B (Black mourning clothes); 6. B (kept close; held secret); 7. A (contrary; opposed)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.3, W.7.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this play is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Act I, Scene II,” how does Shakespeare show Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the characterization you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In Act I, Scene II, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the characterization in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act I, Scene II develops the idea of Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and diction / vocabulary shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act I, Scene II (where it begins, turns and ends) and its characterization shape the reader's understanding of Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act I, Scene II suggests about Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's characterization and diction / vocabulary), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses characterization in Act I, Scene II to complicate the reader's understanding of Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate Act I, Scene II within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read Act I, Scene II alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief follows or bends those conventions, using the characterization as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act I, Scene II and its treatment of Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's characterization and diction / vocabulary, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads Act I, Scene II as evidence for a larger claim about Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads Act I, Scene II as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *My lord, I think I saw him yesternight.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “yesternight” most nearly mean?

   A. an activity that is diverting and that holds the attention

   B. idle, flirtatious play

   C. flowery and pleasant (the easy path)

   D. last night

2. *If it assume my noble father’s person, I’ll speak to it, though hell itself should gape And bid me hold my peace. I pray you all, If you have hitherto conceal’d this sight, Let it be tenable in your silence still; And whatsoever else shall hap to-night, Give it an understanding, but no tongue: I will requite your loves. So, fare you well: Upon the platform, ’twixt eleven and twelve, I’ll visit you.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “Act I, Scene II”?

   A. Worms and kings

   B. Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief

   C. The closet scene

   D. The Ghost's revelation

SAT key: 1. D (last night); 2. B (Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief)

Lesson 5: Act I, Scene III

Focus: Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia

Teacher only · spoilers

Laertes, leaving for France, warns Ophelia that Hamlet cannot choose his own wife and that she must guard her honour. Polonius gives Laertes a set of precepts, then orders Ophelia to stop seeing Hamlet. She agrees to obey.

Background: Daughters were expected to obey fathers in matters of marriage; a prince's marriage was a matter of state.

Significance: The scene introduces Polonius's family as a foil to Hamlet's and shows Ophelia's lack of agency.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Should parents choose whom their children date? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to appearance and reality because....
Prompt: Should parents choose whom their children date?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to appearance and reality because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: tenders — offers (of love); primrose — flowery and pleasant (the easy path); dalliance — idle, flirtatious play; entertainment — an activity that is diverting and that holds the attention; reserve — a habit of keeping one's feelings to oneself.
Words: tenders: offers (of love) · primrose: flowery and pleasant (the easy path) · dalliance: idle, flirtatious play · entertainment: an activity that is diverting and that holds the attention · reserve: a habit of keeping one's feelings to oneself

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Daughters were expected to obey fathers in matters of marriage; a prince's marriage was a matter of state. The scene introduces Polonius's family as a foil to Hamlet's and shows Ophelia's lack of agency. Characterization: Polonius's advice to Laertes is a string of maxims. Conflict: Laertes and Polonius warn Ophelia against Hamlet. Irony: Polonius advises honesty while he will spy. Watch for disease and rot: Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: "proclaims the man, / And they in France of the best rank and station / Are of a most select and generous chief in" (Act I, Scene III, Polonius (speech 8)).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. “Neither a borrower nor a lender be” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius (speech 8)). Polonius's advice. That is characterization at work: Polonius's advice to Laertes is a string of maxims.

> *Neither a borrower nor a lender be* (Act I, Scene III, Polonius (speech 8))

Think-aloud: I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. “Neither a borrower nor a lender be” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius (speech 8)). Polonius's advice. That is characterization at work: Polonius's advice to Laertes is a string of maxims.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Famous maxim (this edition prints "ownself"). Look at the craft: Laertes and Polonius warn Ophelia against Hamlet. Ask: How does this line connect to appearance and reality? Expected: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows. (Famous maxim (this edition prints "ownself").)

> *This above all: to thine ownself be true* (Act I, Scene III, Polonius (speech 8))

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Famous maxim (this edition prints "ownself"). Look at the craft: Laertes and Polonius warn Ophelia against Hamlet.
Ask: How does this line connect to appearance and reality?
Expected answer: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows. (Famous maxim (this edition prints "ownself").)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the scene for characterization, conflict (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act I, Scene III develops the idea of Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and conflict shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. When the text says “This above all: to thine ownself be true” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius (speech 8)), it shows this directly. Polonius delivers maxims such as "to thine ownself be true," then orders Ophelia away from Hamlet, and she answers only "I shall obey, my lord."
Task: Annotate the scene for characterization, conflict (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act I, Scene III develops the idea of Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and conflict shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. When the text says “This above all: to thine ownself be true” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius (speech 8)), it shows this directly. Polonius delivers maxims such as "to thine ownself be true," then orders Ophelia away from Hamlet, and she answers only "I shall obey, my lord."

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: Should parents choose whom their children date? How much choice does Ophelia have?
Anchor question: Should parents choose whom their children date?
Facilitation: How much choice does Ophelia have?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. (“This above all: to thine ownself be true”, Act I, Scene III, Polonius (speech 8)). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. (“This above all: to thine ownself be true”, Act I, Scene III, Polonius (speech 8)). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how characterization shapes Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia. Key takeaway: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Characterization:** Polonius's advice to Laertes is a string of maxims.
- **Conflict:** Laertes and Polonius warn Ophelia against Hamlet.
- **Irony:** Polonius advises honesty while he will spy.

Themes and how they develop

- **appearance and reality:** Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows.

Symbols and motifs

- **disease and rot:** Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: “proclaims the man, / And they in France of the best rank and station / Are of a most select and generous chief in” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius (speech 8)).
- **poison and ears:** Old Hamlet was poisoned through the ear; lies poured into ears, and poison returns at the end. In this scene: “what loss your honour may sustain, / If with too credent ear you list his songs, / Or lose your heart, or your chaste” (Act I, Scene III, Laertes (speech 5)).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “Neither a borrower nor a lender be” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius (speech 8)) Polonius's advice.
- “This above all: to thine ownself be true” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius (speech 8)) Famous maxim (this edition prints "ownself").
- “I shall obey, my lord” (Act I, Scene III, Ophelia (speech 25)) Ophelia's obedience.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family.
Evidence: “This above all: to thine ownself be true” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius (speech 8))
Reasoning: Polonius delivers maxims such as "to thine ownself be true," then orders Ophelia away from Hamlet, and she answers only "I shall obey, my lord."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
tenders (noun)	offers (of love)	*He hath, my lord, of late made many tenders Of his affection to me.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
primrose (adjective)	flowery and pleasant (the easy path)	*But, good my brother, Do not, as some ungracious pastors do, Show me the steep and thorny way to heaven; Whiles, like a*	

		puff'd and reckless libertine, Himself the primrose path of dalliance treads, And recks not his own rede.	Student look-up (not yet verified)
dalliance (noun)	idle, flirtatious play	*But, good my brother, Do not, as some ungracious pastors do, Show me the steep and thorny way to heaven; Whiles, like a puff'd and reckless libertine, Himself the primrose path of dalliance treads, And recks not his own rede.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
entertainment (noun)	an activity that is diverting and that holds the attention	*Those friends thou hast, and their adoption tried, Grapple them to thy soul with hoops of steel; But do not dull thy palm with entertainment Of each new-hatch'd, unfledged comrade.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
reserve (noun)	a habit of keeping one's feelings to oneself	*Give every man thy ear, but few thy voice; Take each man's censure, but reserve thy judgment.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
hearsed (adjective)	placed in a coffin	*Let me not burst in ignorance; but tell Why thy canonized bones, hearsed in death, Have burst their cerements; why the sepulchre, Wherein we saw thee quietly inurn'd, Hath oped his ponderous and marble jaws, To cast thee up again.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
beckons (verb)	signals someone to come	*It beckons you to go away with it, As if it some impartment did desire To you alone.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
cerements (noun)	burial cloths	*Let me not burst in ignorance; but tell Why thy canonized bones, hearsed in death, Have burst their cerements; why the sepulchre, Wherein we saw thee quietly inurn'd, Hath oped his ponderous and marble jaws, To cast thee up again.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. Should parents choose whom their children date?
2. Where does characterization appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with death and mortality?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What does Polonius say about friends? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Grapple tried friends to your soul with hoops of steel.
2. Where is Laertes going? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: France

3. What does Laertes warn Ophelia about? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Hamlet's love
4. What does Polonius advise about money? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Neither borrow nor lend
5. What does Polonius order Ophelia to do? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Stop seeing Hamlet
6. How does Ophelia answer? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: I shall obey
7. Retell the three most important events of "Act I, Scene III" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Laertes, leaving for France, warns Ophelia that Hamlet cannot choose his own wife and that she must guard her honour. Polonius gives Laertes a set of precepts, then orders Ophelia to stop seeing Hamlet. She agrees to obey.
8. Who is on stage in "Act I, Scene III", and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does "Act I, Scene III" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: "He hath, my lord, of late made many tenders Of his affection to me." What does "tenders" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: tenders: offers (of love).

Inferential / analytical

1. What is ironic about Polonius's advice to be true to oneself? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: He is a manipulator and spy.
2. What does "Act I, Scene III" suggest about Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: The scene introduces Polonius's family as a foil to Hamlet's and shows Ophelia's lack of agency.
3. Find one example of characterization in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
4. How does the conflict in this scene shape what we understand about Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Look for the forces, people or desires pulling against each other.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. Useful evidence: "Neither a borrower nor a lender be" (Act I, Scene III, Polonius (speech 8)): Polonius's advice. On conflict: Laertes and Polonius warn Ophelia against Hamlet. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. In the passage that begins "I shall the effect of this good lesson keep, As watchman to my heart.", why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in "Act I, Scene III", and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Laertes, leaving for France, warns Ophelia that Hamlet cannot

choose his own wife and that she must guard her honour. Polonius gives Laertes a set of precepts, then orders Ophelia to stop seeing Hamlet. She agrees to obey.

7. How does “Act I, Scene III” build on “Act I, Scene II”? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. Useful evidence: “This above all: to thine ownself be true” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius (speech 8)): Famous maxim (this edition prints "ownself"). Theme link: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. Useful evidence: “I shall obey, my lord” (Act I, Scene III, Ophelia (speech 25)): Ophelia's obedience. On characterization: Polonius's advice to Laertes is a string of maxims. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. The bell-ringer asked: “Should parents choose whom their children date?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does irony appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with death and mortality? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.6] Look for: Look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. Useful evidence: “Neither a borrower nor a lender be” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius (speech 8)): Polonius's advice. On irony: Polonius advises honesty while he will spy. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Does Ophelia have any real choice? Evaluate. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A reasoned judgment.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. Useful evidence: “This above all: to thine ownself be true” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius (speech 8)): Famous maxim (this edition prints "ownself"). Theme link: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: “The scene introduces Polonius's family as a foil to Hamlet's and shows Ophelia's lack of agency.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. Useful evidence: “I shall obey, my lord” (Act I, Scene III, Ophelia (speech 25)): Ophelia's obedience. Theme link: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. Useful evidence: “Neither a borrower nor a lender be” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius (speech 8)): Polonius's advice. On characterization: Polonius's advice to Laertes is a string of maxims. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. You are directing “Act I, Scene III”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. Useful evidence: “This above all: to thine ownself be true” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius (speech 8)): Famous maxim (this edition prints "ownself"). Theme link: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. Write three questions of your own about “Act I, Scene III”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. Useful evidence: “I shall obey, my lord” (Act I, Scene III, Ophelia (speech 25)): Ophelia's obedience. Theme link: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
6. Connect this scene to corruption and the state: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. Useful evidence: “Neither a borrower nor a lender be” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius (speech 8)): Polonius's advice. Theme link: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. Is the characterization in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. Useful evidence: “This above all: to thine ownself be true” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius (speech 8)): Famous maxim (this edition prints "ownself"). On characterization: Polonius's advice to Laertes is a string of maxims. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. Compare how “Act I, Scene III” treats Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. Useful evidence: “I shall obey, my lord” (Act I, Scene III, Ophelia (speech 25)): Ophelia's obedience. Theme link: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Predict what “Act I, Scene IV” will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. Useful evidence: “Neither a borrower nor a lender be” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius (speech 8)): Polonius's advice. Theme link: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Ophelia is controlled by the men in her family. Useful evidence: “This above all: to thine ownself be true” (Act I, Scene III, Polonius (speech 8)): Famous maxim (this edition prints "ownself"). Theme link: Ophelia is told not to trust Hamlet's vows. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Characterization:** look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Conflict**: the forces, people or desires pulling against each other
- Also notice **Irony**: gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true

Chapter quiz

1. Where is Laertes going?
   A. England
   B. Norway
   C. France
   D. Wittenberg
2. What does Laertes warn Ophelia about?
   A. Claudius
   B. Polonius's anger
   C. The Ghost
   D. Hamlet's love
3. What does Polonius advise about money?
   A. Gamble wisely
   B. Save everything
   C. Neither borrow nor lend
   D. Spend freely
4. What does Polonius order Ophelia to do?
   A. Stop seeing Hamlet
   B. Marry Hamlet

C. Spy on Claudius

D. Go to France

5. How does Ophelia answer?

A. She runs away

B. She refuses

C. I shall obey

D. She laughs

6. In the line “He hath, my lord, of late made many tenders Of his affection to me.”, what does “tenders” most nearly mean?

A. flowery and pleasant (the easy path)

B. an activity that is diverting and that holds the attention

C. offers (of love)

D. idle, flirtatious play

7. In the line “But, good my brother, Do not, as some ungracious pastors do, Show me the steep and thorny way to heaven; Whiles, like a puff’d and reckless libertine, Himself the primrose path of dalliance treads, And recks not his own rede.”, what does “primrose” most nearly mean?

A. idle, flirtatious play

B. an activity that is diverting and that holds the attention

C. offers (of love)

D. flowery and pleasant (the easy path)

Answer key: 1. C (France); 2. D (Hamlet's love); 3. C (Neither borrow nor lend); 4. A (Stop seeing Hamlet); 5. C (I shall obey); 6. C (offers (of love)); 7. D (flowery and pleasant (the easy path))

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.3, W.7.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this play is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Act I, Scene III,” how does Shakespeare show Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the characterization you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In Act I, Scene III, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the characterization in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act I, Scene III develops the idea of Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and conflict shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act I, Scene III (where it begins, turns and ends) and its characterization shape the reader's understanding of Laertes

and Polonius advise Ophelia. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act I, Scene III suggests about Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's characterization and conflict), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses characterization in Act I, Scene III to complicate the reader's understanding of Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate Act I, Scene III within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read Act I, Scene III alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia follows or bends those conventions, using the characterization as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act I, Scene III and its treatment of Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's characterization and conflict, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads Act I, Scene III as evidence for a larger claim about Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads Act I, Scene III as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *But, good my brother, Do not, as some ungracious pastors do, Show me the steep and thorny way to heaven; Whiles, like a puff'd and reckless libertine, Himself the primrose path of dalliance treads, And recks not his own rede.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “dalliance” most nearly mean?

   A. placed in a coffin

B. idle, flirtatious play

C. signals someone to come

D. burial cloths

2. *I shall the effect of this good lesson keep, As watchman to my heart. But, good my brother, Do not, as some ungracious pastors do, Show me the steep and thorny way to heaven; Whiles, like a puff'd and reckless libertine, Himself the primrose path of dalliance treads, And recks not his own rede.*

Which choice best states a central concern of "Act I, Scene III"?

A. Worms and kings

B. Hamlet's letter from the sea

C. Hamlet hides the body

D. Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia

SAT key: 1. B (idle, flirtatious play); 2. D (Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia)

Lesson 6: Act I, Scene IV

Focus: Hamlet sees the Ghost

Teacher only · spoilers

On the battlements at midnight, as Claudius carouses below, Hamlet criticizes Danish drinking. The Ghost appears and beckons. Despite his friends' fears, Hamlet follows. Marcellus says something is rotten in Denmark.

Background: Danish drinking was proverbial in England.

Significance: The scene shows Hamlet's courage and the state's corruption.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
What would make you follow a ghost? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to corruption and the state because....
Prompt: What would make you follow a ghost?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to corruption and the state because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: hearsed — placed in a coffin; beckons — signals someone to come; cerements — burial cloths; wassail — drinking and revelry; ordnance — cannons.
Words: hearsed: placed in a coffin · beckons: signals someone to come · cerements: burial cloths · wassail: drinking and revelry · ordnance: cannons

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Danish drinking was proverbial in England. The scene shows Hamlet's courage and the state's corruption. Setting: The battlements at midnight; Claudius drinks below. Foreshadowing: Hamlet follows the Ghost against his friends' wishes. Diction / vocabulary: Marcellus: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark." Watch for disease and rot: Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: “Something is rotten in the state of Denmark” (Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus (speech 27)).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "The air bites shrewdly; it is very cold" (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 1)). Atmosphere. That is setting at work: The battlements at midnight; Claudius drinks below.

> *The air bites shrewdly; it is very cold* (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 1))

Think-aloud: I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "The air bites shrewdly; it is very cold" (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 1)). Atmosphere. That is setting at work: The battlements at midnight; Claudius drinks below.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Marcellus means something is corrupt in the country. Expected link: disease and rot. Ask: How does this line connect to corruption and the state? Expected: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation. (Corruption.)

> *Something is rotten in the state of Denmark* (Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus (speech 27))

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Marcellus means something is corrupt in the country. Expected link: disease and rot.
Ask: How does this line connect to corruption and the state?
Expected answer: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation. (Corruption.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the scene for setting, foreshadowing (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Hamlet sees the Ghost? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act I, Scene IV develops the idea of Hamlet sees the Ghost. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of setting and foreshadowing shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. When the text says "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark" (Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus (speech 27)), it shows this directly. Hamlet cries "Angels and ministers of grace defend us," and Marcellus concludes "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark."
Task: Annotate the scene for setting, foreshadowing (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Hamlet sees the Ghost? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act I, Scene IV develops the idea of Hamlet sees the Ghost. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of setting and foreshadowing shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. When the text says "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark" (Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus (speech 27)), it shows this directly. Hamlet cries "Angels and ministers of grace defend us," and Marcellus concludes "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark."

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: What would make you follow a ghost? Is the Ghost good or evil?
Anchor question: What would make you follow a ghost?
Facilitation: Is the Ghost good or evil?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Hamlet sees the Ghost? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. ("Something is rotten in the state of Denmark", Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus (speech 27)). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Hamlet sees the Ghost? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. ("Something is rotten in the state of Denmark", Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus (speech 27)). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how setting shapes Hamlet sees the Ghost. Key takeaway: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Setting:** The battlements at midnight; Claudius drinks below.
- **Foreshadowing:** Hamlet follows the Ghost against his friends' wishes.
- **Diction / vocabulary:** Marcellus: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark."

Themes and how they develop

- **corruption and the state:** Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation.

Symbols and motifs

- **disease and rot:** Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark" (Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus (speech 27)).
- **death and the grave:** skulls, worms and dust: what all bodies come to. In this scene: "in ignorance; but tell / Why thy canonized bones, hearsed in death, / Have burst their cerements; why the sepulchre, / Wherein we saw thee" (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 11)).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark" (Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus (speech 27)) Corruption.
- "The air bites shrewdly; it is very cold" (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 1)) Atmosphere.
- "Angels and ministers of grace defend us" (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 11)) Hamlet sees the Ghost.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state.
Evidence: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark" (Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus (speech 27))
Reasoning: Hamlet cries "Angels and ministers of grace defend us," and Marcellus concludes "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
hearsed (adjective)	placed in a coffin	*Let me not burst in ignorance; but tell Why thy canonized bones, hearsed in death, Have burst their cerements; why the sepulchre, Wherein we saw thee quietly inurn'd, Hath oped his ponderous and marble jaws, To cast thee up again.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
beckons (verb)	signals someone to come	*It beckons you to go away with it, As if it some impartment did desire To you alone.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
cerements (noun)	burial cloths	*Let me not burst in ignorance; but tell Why thy canonized bones, hearsed in death, Have burst their cerements; why the sepulchre, Wherein we saw thee quietly inurn'd, Hath oped his ponderous and marble jaws, To cast thee up again.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
wassail (noun)	drinking and revelry	*The king doth wake to-night and takes his rouse, Keeps wassail, and the swaggering up-spring reels; And, as he drains his draughts of Rhenish down, The kettle-drum and trumpet thus bray out The triumph of his pledge.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
ordnance (noun)	cannons	*A flourish of trumpets, and ordnance shot off, within.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
swaggering (adjective)	boisterous; reeling	*The king doth wake to-night and takes his rouse, Keeps wassail, and the swaggering up-spring reels; And, as he drains his draughts of Rhenish down, The kettle-drum and trumpet thus bray out The triumph of his pledge.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
drunkards (noun)	habitual drinkers	*This heavy-headed revel east and west Makes us traduced and tax'd of other nations: They clepe us drunkards, and with swinish phrase Soil our addition; and indeed it takes From our achievements, though perform'd at height, The pith and marrow of our attribute.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

draughts (noun)	doses of liquid medicine	*The king doth wake to-night and takes his rouse, Keeps wassail, and the swaggering up-spring reels; And, as he drains his draughts of Rhenish down, The kettle-drum and trumpet thus bray out The triumph of his pledge.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. What would make you follow a ghost?
2. Where does setting appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with corruption and the state?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What does Hamlet say about his life? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: He does not set it at a pin's fee.
2. What is Claudius doing below? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Drinking and revelling
3. What does the Ghost do? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Beckons Hamlet
4. What do Hamlet's friends fear? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: The Ghost may lead him to madness or death
5. Who says something is rotten in Denmark? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Marcellus
6. How cold is it? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Very cold
7. Retell the three most important events of "Act I, Scene IV" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: On the battlements at midnight, as Claudius carouses below, Hamlet criticizes Danish drinking. The Ghost appears and beckons. Despite his friends' fears, Hamlet follows. Marcellus says something is rotten in Denmark.
8. Who is on stage in "Act I, Scene IV", and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does "Act I, Scene IV" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: "Let me not burst in ignorance; but tell Why thy canonized bones, hearsed in death, Have burst their cerements; why the sepulchre, Wherein we saw thee quietly inurn'd, Hath oped his ponderous and marble jaws, To cast…" What does "hearsed" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: hearsed: placed in a coffin.

Inferential / analytical

1. Why does Hamlet criticize the drinking? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: It damages Denmark's reputation.
2. What does “Act I, Scene IV” suggest about Hamlet sees the Ghost? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: The scene shows Hamlet's courage and the state's corruption.
3. Find one example of setting in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Look for where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling.
4. How does the foreshadowing in this scene shape what we understand about Hamlet sees the Ghost? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: Look for hints, warnings or images that point to later events.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. Useful evidence: “Something is rotten in the state of Denmark” (Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus (speech 27)): Corruption. On foreshadowing: Hamlet follows the Ghost against his friends' wishes. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. In the passage that begins “Indeed?”, why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in “Act I, Scene IV”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: On the battlements at midnight, as Claudius carouses below, Hamlet criticizes Danish drinking. The Ghost appears and beckons. Despite his friends' fears, Hamlet follows. Marcellus says something is rotten in Denmark.
7. How does “Act I, Scene IV” build on “Act I, Scene III”? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. Useful evidence: “The air bites shrewdly; it is very cold” (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 1)): Atmosphere. Theme link: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. Useful evidence: “Angels and ministers of grace defend us” (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 11)): Hamlet sees the Ghost. Theme link: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. The bell-ringer asked: “What would make you follow a ghost?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.

10. Where does diction / vocabulary appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with corruption and the state? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: Look for precise or unusual word choices and their connotations.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. Useful evidence: “Something is rotten in the state of Denmark” (Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus (speech 27)): Corruption. On diction / vocabulary: Marcellus: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Is Hamlet brave or reckless? Argue. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A reasoned view.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. Useful evidence: “The air bites shrewdly; it is very cold” (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 1)): Atmosphere. Theme link: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: “The scene shows Hamlet's courage and the state's corruption.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. Useful evidence: “Angels and ministers of grace defend us” (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 11)): Hamlet sees the Ghost. Theme link: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. Useful evidence: “Something is rotten in the state of Denmark” (Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus (speech 27)): Corruption. Theme link: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. You are directing “Act I, Scene IV”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of Hamlet sees the Ghost. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. Useful evidence: “The air bites shrewdly; it is very cold” (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 1)): Atmosphere. Theme link: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. Write three questions of your own about “Act I, Scene IV”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. Useful evidence: “Angels and ministers of grace defend us” (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 11)): Hamlet sees the Ghost. Theme link: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Connect this scene to revenge and justice: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. Useful evidence: “Something is rotten in the state of Denmark” (Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus (speech 27)): Corruption. Theme link: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. Is the setting in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. Useful evidence: “The air bites shrewdly; it is very cold” (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 1)): Atmosphere. On setting: The battlements at midnight; Claudius drinks below. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. Compare how “Act I, Scene IV” treats Hamlet sees the Ghost with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. Useful evidence: “Angels and ministers of grace defend us” (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 11)): Hamlet sees the Ghost. Theme link: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. Predict what “Act I, Scene V” will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. Useful evidence: “Something is rotten in the state of Denmark” (Act I, Scene IV, Marcellus (speech 27)): Corruption. On foreshadowing: Hamlet follows the Ghost against his friends' wishes. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about Hamlet sees the Ghost? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The scene frames the Ghost as a sign of a sick state. Useful evidence: “The air bites shrewdly; it is very cold” (Act I, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 1)): Atmosphere. Theme link: Danish drinking gives the nation a bad reputation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Setting:** look for where and when events happen and how place shapes action or feeling (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Foreshadowing**: hints, warnings or images that point to later events
- Also notice **Diction / vocabulary**: precise or unusual word choices and their connotations

Chapter quiz

1. What is Claudius doing below?
   A. Praying
   B. Drinking and revelling
   C. Holding council
   D. Sleeping
2. What does the Ghost do?
   A. Vanishes immediately
   B. Speaks to Horatio
   C. Attacks Marcellus
   D. Beckons Hamlet
3. What do Hamlet's friends fear?
   A. Claudius will see
   B. Nothing
   C. It is a trick
   D. The Ghost may lead him to madness or death
4. Who says something is rotten in Denmark?
   A. Bernardo
   B. Hamlet
   C. Horatio
   D. Marcellus
5. How cold is it?
   A. Mild
   B. Very cold
   C. Hot
   D. Warm
6. In the line “Let me not burst in ignorance; but tell Why thy canonized bones, hearsed in death, Have burst their cerements; why the sepulchre, Wherein we saw thee quietly inurn’d, Hath oped his ponderous and marble jaws, To cast thee up again.”, what does “hearsed” most nearly mean?
   A. burial cloths
   B. signals someone to come
   C. drinking and revelry
   D. placed in a coffin
7. In the line “It beckons you to go away with it, As if it some impartment did desire To you alone.”, what does “beckons” most nearly mean?
   A. signals someone to come
   B. placed in a coffin
   C. drinking and revelry
   D. burial cloths

Answer key: 1. B (Drinking and revelling); 2. D (Beckons Hamlet); 3. D (The Ghost may lead him to madness or death); 4. D (Marcellus); 5. B (Very cold); 6. D (placed in a coffin); 7. A (signals someone to come)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.3, W.7.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this play is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In "Act I, Scene IV," how does Shakespeare show Hamlet sees the Ghost? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the setting you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In Act I, Scene IV, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of Hamlet sees the Ghost? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the setting in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act I, Scene IV develops the idea of Hamlet sees the Ghost. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of setting and foreshadowing shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act I, Scene IV (where it begins, turns and ends) and its setting shape the reader's understanding of Hamlet sees the Ghost. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act I, Scene IV suggests about Hamlet sees the Ghost. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's setting and foreshadowing), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses setting in Act I, Scene IV to complicate the reader's understanding of Hamlet sees the Ghost. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate Act I, Scene IV within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of Hamlet sees the Ghost responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read Act I, Scene IV alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of Hamlet sees the Ghost follows or bends those conventions, using the setting as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act I, Scene IV and its treatment of Hamlet sees the Ghost. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's setting and foreshadowing, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads Act I, Scene IV as evidence for a larger claim about Hamlet sees the Ghost in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads Act I, Scene IV as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of Hamlet sees the Ghost. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *Let me not burst in ignorance; but tell Why thy canonized bones, hearsed in death, Have burst their cerements; why the sepulchre, Wherein we saw thee quietly inurn'd, Hath oped his ponderous and marble jaws, To cast thee up again.*

   As used in the text, what does the word "cerements" most nearly mean?

   A. doses of liquid medicine

   B. boisterous; reeling

   C. burial cloths

   D. habitual drinkers

2. *Indeed? I heard it not: then it draws near the season Wherein the spirit held his wont to walk. A flourish of trumpets, and ordnance shot off, within. What does this mean, my lord?*

   Which choice best states a central concern of "Act I, Scene IV"?

   A. Hamlet sees the Ghost

   B. Hamlet's letter from the sea

   C. The duel and the deaths

   D. Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return

SAT key: 1. C (burial cloths); 2. A (Hamlet sees the Ghost)

Lesson 7: Act I, Scene V

Focus: the Ghost's revelation

Teacher only · spoilers

The Ghost says he is Hamlet's father, doomed to walk at night, and that Claudius murdered him by pouring poison into his ear as he slept in his orchard, then seduced Gertrude. He commands revenge but tells Hamlet to leave Gertrude to heaven. Hamlet swears to remember, makes his friends swear secrecy, and warns he may put on an antic disposition.

Background: Dying without last rites ('unhousel'd, disappointed, unanel'd') meant facing judgment unprepared.

Significance: The command of revenge launches the plot.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Is it right to take revenge for someone you love? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to revenge and justice because....
Prompt: Is it right to take revenge for someone you love?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to revenge and justice because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: Hamlet swears to remember.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: traitorous — treacherous; howsoever — in whatever way; ambiguous — open to more than one meaning; methinks — it seems to me; windlasses — roundabout methods.
Words: traitorous: treacherous · howsoever: in whatever way · ambiguous: open to more than one meaning · methinks: it seems to me · windlasses: roundabout methods

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Dying without last rites ('unhousel'd, disappointed, unanel'd') meant facing judgment unprepared. The command of revenge launches the plot. Characterization: The Ghost reveals the murder: poison poured in the ear. Diction / vocabulary: "Remember me." Plot: Hamlet decides to "put an antic disposition on." Watch for poison and ears: Old Hamlet was poisoned through the ear; lies poured into ears, and poison returns at the end. In this scene: “fretful porpentine: / But this eternal blazon must not be / To ears of flesh and blood. List, list, O, list! / If thou didst” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost (speech 10)).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder" (Act I, Scene V, Ghost (speech 12)). The Ghost's command. That is characterization at work: The Ghost reveals the murder: poison poured in the ear.

> *Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder* *(Act I, Scene V, Ghost (speech 12))*

Think-aloud: I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder" (Act I, Scene V, Ghost (speech 12)). The Ghost's command. That is characterization at work: The Ghost reveals the murder: poison poured in the ear.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Hamlet wishes he had not been born to fix this. Expected link: action and delay. Ask: How does this line connect to revenge and justice? Expected: Hamlet swears to remember. (The Ghost's farewell.)

> *Adieu, adieu! Hamlet, remember me* *(Act I, Scene V, Ghost (speech 18))*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Hamlet wishes he had not been born to fix this. Expected link: action and delay.
Ask: How does this line connect to revenge and justice?
Expected answer: Hamlet swears to remember. (The Ghost's farewell.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the scene for characterization, diction / vocabulary (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about the Ghost's revelation? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act I, Scene V develops the idea of the Ghost's revelation. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and diction / vocabulary shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. When the text says "Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder" (Act I, Scene V, Ghost (speech 12)), it shows this directly. The Ghost demands "Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder," and Hamlet ends with "The time is out of joint: O cursed spite, / That ever I was born to set it right!"
Task: Annotate the scene for characterization, diction / vocabulary (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about the Ghost's revelation? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act I, Scene V develops the idea of the Ghost's revelation. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and diction / vocabulary shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. When the text says "Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder" (Act I, Scene V, Ghost (speech 12)), it shows this directly. The Ghost demands "Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder," and Hamlet ends with "The time is out of joint: O cursed spite, / That ever I was born to set it right!"

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: Is it right to take revenge for someone you love? Why does Hamlet feign madness?
Anchor question: Is it right to take revenge for someone you love?
Facilitation: Why does Hamlet feign madness?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about the Ghost's revelation? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. ("Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder", Act I, Scene V, Ghost (speech 12)). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about the Ghost's revelation? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. ("Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder", Act I, Scene V, Ghost (speech 12)). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how characterization shapes the Ghost's revelation. Key takeaway: Hamlet swears to remember.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Characterization:** The Ghost reveals the murder: poison poured in the ear.
- **Diction / vocabulary:** "Remember me."
- **Plot:** Hamlet decides to "put an antic disposition on."

Themes and how they develop

- **revenge and justice:** Hamlet swears to remember.

Symbols and motifs

- **poison and ears:** Old Hamlet was poisoned through the ear; lies poured into ears, and poison returns at the end. In this scene: “fretful porpentine: / But this eternal blazon must not be / To ears of flesh and blood. List, list, O, list! / If thou didst” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost (speech 10)).
- **acting and seeming:** "Seems, madam! nay it is": performance, the players, feigned madness and the Mousetrap. In this scene: “for luxury and damned incest. / But, howsoever thou pursuest this act, / Taint not thy mind, nor let thy soul contrive / Against thy” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost (speech 18)).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost (speech 12)) The Ghost's command.
- “Adieu, adieu! Hamlet, remember me” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost (speech 18)) The Ghost's farewell.
- “The time is out of joint: O cursed spite, / That ever I was born to set it right” (Act I, Scene V, Hamlet (speech 62)) Hamlet's reluctance.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it.
Evidence: “Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost (speech 12))
Reasoning: The Ghost demands "Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder," and Hamlet ends with "The time is out of joint: O cursed spite, / That ever I was born to set it right!"

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
traitorous (adjective)	treacherous	*Ay, that incestuous, that adulterate beast, With witchcraft of his wit, with traitorous gifts— O wicked wit and gifts, that have the power So to seduce!—won to his shameful lust The will of my most seeming-virtuous queen: O Hamlet, what a falling-off was there!*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
	in whatever way		

howsoever (adverb)		*But, howsoever thou pursuest this act, Taint not thy mind, nor let thy soul contrive Against thy mother aught: leave her to heaven And to those thorns that in her bosom lodge, To prick and sting her.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
ambiguous (adjective)	open to more than one meaning	*Or such ambiguous giving out, to note That you know aught of me: this not to do, So grace and mercy at your most need help you, Swear.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
methinks (verb)	it seems to me	*But, soft! methinks I scent the morning air; Brief let me be.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
windlasses (noun)	roundabout methods	*See you now; Your bait of falsehood takes this carp of truth: And thus do we of wisdom and of reach, With windlasses and with assays of bias, By indirections find directions out: So by my former lecture and advice, Shall you my son.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
indirections (noun)	indirect means	*See you now; Your bait of falsehood takes this carp of truth: And thus do we of wisdom and of reach, With windlasses and with assays of bias, By indirections find directions out: So by my former lecture and advice, Shall you my son.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
brothel (noun)	a house of prostitution	*Videlicet, a brothel, or so forth.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
fencing (noun)	sword-fighting for sport	*Ay, or drinking, fencing, swearing, quarrelling, Drabbing: you may go so far.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. Is it right to take revenge for someone you love?
2. Where does characterization appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with revenge and justice?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What does the Ghost say Claudius told people? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: That a serpent stung him in his orchard.
2. How was Old Hamlet killed? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Poison in the ear

3. Who killed him? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Claudius
4. What must Hamlet not do? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Harm his mother
5. What does the Ghost ask Hamlet to do? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Remember him and take revenge
6. What does Hamlet say he may put on? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: An antic disposition
7. Retell the three most important events of "Act I, Scene V" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: The Ghost says he is Hamlet's father, doomed to walk at night, and that Claudius murdered him by pouring poison into his ear as he slept in his orchard, then seduced Gertrude. He commands revenge but tells Hamlet to leave Gertrude to heaven. Hamlet swears to remember, makes his friends swear secrecy, and warns he may put on an antic disposition.
8. Who is on stage in "Act I, Scene V", and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does "Act I, Scene V" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: "Ay, that incestuous, that adulterate beast, With witchcraft of his wit, with traitorous gifts— O wicked wit and gifts, that have the power So to seduce!—won to his shameful lust The will of my most seeming-virtuous…" What does "traitorous" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: traitorous: treacherous.

Inferential / analytical

1. Why does Hamlet make his friends swear? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: To keep secret what they saw and his plan.
2. What does "Act I, Scene V" suggest about the Ghost's revelation? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: The command of revenge launches the plot.
3. Find one example of characterization in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
4. How does the diction / vocabulary in this scene shape what we understand about the Ghost's revelation? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: Look for precise or unusual word choices and their connotations.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. Useful evidence: "Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder" (Act I, Scene V, Ghost (speech 12)): The Ghost's command. On diction / vocabulary: "Remember me." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. In the passage that begins "And therefore as a stranger give it welcome.", why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in "Act I, Scene V", and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: The Ghost says he is Hamlet's father, doomed to walk at night, and

that Claudius murdered him by pouring poison into his ear as he slept in his orchard, then seduced Gertrude. He commands revenge but tells Hamlet to leave Gertrude to heaven. Hamlet swears to remember, makes his friends swear…

7. How does “Act I, Scene V” build on “Act I, Scene IV”? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. Useful evidence: “Adieu, adieu! Hamlet, remember me” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost (speech 18)): The Ghost's farewell. Theme link: Hamlet swears to remember. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. Useful evidence: “The time is out of joint: O cursed spite, / That ever I was born to set it right” (Act I, Scene V, Hamlet (speech 62)): Hamlet's reluctance. On characterization: The Ghost reveals the murder: poison poured in the ear. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. The bell-ringer asked: “Is it right to take revenge for someone you love?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does plot appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with revenge and justice? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Look for key events and the causes linking them.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. Useful evidence: “Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost (speech 12)): The Ghost's command. On plot: Hamlet decides to "put an antic disposition on." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Should Hamlet trust the Ghost? Argue. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A reasoned position.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. Useful evidence: “Adieu, adieu! Hamlet, remember me” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost (speech 18)): The Ghost's farewell. Theme link: Hamlet swears to remember. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: “The command of revenge launches the plot.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. Useful evidence: “The time is out of joint: O cursed spite, / That ever I was born to set it right” (Act I, Scene V, Hamlet (speech 62)): Hamlet's reluctance. Theme link: Hamlet swears to remember. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. Useful evidence: “Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost (speech 12)): The Ghost's command. On characterization: The Ghost reveals the murder: poison poured in the ear. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

4. You are directing “Act I, Scene V”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of the Ghost's revelation. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. Useful evidence: “Adieu, adieu! Hamlet, remember me” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost (speech 18)): The Ghost's farewell. Theme link: Hamlet swears to remember. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. Write three questions of your own about “Act I, Scene V”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. Useful evidence: “The time is out of joint: O cursed spite, / That ever I was born to set it right” (Act I, Scene V, Hamlet (speech 62)): Hamlet's reluctance. Theme link: Hamlet swears to remember. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Connect this scene to action and delay: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. Useful evidence: “Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost (speech 12)): The Ghost's command. Theme link: Hamlet swears to remember. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Is the characterization in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. Useful evidence: “Adieu, adieu! Hamlet, remember me” (Act I, Scene V, Ghost (speech 18)): The Ghost's farewell. On characterization: The Ghost reveals the murder: poison poured in the ear. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. Compare how “Act I, Scene V” treats the Ghost's revelation with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. Useful evidence: “The time is out of joint: O cursed spite, / That ever I was born to set it right” (Act I, Scene V, Hamlet (speech 62)): Hamlet's reluctance. Theme link: Hamlet swears to remember. Credit any

position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Predict what "Act II, Scene I" will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. Useful evidence: "Revenge his foul and most unnatural murder" (Act I, Scene V, Ghost (speech 12)): The Ghost's command. Theme link: Hamlet swears to remember. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about the Ghost's revelation? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet accepts the duty of revenge but feels burdened by it. Useful evidence: "Adieu, adieu! Hamlet, remember me" (Act I, Scene V, Ghost (speech 18)): The Ghost's farewell. Theme link: Hamlet swears to remember. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Characterization:** look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Diction / vocabulary**: precise or unusual word choices and their connotations
- Also notice **Plot**: key events and the causes linking them

Chapter quiz

1. How was Old Hamlet killed?
   A. Poison in the ear
   B. In battle
   C. Stabbed
   D. Drowned
2. Who killed him?
   A. Fortinbras
   B. Polonius
   C. Gertrude
   D. Claudius
3. What must Hamlet not do?
   A. Harm his mother
   B. Leave Denmark
   C. Tell Horatio
   D. Pray
4. What does the Ghost ask Hamlet to do?
   A. Leave Denmark

B. Remember him and take revenge

C. Marry Ophelia

D. Pray for him

5. What does Hamlet say he may put on?

A. Armour

B. A disguise as a priest

C. An antic disposition

D. A crown

6. In the line "Ay, that incestuous, that adulterate beast, With witchcraft of his wit, with traitorous gifts— O wicked wit and gifts, that have the power So to seduce!—won to his shameful lust The will of my most seeming-virtuous queen: O Hamlet, what a falling-off was there!", what does "traitorous" most nearly mean?

A. treacherous

B. it seems to me

C. open to more than one meaning

D. in whatever way

7. In the line "But, howsoever thou pursuest this act, Taint not thy mind, nor let thy soul contrive Against thy mother aught: leave her to heaven And to those thorns that in her bosom lodge, To prick and sting her.", what does "howsoever" most nearly mean?

A. in whatever way

B. it seems to me

C. open to more than one meaning

D. treacherous

Answer key: 1. A (Poison in the ear); 2. D (Claudius); 3. A (Harm his mother); 4. B (Remember him and take revenge); 5. C (An antic disposition); 6. A (treacherous); 7. A (in whatever way)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.3, W.7.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this play is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In "Act I, Scene V," how does Shakespeare show the Ghost's revelation? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the characterization you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In Act I, Scene V, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of the Ghost's revelation? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the characterization in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act I, Scene V develops the idea of the Ghost's revelation. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and diction / vocabulary shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act I, Scene V (where it begins, turns and ends) and its characterization shape the reader's understanding of the Ghost's revelation. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act I, Scene V suggests about the Ghost's revelation. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's characterization and diction / vocabulary), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses characterization in Act I, Scene V to complicate the reader's understanding of the Ghost's revelation. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate Act I, Scene V within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of the Ghost's revelation responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read Act I, Scene V alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of the Ghost's revelation follows or bends those conventions, using the characterization as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act I, Scene V and its treatment of the Ghost's revelation. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's characterization and diction / vocabulary, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads Act I, Scene V as evidence for a larger claim about the Ghost's revelation in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads Act I, Scene V as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of the Ghost's revelation. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *Or such ambiguous giving out, to note That you know aught of me: this not to do, So grace and mercy at your most need help you, Swear.*

As used in the text, what does the word "ambiguous" most nearly mean?

A. a house of prostitution

B. sword-fighting for sport

C. indirect means

D. open to more than one meaning

2. *And therefore as a stranger give it welcome. There are more things in heaven and earth, Horatio, Than are dreamt of in your philosophy. But come; Here, as before, never, so help you mercy, How strange or odd soe'er I bear myself, As I perchance hereafter shall think meet To put an antic disposition on, That you, at such times seeing me, never shall, With arms encumber'd thus, or this headshake, Or by pronouncing of some doubtful phrase, As "Well, well, we know," or "We could, an if we would," Or "If we list to speak," or "There be, an if they might," Or such ambiguous giving out, to note That you know aught of me: this not to do, So grace and mercy at your most need help you, Swear.*

Which choice best states a central concern of "Act I, Scene V"?

A. The Ghost's revelation

B. Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief

C. The plot against Hamlet

D. The court of Denmark

SAT key: 1. D (open to more than one meaning); 2. A (The Ghost's revelation)

Lesson 8: Act II, Scene I

Focus: Polonius spies on Laertes

Teacher only · spoilers

Polonius sends Reynaldo to Paris to spy on Laertes by spreading small slanders. Ophelia enters frightened: Hamlet came to her closet dishevelled, stared, sighed and left. Polonius concludes Hamlet is mad for love and goes to tell the king.

Background: Spying and informers were part of Elizabethan court life.

Significance: Polonius's methods show a court of surveillance.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Is it ever right to spy on family? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to appearance and reality because....
Prompt: Is it ever right to spy on family?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to appearance and reality because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: indirection.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: windlasses — roundabout methods; indirections — indirect means; brothel — a house of prostitution; fencing — sword-fighting for sport; affrighted — frightened.
Words: windlasses: roundabout methods · indirections: indirect means · brothel: a house of prostitution · fencing: sword-fighting for sport · affrighted: frightened

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Spying and informers were part of Elizabethan court life. Polonius's methods show a court of surveillance. Characterization: Polonius sends Reynaldo to spy on Laertes. Irony: Polonius uses lies to find truth. Plot: Ophelia reports Hamlet's strange visit. Watch for disease and rot: Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: "put on him / What forgeries you please; marry, none so rank / As may dishonour him; take heed of that; / But, sir, such" (Act II, Scene I, Polonius (speech 7)).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "O, my lord, my lord, I have been so affrighted" (Act II, Scene I, Ophelia (speech 28)). Ophelia's fear. That is characterization at work: Polonius sends Reynaldo to spy on Laertes.

> *O, my lord, my lord, I have been so affrighted* (Act II, Scene I, Ophelia (speech 28))

Think-aloud: I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "O, my lord, my lord, I have been so affrighted" (Act II, Scene I, Ophelia (speech 28)). Ophelia's fear. That is characterization at work: Polonius sends Reynaldo to spy on Laertes.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: He means use indirect methods to find out facts. Expected link: spying and watching. Ask: How does this line connect to appearance and reality? Expected: Indirection. (Polonius's method.)

> *By indirections find directions out* (Act II, Scene I, Polonius (speech 19))

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: He means use indirect methods to find out facts. Expected link: spying and watching.
Ask: How does this line connect to appearance and reality?
Expected answer: Indirection. (Polonius's method.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the scene for characterization, irony (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Polonius spies on Laertes? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act II, Scene I develops the idea of Polonius spies on Laertes. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and irony shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception. When the text says "By indirections find directions out" (Act II, Scene I, Polonius (speech 19)), it shows this directly. He tells Reynaldo to "By indirections find directions out," and after Ophelia's report decides "This is the very ecstasy of love."
Task: Annotate the scene for characterization, irony (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Polonius spies on Laertes? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act II, Scene I develops the idea of Polonius spies on Laertes. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and irony shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception. When the text says "By indirections find directions out" (Act II, Scene I, Polonius (speech 19)), it shows this directly. He tells Reynaldo to "By indirections find directions out," and after Ophelia's report decides "This is the very ecstasy of love."

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: Is it ever right to spy on family? Is Polonius wise or foolish?
Anchor question: Is it ever right to spy on family?
Facilitation: Is Polonius wise or foolish?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Polonius spies on Laertes? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception. ("By indirections find directions out", Act II, Scene I, Polonius (speech 19)). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Polonius spies on Laertes? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception. ("By indirections find directions out", Act II, Scene I, Polonius (speech 19)). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how characterization shapes Polonius spies on Laertes. Key takeaway: indirection.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Characterization:** Polonius sends Reynaldo to spy on Laertes.
- **Irony:** Polonius uses lies to find truth.
- **Plot:** Ophelia reports Hamlet's strange visit.

Themes and how they develop

- **appearance and reality:** indirection.

Symbols and motifs

- **disease and rot:** Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: "put on him / What forgeries you please; marry, none so rank / As may dishonour him; take heed of that; / But, sir, such" (Act II, Scene I, Polonius (speech 7)).
- **acting and seeming:** "Seems, madam! nay it is": performance, the players, feigned madness and the Mousetrap. In this scene: "meaning: but breathe his faults so quaintly / That they may seem the taints of liberty, / The flash and outbreak of a fiery" (Act II, Scene I, Polonius (speech 11)).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- "By indirections find directions out" (Act II, Scene I, Polonius (speech 19)) Polonius's method.
- "O, my lord, my lord, I have been so affrighted" (Act II, Scene I, Ophelia (speech 28)) Ophelia's fear.
- "This is the very ecstasy of love" (Act II, Scene I, Polonius (speech 35)) Polonius's diagnosis.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception.
Evidence: "By indirections find directions out" (Act II, Scene I, Polonius (speech 19))
Reasoning: He tells Reynaldo to "By indirections find directions out," and after Ophelia's report decides "This is the very ecstasy of love."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
windlasses (noun)	roundabout methods	*See you now; Your bait of falsehood takes this carp of truth: And thus do we of wisdom and of reach, With windlasses and with assays of bias, By indirections find directions out: So by my former lecture and advice, Shall you my son.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
indirections (noun)	indirect means	*See you now; Your bait of falsehood takes this carp of truth: And thus do we of wisdom and of reach, With windlasses and with assays of bias, By indirections find directions out: So by my former lecture and advice, Shall you my son.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
brothel (noun)	a house of prostitution	*Videlicet, a brothel, or so forth.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
fencing (noun)	sword-fighting for sport	*Ay, or drinking, fencing, swearing, quarrelling, Drabbing: you may go so far.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
affrighted (verb)	frightened	*O, my lord, my lord, I have been so affrighted!*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
perusal (noun)	a careful reading	*He took me by the wrist and held me hard; Then goes he to the length of all his arm; And, with his other hand thus o'er his brow, He falls to such perusal of my face As he would draw it.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
ecstasy (noun)	madness; frenzy	*This is the very ecstasy of love, Whose violent property fordoes itself And leads the will to desperate undertakings As oft as any passion under heaven That does afflict our natures.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
appurtenance (noun)	accompaniment; proper ceremony	*Your hands, come then: the appurtenance of welcome is fashion and ceremony: let me comply with you in this garb, lest my*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

		extent to the players, which, I tell you, must show fairly outward, should more appear like entertainment than yours.	

Discussion questions

1. Is it ever right to spy on family?
2. Where does characterization appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with action and delay?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. How was Hamlet dressed? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Doublet unbraced, stockings down, no hat, pale.
2. Where is Reynaldo sent? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Paris
3. What is Reynaldo told to do? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Spy on Laertes
4. What frightened Ophelia? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Hamlet's strange visit
5. What does Polonius conclude? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Hamlet is mad for love
6. Whom will Polonius tell? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: The king
7. Retell the three most important events of "Act II, Scene I" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Polonius sends Reynaldo to Paris to spy on Laertes by spreading small slanders. Ophelia enters frightened: Hamlet came to her closet dishevelled, stared, sighed and left. Polonius concludes Hamlet is mad for love and goes to tell the king.
8. Who is on stage in "Act II, Scene I", and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does "Act II, Scene I" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: "See you now; Your bait of falsehood takes this carp of truth: And thus do we of wisdom and of reach, With windlasses and with assays of bias, By indirections find directions out: So by my former lecture and advice,…" What does "windlasses" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: windlasses: roundabout methods.

Inferential / analytical

1. Why is Polonius's method ironic? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: He uses lies to discover truth.
2. What does “Act II, Scene I” suggest about Polonius spies on Laertes? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: Polonius's methods show a court of surveillance.
3. Find one example of characterization in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
4. How does the irony in this scene shape what we understand about Polonius spies on Laertes? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.6] Look for: Look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception. Useful evidence: “By indirections find directions out” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius (speech 19)): Polonius's method. On irony: Polonius uses lies to find truth. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. In the passage that begins “At “closes in the consequence,””, why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in “Act II, Scene I”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Polonius sends Reynaldo to Paris to spy on Laertes by spreading small slanders. Ophelia enters frightened: Hamlet came to her closet dishevelled, stared, sighed and left. Polonius concludes Hamlet is mad for love and goes to tell the king.
7. How does “Act II, Scene I” build on “Act I, Scene V”? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception. Useful evidence: “O, my lord, my lord, I have been so affrighted” (Act II, Scene I, Ophelia (speech 28)): Ophelia's fear. Theme link: indirection. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception. Useful evidence: “This is the very ecstasy of love” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius (speech 35)): Polonius's diagnosis. On characterization: Polonius sends Reynaldo to spy on Laertes. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. The bell-ringer asked: “Is it ever right to spy on family?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.

10. Where does plot appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with action and delay? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Look for key events and the causes linking them.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception. Useful evidence: “By indirections find directions out” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius (speech 19)): Polonius's method. On plot: Ophelia reports Hamlet's strange visit. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Is Hamlet's visit to Ophelia part of his act? Argue. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A reasoned reading.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception. Useful evidence: “O, my lord, my lord, I have been so affrighted” (Act II, Scene I, Ophelia (speech 28)): Ophelia's fear. Theme link: indirection. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: “Polonius's methods show a court of surveillance.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception. Useful evidence: “This is the very ecstasy of love” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius (speech 35)): Polonius's diagnosis. Theme link: indirection. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception. Useful evidence: “By indirections find directions out” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius (speech 19)): Polonius's method. On characterization: Polonius sends Reynaldo to spy on Laertes. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. You are directing “Act II, Scene I”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of Polonius spies on Laertes. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception. Useful evidence: “O, my lord, my lord, I have been so affrighted” (Act II, Scene I, Ophelia (speech 28)): Ophelia's fear. Theme link: indirection. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. Write three questions of your own about “Act II, Scene I”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception. Useful evidence: “This is the very ecstasy of love” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius (speech 35)): Polonius's diagnosis. Theme link: indirection. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Connect this scene to appearance and reality: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception. Useful evidence: “By indirections find directions out” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius (speech 19)): Polonius's method. Theme link: indirection. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. Is the characterization in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception. Useful evidence: “O, my lord, my lord, I have been so affrighted” (Act II, Scene I, Ophelia (speech 28)): Ophelia's fear. On characterization: Polonius sends Reynaldo to spy on Laertes. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. Compare how “Act II, Scene I” treats Polonius spies on Laertes with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception. Useful evidence: “This is the very ecstasy of love” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius (speech 35)): Polonius's diagnosis. Theme link: indirection. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. Predict what “Act II, Scene II” will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception. Useful evidence: “By indirections find directions out” (Act II, Scene I, Polonius (speech 19)): Polonius's method. Theme link: indirection. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about Polonius spies on Laertes? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Polonius believes he can uncover truth through deception. Useful evidence: “O, my lord, my lord, I have been so affrighted” (Act II, Scene I, Ophelia (speech 28)): Ophelia's fear. Theme link: indirection. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Characterization:** look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Irony**: gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true
- Also notice **Plot**: key events and the causes linking them

Chapter quiz

1. Where is Reynaldo sent?
   A. Paris
   B. Wittenberg
   C. London
   D. Norway
2. What is Reynaldo told to do?
   A. Spy on Laertes
   B. Bring money only
   C. Fight Laertes
   D. Find Hamlet
3. What frightened Ophelia?
   A. Hamlet's strange visit
   B. A ghost
   C. Laertes's letter
   D. Her father's anger
4. What does Polonius conclude?
   A. Hamlet is mad for love
   B. Hamlet is ill
   C. Hamlet is spying
   D. Hamlet is faking
5. Whom will Polonius tell?
   A. Laertes
   B. The king
   C. Gertrude only
   D. Horatio
6. In the line "See you now; Your bait of falsehood takes this carp of truth: And thus do we of wisdom and of reach, With windlasses and with assays of bias, By indirections find directions out: So by my former lecture and advice, Shall you my son.", what does "windlasses" most nearly mean?
   A. roundabout methods
   B. sword-fighting for sport
   C. a house of prostitution
   D. indirect means
7. In the line "See you now; Your bait of falsehood takes this carp of truth: And thus do we of wisdom and of reach, With windlasses and with assays of bias, By indirections find directions out: So by my former lecture and advice, Shall you my son.", what does "indirections" most nearly mean?
   A. roundabout methods
   B. indirect means
   C. sword-fighting for sport

D. a house of prostitution

Answer key: 1. A (Paris); 2. A (Spy on Laertes); 3. A (Hamlet's strange visit); 4. A (Hamlet is mad for love); 5. B (The king); 6. A (roundabout methods); 7. B (indirect means)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.3, W.7.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this play is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In "Act II, Scene I," how does Shakespeare show Polonius spies on Laertes? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the characterization you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In Act II, Scene I, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of Polonius spies on Laertes? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the characterization in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act II, Scene I develops the idea of Polonius spies on Laertes. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and irony shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act II, Scene I (where it begins, turns and ends) and its characterization shape the reader's understanding of Polonius spies on Laertes. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act II, Scene I suggests about Polonius spies on Laertes. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's characterization and irony), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses characterization in Act II, Scene I to complicate the reader's understanding of Polonius spies on Laertes. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate Act II, Scene I within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of Polonius spies on Laertes responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read Act II, Scene I alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of Polonius spies on Laertes follows or bends those conventions, using the characterization as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act II, Scene I and its treatment of Polonius spies on Laertes. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's characterization and irony, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads Act II, Scene I as evidence for a larger claim about Polonius spies on Laertes in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads Act II, Scene I as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of Polonius spies on Laertes. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *Videlicet, a brothel, or so forth.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “brothel” most nearly mean?

   A. a careful reading

   B. accompaniment; proper ceremony

   C. a house of prostitution

   D. madness; frenzy

2. *At “closes in the consequence,” ay, marry; He closes thus: “I know the gentleman; I saw him yesterday, or t’ other day, Or then, or then; with such, or such; and, as you say, There was a’ gaming; there o’ertook in’s rouse; There falling out at tennis:” or perchance, “I saw him enter such a house of sale,” Videlicet, a brothel, or so forth. See you now; Your bait of falsehood takes this carp of truth: And thus do we of wisdom and of reach, With windlasses and with assays of bias, By indirections find directions out: So by my former lecture and advice, Shall you my son. You have me, have you not?*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “Act II, Scene I”?

   A. The duel and the deaths

   B. Polonius spies on Laertes

   C. Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players

   D. Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia

SAT key: 1. C (a house of prostitution); 2. B (Polonius spies on Laertes)

Lesson 9: Act II, Scene II

Focus: Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players

Teacher only · spoilers

Claudius and Gertrude have summoned Rosencrantz and Guildenstern to discover Hamlet's trouble. Ambassadors report Norway's peace. Polonius reads Hamlet's love letter and plans to spy. Hamlet mocks Polonius, sees through his friends, and welcomes travelling players. After the First Player weeps for Hecuba, Hamlet berates himself and plans a play to catch Claudius's conscience.

Background: Child companies rivalled adult players around 1600, a topical reference.

Significance: Hamlet devises the play to test the Ghost's story.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Why might someone need proof before acting? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to action and delay because....
Prompt: Why might someone need proof before acting?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to action and delay because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: Hamlet berates himself for inaction.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: appurtenance — accompaniment; proper ceremony; fishmonger — a fish-seller; possibly a pimp in slang; doomsday — the day of final judgment; quintessence — the purest essence; expostulate — to argue earnestly with someone to change their mind. “expostulate”: From Latin expostulare "to demand urgently, remonstrate," from ex- + postulare "to demand."
Words: appurtenance: accompaniment; proper ceremony · fishmonger: a fish-seller; possibly a pimp in slang · doomsday: the day of final judgment · quintessence: the purest essence · expostulate: to argue earnestly with someone to change their mind

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Child companies rivalled adult players around 1600, a topical reference. Hamlet devises the play to test the Ghost's story. Characterization: Hamlet mocks Polonius; greets Rosencrantz and Guildenstern; welcomes the players. Structure: Soliloquy: "O, what a rogue and peasant slave am I." Plot: Hamlet plans The Mousetrap. Watch for disease and rot: Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: “It was against your highness: whereat grieved, / That so his sickness, age and impotence / Was falsely borne in hand, sends out arrests” (Act II, Scene II, Voltimand (speech 17)).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "Though this be madness, yet there is method in't" (Act II, Scene II, Polonius (speech 57)). Polonius's aside. That is characterization at work: Hamlet mocks Polonius; greets Rosencrantz and Guildenstern; welcomes the players.

> *Though this be madness, yet there is method in't* (Act II, Scene II, Polonius (speech 57))

Think-aloud: I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "Though this be madness, yet there is method in't" (Act II, Scene II, Polonius (speech 57)). Polonius's aside. That is characterization at work: Hamlet mocks Polonius; greets Rosencrantz and Guildenstern; welcomes the players.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Hamlet will use the play to provoke Claudius. Expected link: acting and seeming. Ask: How does this line connect to action and delay? Expected: Hamlet berates himself for inaction. (The plan.)

> *the play's the thing / Wherein I'll catch the conscience of the king* (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 164))

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Hamlet will use the play to provoke Claudius. Expected link: acting and seeming.
Ask: How does this line connect to action and delay?
Expected answer: Hamlet berates himself for inaction. (The plan.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the scene for characterization, structure (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act II, Scene II develops the idea of Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and structure shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. When the text says “What a piece of work is a man” (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 100)), it shows this directly. Polonius sees "method in't," Hamlet marvels "What a piece of work is a man," then resolves "The play's the thing / Wherein I'll catch the conscience of the king."
Task: Annotate the scene for characterization, structure (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act II, Scene II develops the idea of Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and structure shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. When the text says “What a piece of work is a man” (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 100)), it shows this directly. Polonius sees "method in't," Hamlet marvels "What a piece of work is a man," then resolves "The play's the thing / Wherein I'll catch the conscience of the king."

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: Why might someone need proof before acting? Why does Hamlet need proof?
Anchor question: Why might someone need proof before acting?
Facilitation: Why does Hamlet need proof?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. (“What a piece of work is a man”, Act II, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 100)). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. (“What a piece of work is a man”, Act II, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 100)). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how characterization shapes Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players. Key takeaway: Hamlet berates himself for inaction.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Characterization:** Hamlet mocks Polonius; greets Rosencrantz and Guildenstern; welcomes the players.
- **Structure:** Soliloquy: "O, what a rogue and peasant slave am I."
- **Plot:** Hamlet plans The Mousetrap.

Themes and how they develop

- **action and delay:** Hamlet berates himself for inaction.

Symbols and motifs

- **disease and rot:** Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: “It was against your highness: whereat grieved, / That so his sickness, age and impotence / Was falsely borne in hand, sends out arrests” (Act II, Scene II, Voltimand (speech 17)).
- **poison and ears:** Old Hamlet was poisoned through the ear; lies poured into ears, and poison returns at the end. In this scene: “by time, by means and place, / All given to mine ear” (Act II, Scene II, Polonius (speech 23)).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “Though this be madness, yet there is method in’t” (Act II, Scene II, Polonius (speech 57)) Polonius's aside.
- “What a piece of work is a man” (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 100)) Hamlet on humanity.
- “the play’s the thing / Wherein I’ll catch the conscience of the king” (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 164)) The plan.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth.
Evidence: “What a piece of work is a man” (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 100))
Reasoning: Polonius sees "method in't," Hamlet marvels "What a piece of work is a man," then resolves "The play's the thing / Wherein I'll catch the conscience of the king."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
appurtenance (noun)	accompaniment; proper ceremony	*Your hands, come then: the appurtenance of welcome is fashion and ceremony: let me comply with you in this garb, lest my extent to*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

		the players, which, I tell you, must show fairly outward, should more appear like entertainment than yours.	
fishmonger (noun)	a fish-seller; possibly a pimp in slang	*Excellent well; you are a fishmonger.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
doomsday (noun)	the day of final judgment	*Then is doomsday near: but your news is not true.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
quintessence (noun)	the purest essence	*And yet, to me, what is this quintessence of dust? man delights not me: no, nor woman neither, though by your smiling you seem to say so.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
expostulate (verb)	to argue earnestly with someone to change their mind	*My liege, and madam, to expostulate What majesty should be, what duty is, Why day is day, night night, and time is time, Were nothing but to waste night, day and time.*	“expostulate”: From Latin expostulare "to demand urgently, remonstrate," from ex- + postulare "to demand." (Online Etymology Dictionary, https://www.etymonline.com/word/expostulate)
dungeons (noun)	dark underground prison cells	*A goodly one; in which there are many confines, wards and dungeons, Denmark being one o’ the worst.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
brevity (noun)	the use of brief expressions	*Therefore, since brevity is the soul of wit, And tediousness the limbs and outward flourishes, I will be brief: your noble son is mad: Mad call I it; for, to define true madness, What is’t but to be nothing else but mad?*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
defective (adjective)	having a defect	*Mad let us grant him, then: and now remains That we find out the cause of this effect, Or rather say, the cause of this defect, For this effect defective comes by cause: Thus it remains, and the remainder thus.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
provoke (verb)	call forth (emotions, feelings, and responses)	*Moreover that we much did long to see you, The need we have to use you did provoke Our hasty sending.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
secrecy (noun)	the trait of keeping things secret	*I will tell you why; so shall my anticipation prevent your discovery, and your secrecy to the king and queen moult no feather.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. Why might someone need proof before acting?
2. Where does characterization appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with appearance and reality?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. Whose death does the First Player describe? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Priam's, and Hecuba's grief.
2. Who summoned Rosencrantz and Guildenstern? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Claudius and Gertrude
3. What does Polonius read? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Hamlet's love letter to Ophelia
4. What does Hamlet call Polonius? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: A fishmonger
5. Who arrives at court? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Travelling players
6. What will the play catch? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: The conscience of the king
7. Retell the three most important events of "Act II, Scene II" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Claudius and Gertrude have summoned Rosencrantz and Guildenstern to discover Hamlet's trouble. Ambassadors report Norway's peace. Polonius reads Hamlet's love letter and plans to spy. Hamlet mocks Polonius, sees through his friends, and welcomes travelling players. After the First Player weeps for Hecuba, Hamlet berates himself and plans a play to catch Claudius's conscience.
8. Who is on stage in "Act II, Scene II", and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does "Act II, Scene II" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: "Your hands, come then: the appurtenance of welcome is fashion and ceremony: let me comply with you in this garb, lest my extent to the players, which, I tell you, must show fairly outward, should more appear like…" What does "appurtenance" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: appurtenance: accompaniment; proper ceremony.

Inferential / analytical

1. Why does Hamlet doubt the Ghost? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: It may be a devil.
2. What does “Act II, Scene II” suggest about Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: Hamlet devises the play to test the Ghost's story.
3. Find one example of characterization in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
4. How does the structure in this scene shape what we understand about Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: Look for how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. Useful evidence: “Though this be madness, yet there is method in’t” (Act II, Scene II, Polonius (speech 57)): Polonius's aside. On structure: Soliloquy: "O, what a rogue and peasant slave am I." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. In the passage that begins “This business is well ended.”, why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in “Act II, Scene II”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Claudius and Gertrude have summoned Rosencrantz and Guildenstern to discover Hamlet's trouble. Ambassadors report Norway's peace. Polonius reads Hamlet's love letter and plans to spy. Hamlet mocks Polonius, sees through his friends, and welcomes travelling players. After the First Player weeps for…
7. How does “Act II, Scene II” build on “Act II, Scene I”? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. Useful evidence: “What a piece of work is a man” (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 100)): Hamlet on humanity. On structure: Soliloquy: "O, what a rogue and peasant slave am I." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. Useful evidence: “the play’s the thing / Wherein I’ll catch the conscience of the king” (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 164)): The plan. On characterization: Hamlet mocks Polonius; greets Rosencrantz and Guildenstern; welcomes the players. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. The bell-ringer asked: “Why might someone need proof before acting?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.

10. Where does plot appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with appearance and reality? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Look for key events and the causes linking them.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. Useful evidence: “Though this be madness, yet there is method in’t” (Act II, Scene II, Polonius (speech 57)): Polonius's aside. On plot: Hamlet plans The Mousetrap. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Is Hamlet right to test the Ghost? [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A judgment.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. Useful evidence: “What a piece of work is a man” (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 100)): Hamlet on humanity. Theme link: Hamlet berates himself for inaction. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: “Hamlet devises the play to test the Ghost's story.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. Useful evidence: “the play’s the thing / Wherein I’ll catch the conscience of the king” (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 164)): The plan. Theme link: Hamlet berates himself for inaction. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. Useful evidence: “Though this be madness, yet there is method in’t” (Act II, Scene II, Polonius (speech 57)): Polonius's aside. On characterization: Hamlet mocks Polonius; greets Rosencrantz and Guildenstern; welcomes the players. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. You are directing “Act II, Scene II”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. Useful evidence: “What a piece of work is a man” (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 100)): Hamlet on humanity. On structure: Soliloquy: "O, what a rogue and peasant slave am I." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. Write three questions of your own about “Act II, Scene II”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. Useful evidence: “the play’s the thing / Wherein I’ll catch the conscience of the king” (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 164)): The plan. Theme link: Hamlet berates himself for inaction. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
6. Connect this scene to death and mortality: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A judgment of

thematic development across the work.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. Useful evidence: "Though this be madness, yet there is method in't" (Act II, Scene II, Polonius (speech 57)): Polonius's aside. Theme link: Hamlet berates himself for inaction. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Is the characterization in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. Useful evidence: "What a piece of work is a man" (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 100)): Hamlet on humanity. On characterization: Hamlet mocks Polonius; greets Rosencrantz and Guildenstern; welcomes the players. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. Compare how "Act II, Scene II" treats Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. Useful evidence: "the play's the thing / Wherein I'll catch the conscience of the king" (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 164)): The plan. Theme link: Hamlet berates himself for inaction. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Predict what "Act III, Scene I" will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. Useful evidence: "Though this be madness, yet there is method in't" (Act II, Scene II, Polonius (speech 57)): Polonius's aside. Theme link: Hamlet berates himself for inaction. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet uses theatre to test the truth. Useful evidence: "What a piece of work is a man" (Act II, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 100)): Hamlet on humanity. Theme link: Hamlet berates himself for inaction. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Characterization:** look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Structure**: how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does
- Also notice **Plot**: key events and the causes linking them

Chapter quiz

1. Who summoned Rosencrantz and Guildenstern?
   A. Polonius
   B. Claudius and Gertrude
   C. Horatio
   D. Hamlet
2. What does Polonius read?
   A. The Ghost's words
   B. Hamlet's love letter to Ophelia
   C. A play
   D. A letter from Laertes
3. What does Hamlet call Polonius?
   A. A fishmonger
   B. A king
   C. A ghost
   D. A friend
4. Who arrives at court?
   A. Fortinbras
   B. Laertes
   C. Travelling players
   D. Pirates
5. What will the play catch?
   A. Ophelia
   B. The conscience of the king
   C. A thief
   D. Fortinbras
6. In the line "Your hands, come then: the appurtenance of welcome is fashion and ceremony: let me comply with you in this garb, lest my extent to the players, which, I tell you, must show fairly outward, should more appear like entertainment than yours.", what does "appurtenance" most nearly mean?
   A. a fish-seller; possibly a pimp in slang
   B. accompaniment; proper ceremony
   C. the purest essence
   D. the day of final judgment
7. In the line "Excellent well; you are a fishmonger.", what does "fishmonger" most nearly mean?
   A. the purest essence
   B. the day of final judgment
   C. a fish-seller; possibly a pimp in slang
   D. accompaniment; proper ceremony

Answer key: 1. B (Claudius and Gertrude); 2. B (Hamlet's love letter to Ophelia); 3. A (A fishmonger); 4. C (Travelling players); 5. B (The conscience of the king); 6. B (accompaniment; proper ceremony); 7. C (a fish-seller; possibly a pimp in slang)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.3, W.7.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this play is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In "Act II, Scene II," how does Shakespeare show Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the characterization you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In Act II, Scene II, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the characterization in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act II, Scene II develops the idea of Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and structure shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act II, Scene II (where it begins, turns and ends) and its characterization shape the reader's understanding of Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act II, Scene II suggests about Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's characterization and structure), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses characterization in Act II, Scene II to complicate the reader's understanding of Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate Act II, Scene II within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read Act II, Scene II alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players follows or bends those conventions, using the characterization as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act II, Scene II and its treatment of Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's characterization and structure, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads Act II, Scene II as evidence for a larger claim about Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads Act II, Scene II as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *Then is doomsday near: but your news is not true.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “doomsday” most nearly mean?

   A. call forth (emotions, feelings, and responses)

   B. having a defect

   C. the day of final judgment

   D. the trait of keeping things secret

2. *This business is well ended. My liege, and madam, to expostulate What majesty should be, what duty is, Why day is day, night night, and time is time, Were nothing but to waste night, day and time. Therefore, since brevity is the soul of wit, And tediousness the limbs and outward flourishes, I will be brief: your noble son is mad: Mad call I it; for, to define true madness, What is’t but to be nothing else but mad? But let that go.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “Act II, Scene II”?

   A. The plot against Hamlet

   B. The Ghost's revelation

   C. Hamlet hides the body

   D. Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players

SAT key: 1. C (the day of final judgment); 2. D (Rosencrantz, Guildenstern and the players)

Lesson 10: Act III, Scene I

Focus: 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene

Content note (suicidal thoughts): 'To be, or not to be' weighs living against dying. Use the safe-messaging script; keep the discussion on Hamlet's reasoning about action and uncertainty, and name where to find support.
Student preview: This speech considers whether life is worth living. Support is available if this is hard to read.
Suggested language: "What stops Hamlet from acting, according to the speech?"
Safe messaging: Discuss the character's despair and what the text does with it; do not dwell on methods. Before the lesson, remind students that support is available and how to reach the counselor. Check in privately with any student who seems affected and follow your school's referral protocol. **Share with students:** If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today. Let a counselor know in advance that this scene is being taught.

Teacher only · spoilers

Rosencrantz and Guildenstern report failure. Claudius and Polonius hide to watch Hamlet with Ophelia. Hamlet meditates on life, death and action. Ophelia returns his gifts; he denies loving her, tells her to go to a nunnery, and rails against marriage. Claudius decides to send Hamlet to England.

Background: Suicide was considered a mortal sin.

Significance: Hamlet's thought and cruelty are both on show.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Why is thinking sometimes an obstacle to acting? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to death and mortality because.... Content note before we start: This speech considers whether life is worth living. Support is available if this is hard to read. If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today.
Prompt: Why is thinking sometimes an obstacle to acting?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to death and mortality because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: Hamlet contemplates death.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: calumny — slander; nunnery — a convent of nuns; also slang for a brothel; wildness — a feeling of extreme emotional intensity; pastime — a sport; diversion; forcing — making oneself do something.
Words: calumny: slander · nunnery: a convent of nuns; also slang for a brothel · wildness: a feeling of extreme emotional intensity · pastime: a sport; diversion · forcing: making oneself do something

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Suicide was considered a mortal sin. Hamlet's thought and cruelty are both on show. Structure: "To be, or not to be" soliloquy. Characterization: Hamlet rejects Ophelia. Irony: Claudius and Polonius spy. Watch for poison and ears: Old Hamlet was poisoned through the ear; lies poured into ears, and poison returns at the end. In this scene: "him; / And I'll be placed, so please you, in the ear / Of all their conference. If she find him not, / To England" (Act III, Scene I, Polonius (speech 44)).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "To be, or not to be: that is the question" (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet (speech 19)). Life versus death. That is structure at work: "To be, or not to be" soliloquy.

> *To be, or not to be: that is the question (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet (speech 19))*

Think-aloud: I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "To be, or not to be: that is the question" (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet (speech 19)). Life versus death. That is structure at work: "To be, or not to be" soliloquy.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Thinking prevents action. Look at the craft: Hamlet rejects Ophelia. Ask: How does this line connect to death and mortality? Expected: Hamlet contemplates death. (Thinking prevents action.)

> *Thus conscience does make cowards of us all (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet (speech 19))*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Thinking prevents action. Look at the craft: Hamlet rejects Ophelia.
Ask: How does this line connect to death and mortality?
Expected answer: Hamlet contemplates death. (Thinking prevents action.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the scene for structure, characterization (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act III, Scene I develops the idea of 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of structure and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. When the text says “Thus conscience does make cowards of us all” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet (speech 19)), it shows this directly. He asks "To be, or not to be" and concludes "conscience does make cowards of us all," then turns on Ophelia: "Get thee to a nunnery."
Task: Annotate the scene for structure, characterization (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act III, Scene I develops the idea of 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of structure and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. When the text says “Thus conscience does make cowards of us all” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet (speech 19)), it shows this directly. He asks "To be, or not to be" and concludes "conscience does make cowards of us all," then turns on Ophelia: "Get thee to a nunnery."

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: Why is thinking sometimes an obstacle to acting? Does Hamlet know he is being watched?
Anchor question: Why is thinking sometimes an obstacle to acting?
Facilitation: Does Hamlet know he is being watched?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. (“Thus conscience does make cowards of us all”, Act III, Scene I, Hamlet (speech 19)). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. (“Thus conscience does make cowards of us all”, Act III, Scene I, Hamlet (speech 19)). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how structure shapes 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene. Key takeaway: Hamlet contemplates death.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Structure:** "To be, or not to be" soliloquy.
- **Characterization:** Hamlet rejects Ophelia.
- **Irony:** Claudius and Polonius spy.

Themes and how they develop

- **death and mortality:** Hamlet contemplates death.

Symbols and motifs

- **poison and ears:** Old Hamlet was poisoned through the ear; lies poured into ears, and poison returns at the end. In this scene: “him; / And I’ll be placed, so please you, in the ear / Of all their conference. If she find him not, / To England” (Act III, Scene I, Polonius (speech 44)).
- **acting and seeming:** "Seems, madam! nay it is": performance, the players, feigned madness and the Mousetrap. In this scene: “Madam, it so fell out, that certain players / We o’er-raught on the way: of these we told him; / And” (Act III, Scene I, Rosencrantz (speech 9)).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “To be, or not to be: that is the question” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet (speech 19)) Life versus death.
- “Thus conscience does make cowards of us all” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet (speech 19)) Thinking prevents action.
- “Get thee to a nunnery” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet (speech 35)) Hamlet's rejection.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis.
Evidence: “Thus conscience does make cowards of us all” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet (speech 19))
Reasoning: He asks "To be, or not to be" and concludes "conscience does make cowards of us all," then turns on Ophelia: "Get thee to a nunnery."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
calumny (noun)	slander	*If thou dost marry, I’ll give thee this plague for thy dowry: be thou as chaste as ice, as pure as snow, thou shalt not escape calumny.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
nunnery (noun)		*Get thee to a nunnery: why wouldst thou be a breeder of sinners?*	

	a convent of nuns; also slang for a brothel		Student look-up (not yet verified)
wildness (noun)	a feeling of extreme emotional intensity	*And for your part, Ophelia, I do wish That your good beauties be the happy cause Of Hamlet's wildness: so shall I hope your virtues Will bring him to his wonted way again, To both your honours.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
pastime (noun)	a sport; diversion	*Did you assay him To any pastime?*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
forcing (verb)	making oneself do something	*But with much forcing of his disposition.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
candied (adjective)	sugared; flattering	*No, let the candied tongue lick absurd pomp, And crook the pregnant hinges of the knee Where thrift may follow fawning.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
chameleon (noun)	a lizard once believed to live on air	*Excellent, i' faith; of the chameleon's dish: I eat the air, promise-crammed: you cannot feed capons so.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
heedful (adjective)	careful; watchful	*Give him heedful note; For I mine eyes will rivet to his face, And after we will both our judgments join In censure of his seeming.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. Why is thinking sometimes an obstacle to acting?
2. Where does structure appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with death and mortality?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What does Hamlet call death? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: The undiscover'd country.
2. Who hides to watch? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Claudius and Polonius
3. What does Ophelia return? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Hamlet's gifts

4. Where does Hamlet tell Ophelia to go? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: A nunnery
5. What does Claudius decide? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: To send Hamlet to England
6. What does conscience make of us? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Cowards
7. Retell the three most important events of "Act III, Scene I" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Rosencrantz and Guildenstern report failure. Claudius and Polonius hide to watch Hamlet with Ophelia. Hamlet meditates on life, death and action. Ophelia returns his gifts; he denies loving her, tells her to go to a nunnery, and rails against marriage. Claudius decides to send Hamlet to England.
8. Who is on stage in "Act III, Scene I", and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does "Act III, Scene I" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: "If thou dost marry, I'll give thee this plague for thy dowry: be thou as chaste as ice, as pure as snow, thou shalt not escape calumny." What does "calumny" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: calumny: slander.

Inferential / analytical

1. Does Hamlet know he is watched? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A reasoned inference.
2. What does "Act III, Scene I" suggest about 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: Hamlet's thought and cruelty are both on show.
3. Find one example of structure in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: Look for how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does.
4. How does the characterization in this scene shape what we understand about 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. Useful evidence: "To be, or not to be: that is the question" (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet (speech 19)): Life versus death. On characterization: Hamlet rejects Ophelia. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. In the passage that begins "I shall obey you.", why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in "Act III, Scene I", and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Rosencrantz and Guildenstern report failure. Claudius and Polonius hide to watch Hamlet with Ophelia. Hamlet meditates on life, death and action. Ophelia returns his gifts; he denies loving her, tells her to go to a nunnery, and rails against marriage. Claudius decides to send Hamlet to England.

7. How does “Act III, Scene I” build on “Act II, Scene II”? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. Useful evidence: “Thus conscience does make cowards of us all” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet (speech 19)): Thinking prevents action. On structure: "To be, or not to be" soliloquy. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. Useful evidence: “Get thee to a nunnery” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet (speech 35)): Hamlet's rejection. On characterization: Hamlet rejects Ophelia. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. The bell-ringer asked: “Why is thinking sometimes an obstacle to acting?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does irony appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with death and mortality? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.6] Look for: Look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. Useful evidence: “To be, or not to be: that is the question” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet (speech 19)): Life versus death. On irony: Claudius and Polonius spy. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Is Hamlet's treatment of Ophelia excusable? [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A judgment.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. Useful evidence: “Thus conscience does make cowards of us all” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet (speech 19)): Thinking prevents action. Theme link: Hamlet contemplates death. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: “Hamlet's thought and cruelty are both on show.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. Useful evidence: “Get thee to a nunnery” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet (speech 35)): Hamlet's rejection. Theme link: Hamlet contemplates death. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. Useful evidence: “To be, or not to be: that is the question” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet (speech 19)): Life versus death.

On characterization: Hamlet rejects Ophelia. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

4. You are directing “Act III, Scene I”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. Useful evidence: “Thus conscience does make cowards of us all” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet (speech 19)): Thinking prevents action. On structure: "To be, or not to be" soliloquy. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. Write three questions of your own about “Act III, Scene I”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. Useful evidence: “Get thee to a nunnery” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet (speech 35)): Hamlet's rejection. Theme link: Hamlet contemplates death. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
6. Connect this scene to corruption and the state: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. Useful evidence: “To be, or not to be: that is the question” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet (speech 19)): Life versus death. Theme link: Hamlet contemplates death. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. Is the structure in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. Useful evidence: “Thus conscience does make cowards of us all” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet (speech 19)): Thinking prevents action. On structure: "To be, or not to be" soliloquy. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. Compare how “Act III, Scene I” treats 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. Useful evidence: “Get thee to a nunnery” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet (speech 35)): Hamlet's rejection. Theme link: Hamlet contemplates death. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. Predict what “Act III, Scene II” will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. Useful evidence: “To be, or not to be: that is the question” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet (speech 19)): Life versus death.

Theme link: Hamlet contemplates death. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's thoughts on death reveal his paralysis. Useful evidence: “Thus conscience does make cowards of us all” (Act III, Scene I, Hamlet (speech 19)): Thinking prevents action. Theme link: Hamlet contemplates death. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Structure:** look for how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Characterization**: what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them
- Also notice **Irony**: gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true

Chapter quiz

1. Who hides to watch?
    A. Gertrude and Horatio
    B. Laertes
    C. Claudius and Polonius
    D. Rosencrantz
2. What does Ophelia return?
    A. A ring
    B. Hamlet's gifts
    C. Flowers
    D. A letter
3. Where does Hamlet tell Ophelia to go?
    A. England
    B. A nunnery
    C. Her father
    D. France
4. What does Claudius decide?
    A. To send Hamlet to England
    B. To confess
    C. To kill Hamlet
    D. To abdicate
5. What does conscience make of us?
    A. Kings
    B. Cowards

C. Saints

D. Heroes

6. In the line “If thou dost marry, I’ll give thee this plague for thy dowry: be thou as chaste as ice, as pure as snow, thou shalt not escape calumny.”, what does “calumny” most nearly mean?

A. slander

B. a sport; diversion

C. a convent of nuns; also slang for a brothel

D. a feeling of extreme emotional intensity

7. In the line “Get thee to a nunnery: why wouldst thou be a breeder of sinners?”, what does “nunnery” most nearly mean?

A. a feeling of extreme emotional intensity

B. slander

C. a sport; diversion

D. a convent of nuns; also slang for a brothel

Answer key: 1. C (Claudius and Polonius); 2. B (Hamlet's gifts); 3. B (A nunnery); 4. A (To send Hamlet to England); 5. B (Cowards); 6. A (slander); 7. D (a convent of nuns; also slang for a brothel)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.3, W.7.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this play is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Act III, Scene I,” how does Shakespeare show 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the structure you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.5, W.9-10.1): In Act III, Scene I, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the structure in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.5, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act III, Scene I develops the idea of 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of structure and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act III, Scene I (where it begins, turns and ends) and its structure shape the reader's understanding of 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act III, Scene I suggests about 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's structure and characterization), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses structure in Act III, Scene I to complicate the reader's understanding of 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate Act III, Scene I within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read Act III, Scene I alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene follows or bends those conventions, using the structure as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act III, Scene I and its treatment of 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's structure and characterization, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads Act III, Scene I as evidence for a larger claim about 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads Act III, Scene I as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *And for your part, Ophelia, I do wish That your good beauties be the happy cause Of Hamlet’s wildness: so shall I hope your virtues Will bring him to his wonted way again, To both your honours.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “wildness” most nearly mean?

   A. sugared; flattering

   B. a feeling of extreme emotional intensity

   C. careful; watchful

   D. a lizard once believed to live on air

2. *I shall obey you. And for your part, Ophelia, I do wish That your good beauties be the happy cause Of Hamlet’s wildness: so shall I hope your virtues Will bring him to his wonted way again, To both your honours.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “Act III, Scene I”?

   A. Fortinbras's army

   B. Worms and kings

C. The graveyard

D. 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene

SAT key: 1. B (a feeling of extreme emotional intensity); 2. D ('To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene)

Lesson 11: Act III, Scene II

Focus: the Mousetrap

Teacher only · spoilers

Hamlet coaches the players, praises Horatio and asks him to watch Claudius. During the play The Murder of Gonzago (renamed The Mousetrap), Hamlet makes bawdy jests to Ophelia and comments. When the poisoner pours poison in the king's ear, Claudius rises and leaves. Hamlet is elated. Rosencrantz and Guildenstern summon him to his mother; Hamlet mocks them with a recorder.

Background: Plays within plays were popular.

Significance: The test succeeds.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Can art reveal the truth? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to appearance and reality because....
Prompt: Can art reveal the truth?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to appearance and reality because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: theater reveals truth.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: candied — sugared; flattering; chameleon — a lizard once believed to live on air; heedful — careful; watchful; dallying — flirting; trifling; purgation — cleansing; also medical purging.
Words: candied: sugared; flattering · chameleon: a lizard once believed to live on air · heedful: careful; watchful · dallying: flirting; trifling · purgation: cleansing; also medical purging

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Plays within plays were popular. The test succeeds. Structure: The Mousetrap play within a play. Characterization: Hamlet's instructions to the players; Claudius's reaction. Irony: The Player Queen's vows. Watch for disease and rot: Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: "a fellow, takes off his crown, kisses it, and pours poison in the King's ears, and exit. The Queen returns; finds the" (Act III, Scene II, speech (speech 42)).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. “suit the action to the word, the word to the action” (Act III, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 3)). Acting advice. That is structure at work: The Mousetrap play within a play.

> *suit the action to the word, the word to the action* (Act III, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 3))

Think-aloud: I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. “suit the action to the word, the word to the action” (Act III, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 3)). Acting advice. That is structure at work: The Mousetrap play within a play.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Gertrude on the Player Queen. Look at the craft: Hamlet's instructions to the players; Claudius's reaction. Ask: How does this line connect to appearance and reality? Expected: Theater reveals truth. (Gertrude on the Player Queen.)

> *The lady doth protest too much, methinks* (Act III, Scene II, Queen (speech 66))

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Gertrude on the Player Queen. Look at the craft: Hamlet's instructions to the players; Claudius's reaction.
Ask: How does this line connect to appearance and reality?
Expected answer: Theater reveals truth. (Gertrude on the Player Queen.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the scene for structure, characterization (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about the Mousetrap? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act III, Scene II develops the idea of the Mousetrap. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of structure and irony shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius. When the text says “The lady doth protest too much, methinks” (Act III, Scene II, Queen (speech 66)), it shows this directly. Hamlet instructs to "Suit the action to the word," Gertrude remarks "The lady doth protest too much, methinks," and Claudius cries "Give me some light: away!"
Task: Annotate the scene for structure, characterization (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about the Mousetrap? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act III, Scene II develops the idea of the Mousetrap. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of structure and irony shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius. When the text says “The lady doth protest too much, methinks” (Act III, Scene II, Queen (speech 66)), it shows this directly. Hamlet instructs to "Suit the action to the word," Gertrude remarks "The lady doth protest too much, methinks," and Claudius cries "Give me some light: away!"

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: Can art reveal the truth? Is Claudius's reaction proof?
Anchor question: Can art reveal the truth?
Facilitation: Is Claudius's reaction proof?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about the Mousetrap? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius. (“The lady doth protest too much, methinks”, Act III, Scene II, Queen (speech 66)). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about the Mousetrap? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius. (“The lady doth protest too much, methinks”, Act III, Scene II, Queen (speech 66)). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how structure shapes the Mousetrap. Key takeaway: theater reveals truth.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Structure:** The Mousetrap play within a play.
- **Characterization:** Hamlet's instructions to the players; Claudius's reaction.
- **Irony:** The Player Queen's vows.

Themes and how they develop

- **appearance and reality:** theater reveals truth.

Symbols and motifs

- **disease and rot:** Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: “a fellow, takes off his crown, kisses it, and pours poison in the King’s ears, and exit. The Queen returns; finds the” (Act III, Scene II, speech (speech 42)).
- **poison and ears:** Old Hamlet was poisoned through the ear; lies poured into ears, and poison returns at the end. In this scene: “a passion to tatters, to very rags, to split the ears of the groundlings, who for the most part are capable of” (Act III, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 1)).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- "suit the action to the word, the word to the action" (Act III, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 3)) Acting advice.
- "The lady doth protest too much, methinks" (Act III, Scene II, Queen (speech 66)) Gertrude on the Player Queen.
- "Give me some light: away" (Act III, Scene II, King (speech 84)) Claudius flees.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius.
Evidence: "The lady doth protest too much, methinks" (Act III, Scene II, Queen (speech 66))
Reasoning: Hamlet instructs to "Suit the action to the word," Gertrude remarks "The lady doth protest too much, methinks," and Claudius cries "Give me some light: away!"

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
candied (adjective)	sugared; flattering	*No, let the candied tongue lick absurd pomp, And crook the pregnant hinges of the knee Where thrift may follow fawning.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
chameleon (noun)	a lizard once believed to live on air	*Excellent, i' faith; of the chameleon's dish: I eat the air, promise-crammed: you cannot feed capons so.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
heedful (adjective)	careful; watchful	*Give him heedful note; For I mine eyes will rivet to his face, And after we will both our judgments join In censure of his seeming.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
dallying (noun)	flirting; trifling	*I could interpret between you and your love, if I could see the puppets dallying.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
purgation (noun)	cleansing; also medical purging	*Your wisdom should show itself more richer to signify this to his doctor; for, for me to put him to his purgation would perhaps plunge him into far more choler.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
agreeing (verb)	be in accord; be in agreement	*Thoughts black, hands apt, drugs fit, and time agreeing; Confederate season, else no creature seeing; Thou mixture rank, of midnight weeds collected, With Hecate's ban thrice blasted, thrice infected, Thy natural magic and dire property, On wholesome life usurp immediately.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
journeys (noun)	the act of traveling from one place to another	*So many journeys may the sun and moon Make us again count o'er ere love be done!*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
embracing (verb)	hugging	*Enter a King and a Queen very lovingly; the Queen embracing him, and he her.*	

			Student look-up (not yet verified)
mixture (noun)	a combination of different things	*Thoughts black, hands apt, drugs fit, and time agreeing; Confederate season, else no creature seeing; Thou mixture rank, of midnight weeds collected, With Hecate's ban thrice blasted, thrice infected, Thy natural magic and dire property, On wholesome life usurp immediately.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
counsel (noun)	secret; private plan	*We shall know by this fellow: the players cannot keep counsel; they'll tell all.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. Can art reveal the truth?
2. Where does structure appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with corruption and the state?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What does Hamlet tell the players about acting? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Suit the action to the word.
2. What is the play's name? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: The Mousetrap
3. Whom does Hamlet ask to watch Claudius? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Horatio
4. What does Claudius do during the poisoning scene? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Leaves
5. What does Gertrude say of the Player Queen? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: She protests too much
6. What instrument does Hamlet use to mock Guildenstern? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: A recorder
7. Retell the three most important events of "Act III, Scene II" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Hamlet coaches the players, praises Horatio and asks him to watch Claudius. During the play The Murder of Gonzago (renamed The Mousetrap), Hamlet makes bawdy jests to Ophelia and comments. When the poisoner pours poison in the king's ear, Claudius rises and leaves. Hamlet is elated. Rosencrantz and Guildenstern summon him to his mother; Hamlet mocks them with a recorder.

8. Who is on stage in “Act III, Scene II”, and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does “Act III, Scene II” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: “No, let the candied tongue lick absurd pomp, And crook the pregnant hinges of the knee Where thrift may follow fawning.” What does “candied” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: candied: sugared; flattering.

Inferential / analytical

1. Why does Hamlet trust Horatio? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: He is not passion's slave.
2. What does “Act III, Scene II” suggest about the Mousetrap? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: The test succeeds.
3. Find one example of structure in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: Look for how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does.
4. How does the irony in this scene shape what we understand about the Mousetrap? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.6] Look for: Look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius. Useful evidence: “suit the action to the word, the word to the action” (Act III, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 3)): Acting advice. On irony: The Player Queen's vows. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. In the passage that begins “Enter a King and a Queen very lovingly; the Queen embracing him, and he her.”, why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in “Act III, Scene II”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Hamlet coaches the players, praises Horatio and asks him to watch Claudius. During the play The Murder of Gonzago (renamed The Mousetrap), Hamlet makes bawdy jests to Ophelia and comments. When the poisoner pours poison in the king's ear, Claudius rises and leaves. Hamlet is elated. Rosencrantz and…
7. How does “Act III, Scene II” build on “Act III, Scene I”? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius. Useful evidence: “The lady doth protest too much, methinks” (Act III, Scene II, Queen (speech 66)): Gertrude on the Player Queen. On structure: The Mousetrap play within a play. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius. Useful evidence: “Give me some light: away” (Act III, Scene II, King (speech 84)): Claudius flees. On

characterization: Hamlet's instructions to the players; Claudius's reaction. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. The bell-ringer asked: “Can art reveal the truth?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does characterization appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with corruption and the state? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius. Useful evidence: “suit the action to the word, the word to the action” (Act III, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 3)): Acting advice. On characterization: Hamlet's instructions to the players; Claudius's reaction. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Does the Mousetrap prove Claudius's guilt? [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A reasoned argument.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius. Useful evidence: “The lady doth protest too much, methinks” (Act III, Scene II, Queen (speech 66)): Gertrude on the Player Queen. Theme link: theater reveals truth. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: “The test succeeds.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius. Useful evidence: “Give me some light: away” (Act III, Scene II, King (speech 84)): Claudius flees. Theme link: theater reveals truth. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius. Useful evidence: “suit the action to the word, the word to the action” (Act III, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 3)): Acting advice. On characterization: Hamlet's instructions to the players; Claudius's reaction. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. You are directing “Act III, Scene II”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of the Mousetrap. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius. Useful evidence: “The lady doth protest too much, methinks” (Act III, Scene II, Queen (speech 66)): Gertrude on the Player Queen. On structure: The Mousetrap play within a play. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. Write three questions of your own about "Act III, Scene II": one recall, one "why/how", and one "should/what if". Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius. Useful evidence: "Give me some light: away" (Act III, Scene II, King (speech 84)): Claudius flees. Theme link: theater reveals truth. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Connect this scene to revenge and justice: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius. Useful evidence: "suit the action to the word, the word to the action" (Act III, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 3)): Acting advice. Theme link: theater reveals truth. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Is the structure in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius. Useful evidence: "The lady doth protest too much, methinks" (Act III, Scene II, Queen (speech 66)): Gertrude on the Player Queen. On structure: The Mousetrap play within a play. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. Compare how "Act III, Scene II" treats the Mousetrap with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius. Useful evidence: "Give me some light: away" (Act III, Scene II, King (speech 84)): Claudius flees. Theme link: theater reveals truth. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Predict what "Act III, Scene III" will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius. Useful evidence: "suit the action to the word, the word to the action" (Act III, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 3)): Acting advice. Theme link: theater reveals truth. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about the Mousetrap? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The Mousetrap succeeds in exposing Claudius. Useful evidence: "The lady doth protest too much, methinks" (Act III, Scene II, Queen (speech 66)): Gertrude on the Player Queen. Theme link: theater reveals truth. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Structure:** look for how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Irony**: gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true
- Also notice **Characterization**: what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them

Chapter quiz

1. What is the play's name?
   A. The Ghost
   B. The Revenge
   C. The King's Fall
   D. The Mousetrap
2. Whom does Hamlet ask to watch Claudius?
   A. Polonius
   B. Horatio
   C. Ophelia
   D. Laertes
3. What does Claudius do during the poisoning scene?
   A. Applauds
   B. Leaves
   C. Laughs
   D. Sleeps
4. What does Gertrude say of the Player Queen?
   A. She protests too much
   B. She is mad
   C. She is beautiful
   D. She is honest
5. What instrument does Hamlet use to mock Guildenstern?
   A. A drum
   B. A lute
   C. A recorder
   D. A trumpet
6. In the line “No, let the candied tongue lick absurd pomp, And crook the pregnant hinges of the knee Where thrift may follow fawning.”, what does “candied” most nearly mean?
   A. a lizard once believed to live on air
   B. sugared; flattering
   C. careful; watchful
   D. flirting; trifling

7. In the line “Excellent, i’ faith; of the chameleon’s dish: I eat the air, promise-crammed: you cannot feed capons so.”, what does “chameleon” most nearly mean?

   A. sugared; flattering

   B. flirting; trifling

   C. careful; watchful

   D. a lizard once believed to live on air

Answer key: 1. D (The Mousetrap); 2. B (Horatio); 3. B (Leaves); 4. A (She protests too much); 5. C (A recorder); 6. B (sugared; flattering); 7. D (a lizard once believed to live on air)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.3, W.7.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this play is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Act III, Scene II,” how does Shakespeare show the Mousetrap? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the structure you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.5, W.9-10.1): In Act III, Scene II, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of the Mousetrap? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the structure in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.5, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act III, Scene II develops the idea of the Mousetrap. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of structure and irony shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act III, Scene II (where it begins, turns and ends) and its structure shape the reader's understanding of the Mousetrap. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act III, Scene II suggests about the Mousetrap. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's structure and irony), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses structure in Act III, Scene II to complicate the reader's understanding of the Mousetrap. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate Act III, Scene II within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of the Mousetrap responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read Act III, Scene II alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of the Mousetrap follows or bends those conventions, using the structure as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act III, Scene II and its treatment of the Mousetrap. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's structure and irony, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads Act III, Scene II as evidence for a larger claim about the Mousetrap in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads Act III, Scene II as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of the Mousetrap. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *Give him heedful note; For I mine eyes will rivet to his face, And after we will both our judgments join In censure of his seeming.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “heedful” most nearly mean?

   A. a combination of different things

   B. careful; watchful

   C. hugging

   D. secret; private plan

2. *Enter a King and a Queen very lovingly; the Queen embracing him, and he her. She kneels, and makes show of protestation unto him. He takes her up, and declines his head upon her neck: lays him down upon a bank of flowers: she, seeing him asleep, leaves him. Anon comes in a fellow, takes off his crown, kisses it, and pours poison in the King’s ears, and exit. The Queen returns; finds the King dead, and makes passionate action. The Poisoner, with some two or three Mutes, comes in again, seeming to lament with her. The dead body is carried away. The Poisoner wooes the Queen with gifts: she seems loath and unwilling awhile, but in the end accepts his love. Exeunt.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “Act III, Scene II”?

   A. The Mousetrap

   B. The court of Denmark

   C. Fortinbras's army

   D. Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return

SAT key: 1. B (careful; watchful); 2. A (The Mousetrap)

Lesson 12: Act III, Scene III

Focus: Claudius at prayer

Teacher only · spoilers

Claudius orders Hamlet sent to England. Alone, he confesses his crime but cannot truly repent. Hamlet finds him kneeling and refuses to kill him while praying, for fear of sending him to heaven. Claudius rises: his words were empty.

Background: Belief that dying in prayer meant salvation.

Significance: A key moment of delay.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Is it ever wrong to wait? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to revenge and justice because....
Prompt: Is it ever wrong to wait?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to revenge and justice because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: Hamlet wants damnation.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: prolongs — delays; extends; forestalled — prevented beforehand; fetters — chains for the feet; stubborn — unbending; cutpurse — a thief; pickpocket.
Words: prolongs: delays; extends · forestalled: prevented beforehand · fetters: chains for the feet · stubborn: unbending · cutpurse: a thief; pickpocket

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Belief that dying in prayer meant salvation. A key moment of delay. Characterization: Claudius's confession and prayer. Irony: Hamlet spares him because he seems to pray. Structure: soliloquies of both. Watch for disease and rot: Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: "Thanks, dear my lord. Exit Polonius. / O, my offence is rank, it smells to heaven; / It hath the primal eldest curse upon't" (Act III, Scene III, King (speech 7)).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. “O, my offence is rank, it smells to heaven” (Act III, Scene III, King (speech 7)). Claudius confesses. That is characterization at work: Claudius's confession and prayer.

> *O, my offence is rank, it smells to heaven* (Act III, Scene III, King (speech 7))

Think-aloud: I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. “O, my offence is rank, it smells to heaven” (Act III, Scene III, King (speech 7)). Claudius confesses. That is characterization at work: Claudius's confession and prayer.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Hamlet's chance. Look at the craft: Hamlet spares him because he seems to pray. Ask: How does this line connect to revenge and justice? Expected: Hamlet wants damnation. (Hamlet's chance.)

> *Now might I do it pat, now he is praying* (Act III, Scene III, Hamlet (speech 8))

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Hamlet's chance. Look at the craft: Hamlet spares him because he seems to pray.
Ask: How does this line connect to revenge and justice?
Expected answer: Hamlet wants damnation. (Hamlet's chance.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the scene for characterization, irony (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Claudius at prayer? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act III, Scene III develops the idea of Claudius at prayer. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and irony shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. When the text says “My words fly up, my thoughts remain below” (Act III, Scene III, King (speech 9)), it shows this directly. Claudius admits "my offence is rank," Hamlet hesitates ("Now might I do it pat, now he is praying"), but Claudius admits "My words fly up, my thoughts remain below."
Task: Annotate the scene for characterization, irony (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Claudius at prayer? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act III, Scene III develops the idea of Claudius at prayer. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and irony shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. When the text says “My words fly up, my thoughts remain below” (Act III, Scene III, King (speech 9)), it shows this directly. Claudius admits "my offence is rank," Hamlet hesitates ("Now might I do it pat, now he is praying"), but Claudius admits "My words fly up, my thoughts remain below."

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: Is it ever wrong to wait? Is Hamlet's reason for delay convincing?
Anchor question: Is it ever wrong to wait?
Facilitation: Is Hamlet's reason for delay convincing?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Claudius at prayer? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. (“My words fly up, my thoughts remain below”, Act III, Scene III, King (speech 9)). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Claudius at prayer? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. (“My words fly up, my thoughts remain below”, Act III, Scene III, King (speech 9)). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how characterization shapes Claudius at prayer. Key takeaway: Hamlet wants damnation.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Characterization:** Claudius's confession and prayer.
- **Irony:** Hamlet spares him because he seems to pray.
- **Structure:** soliloquies of both.

Themes and how they develop

- **revenge and justice:** Hamlet wants damnation.

Symbols and motifs

- **disease and rot:** Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: “Thanks, dear my lord. Exit Polonius. / O, my offence is rank, it smells to heaven; / It hath the primal eldest curse upon’t” (Act III, Scene III, King (speech 7)).
- **acting and seeming:** "Seems, madam! nay it is": performance, the players, feigned madness and the Mousetrap. In this scene: “pleasure of his bed; / At gaming, swearing, or about some act / That has no relish of salvation in’t; / Then trip him, that” (Act III, Scene III, Hamlet (speech 8)).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- "O, my offence is rank, it smells to heaven" (Act III, Scene III, King (speech 7)) Claudius confesses.
- "Now might I do it pat, now he is praying" (Act III, Scene III, Hamlet (speech 8)) Hamlet's chance.
- "My words fly up, my thoughts remain below" (Act III, Scene III, King (speech 9)) Claudius cannot pray.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading.
Evidence: "My words fly up, my thoughts remain below" (Act III, Scene III, King (speech 9))
Reasoning: Claudius admits "my offence is rank," Hamlet hesitates ("Now might I do it pat, now he is praying"), but Claudius admits "My words fly up, my thoughts remain below."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
prolongs (verb)	delays; extends	*My mother stays: This physic but prolongs thy sickly days.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
forestalled (verb)	prevented beforehand	*And what's in prayer but this two-fold force, To be forestalled ere we come to fall, Or pardon'd being down?*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
fetters (noun)	chains for the feet	*Arm you, I pray you, to this speedy voyage; For we will fetters put upon this fear, Which now goes too free-footed.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
stubborn (adjective)	unbending	*Bow, stubborn knees; and, heart with strings of steel, Be soft as sinews of the newborn babe!*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
cutpurse (noun)	a thief; pickpocket	*A murderer and a villain; A slave that is not twentieth part the tithe Of your precedent lord; a vice of kings; A cutpurse of the empire and the rule, That from a shelf the precious diadem stole, And put it in his pocket!*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
bodiless (adjective)	without a body; imagined	*This the very coinage of your brain: This bodiless creation ecstasy Is very cunning in.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
easiness (noun)	an easygoing, relaxed manner	*Refrain to-night, And that shall lend a kind of easiness To the next abstinence: the next more easy; For use almost can change the stamp of nature, And either master the devil, or throw him out With wondrous potency.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
prating (adjective)	chattering	*Indeed this counsellor Is now most still, most secret and most grave, Who was in life a foolish prating knave.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. Is it ever wrong to wait?
2. Where does characterization appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with revenge and justice?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What does Claudius call his offence? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Rank; it smells to heaven.
2. What does Claudius try to do? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Pray
3. Why does Hamlet not kill him? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: He might go to heaven
4. What does Claudius admit? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Murdering his brother
5. Can Claudius repent? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: No, he will not give up his gains
6. Where is Hamlet going next? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: To his mother
7. Retell the three most important events of "Act III, Scene III" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Claudius orders Hamlet sent to England. Alone, he confesses his crime but cannot truly repent. Hamlet finds him kneeling and refuses to kill him while praying, for fear of sending him to heaven. Claudius rises: his words were empty.
8. Who is on stage in "Act III, Scene III", and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does "Act III, Scene III" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: "My mother stays: This physic but prolongs thy sickly days." What does "prolongs" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: prolongs: delays; extends.

Inferential / analytical

1. Why is Hamlet's reasoning ironic? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Claudius was not truly praying.

2. What does "Act III, Scene III" suggest about Claudius at prayer? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A key moment of delay.
3. Find one example of characterization in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
4. How does the irony in this scene shape what we understand about Claudius at prayer? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.6] Look for: Look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. Useful evidence: "O, my offence is rank, it smells to heaven" (Act III, Scene III, King (speech 7)): Claudius confesses. On irony: Hamlet spares him because he seems to pray. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. In the passage that begins "I like him not, nor stands it safe with us To let his madness range.", why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in "Act III, Scene III", and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Claudius orders Hamlet sent to England. Alone, he confesses his crime but cannot truly repent. Hamlet finds him kneeling and refuses to kill him while praying, for fear of sending him to heaven. Claudius rises: his words were empty.
7. How does "Act III, Scene III" build on "Act III, Scene II"? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. Useful evidence: "Now might I do it pat, now he is praying" (Act III, Scene III, Hamlet (speech 8)): Hamlet's chance. On structure: soliloquies of both. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. Useful evidence: "My words fly up, my thoughts remain below" (Act III, Scene III, King (speech 9)): Claudius cannot pray. On characterization: Claudius's confession and prayer. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. The bell-ringer asked: "Is it ever wrong to wait?" Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does structure appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with revenge and justice? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: Look for how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. Useful evidence: "O, my offence is rank, it smells to heaven" (Act III, Scene III, King (speech 7)): Claudius confesses. On structure: soliloquies of both. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Is Hamlet's reason a pretext? [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A judgment.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. Useful evidence: “Now might I do it pat, now he is praying” (Act III, Scene III, Hamlet (speech 8)): Hamlet's chance. Theme link: Hamlet wants damnation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: “A key moment of delay.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. Useful evidence: “My words fly up, my thoughts remain below” (Act III, Scene III, King (speech 9)): Claudius cannot pray. Theme link: Hamlet wants damnation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. Useful evidence: “O, my offence is rank, it smells to heaven” (Act III, Scene III, King (speech 7)): Claudius confesses. On characterization: Claudius's confession and prayer. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. You are directing “Act III, Scene III”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of Claudius at prayer. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. Useful evidence: “Now might I do it pat, now he is praying” (Act III, Scene III, Hamlet (speech 8)): Hamlet's chance. On structure: soliloquies of both. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. Write three questions of your own about “Act III, Scene III”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. Useful evidence: “My words fly up, my thoughts remain below” (Act III, Scene III, King (speech 9)): Claudius cannot pray. Theme link: Hamlet wants damnation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
6. Connect this scene to action and delay: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. Useful evidence: “O, my offence is rank, it smells to heaven” (Act III, Scene III, King (speech 7)): Claudius confesses. Theme link: Hamlet wants damnation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. Is the characterization in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. Useful evidence: “Now might I do it pat, now he is praying” (Act III, Scene III, Hamlet (speech 8)): Hamlet's chance. On characterization: Claudius's confession and prayer. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. Compare how “Act III, Scene III” treats Claudius at prayer with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. Useful evidence: “My words fly up, my thoughts remain below” (Act III, Scene III, King (speech 9)): Claudius cannot pray. Theme link: Hamlet wants damnation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Predict what “Act III, Scene IV” will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. Useful evidence: “O, my offence is rank, it smells to heaven” (Act III, Scene III, King (speech 7)): Claudius confesses. Theme link: Hamlet wants damnation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about Claudius at prayer? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's delay rests on a misreading. Useful evidence: “Now might I do it pat, now he is praying” (Act III, Scene III, Hamlet (speech 8)): Hamlet's chance. Theme link: Hamlet wants damnation. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Characterization:** look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Irony**: gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true
- Also notice **Structure**: how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does

Chapter quiz

1. What does Claudius try to do?
   A. Pray
   B. Escape
   C. Fight
   D. Sleep
2. Why does Hamlet not kill him?
   A. Gertrude enters
   B. He might go to heaven
   C. Hamlet is afraid

D. He is guarded

3. What does Claudius admit?
   A. Loving Ophelia
   B. Nothing
   C. Murdering his brother
   D. Fearing Norway
4. Can Claudius repent?
   A. He refuses to try
   B. He tries and succeeds
   C. No, he will not give up his gains
   D. Yes
5. Where is Hamlet going next?
   A. To England
   B. To Ophelia
   C. To his mother
   D. To the players
6. In the line "My mother stays: This physic but prolongs thy sickly days.", what does "prolongs" most nearly mean?
   A. prevented beforehand
   B. chains for the feet
   C. unbending
   D. delays; extends
7. In the line "And what's in prayer but this two-fold force, To be forestalled ere we come to fall, Or pardon'd being down?", what does "forestalled" most nearly mean?
   A. unbending
   B. delays; extends
   C. chains for the feet
   D. prevented beforehand

Answer key: 1. A (Pray); 2. B (He might go to heaven); 3. C (Murdering his brother); 4. C (No, he will not give up his gains); 5. C (To his mother); 6. D (delays; extends); 7. D (prevented beforehand)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.3, W.7.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this play is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In "Act III, Scene III," how does Shakespeare show Claudius at prayer? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the characterization you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In Act III, Scene III, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of Claudius at prayer? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the characterization in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act III, Scene III develops the idea of Claudius at prayer. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and irony shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act III, Scene III (where it begins, turns and ends) and its characterization shape the reader's understanding of Claudius at prayer. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act III, Scene III suggests about Claudius at prayer. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's characterization and irony), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses characterization in Act III, Scene III to complicate the reader's understanding of Claudius at prayer. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate Act III, Scene III within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of Claudius at prayer responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read Act III, Scene III alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of Claudius at prayer follows or bends those conventions, using the characterization as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act III, Scene III and its treatment of Claudius at prayer. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's characterization and irony, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads Act III, Scene III as evidence for a larger claim about Claudius at prayer in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads Act III, Scene III as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of Claudius at prayer. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or

postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *Arm you, I pray you, to this speedy voyage; For we will fetters put upon this fear, Which now goes too free-footed.*

   As used in the text, what does the word "fetters" most nearly mean?

   A. chattering
   B. an easygoing, relaxed manner
   C. without a body; imagined
   D. chains for the feet

2. *I like him not, nor stands it safe with us To let his madness range. Therefore prepare you; I your commission will forthwith dispatch, And he to England shall along with you: The terms of our estate may not endure Hazard so dangerous as doth hourly grow Out of his lunacies.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of "Act III, Scene III"?

   A. The Mousetrap
   B. Claudius at prayer
   C. Hamlet's letter from the sea
   D. Worms and kings

SAT key: 1. D (chains for the feet); 2. B (Claudius at prayer)

Lesson 13: Act III, Scene IV

Focus: the closet scene

Content note (killing, violence toward a parent (threatened)): Hamlet frightens his mother and kills Polonius through a curtain. Focus on rashness and responsibility.
Student preview: A man is killed by mistake in this scene.
Suggested language: "Who is responsible for Polonius's death?"

Teacher only · spoilers

Polonius hides behind the arras in Gertrude's room. Hamlet's violence frightens Gertrude; Polonius cries out and Hamlet stabs through the arras, killing him. Hamlet compares portraits of the two kings and condemns Gertrude. The Ghost appears to Hamlet alone. Hamlet urges Gertrude to avoid Claudius's bed, and drags out Polonius's body.

Background: Gertrude's 'closet' was a private room.

Significance: Hamlet finally acts but wrongly.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
What happens when anger takes over? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to corruption and the state because.... Content note before we start: A man is killed by mistake in this scene.
Prompt: What happens when anger takes over?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to corruption and the state because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: Gertrude's guilt.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: cutpurse — a thief; pickpocket; bodiless — without a body; imagined; easiness — an easygoing, relaxed manner; prating — chattering; mandate — a document giving an official instruction or command.
Words: cutpurse: a thief; pickpocket · bodiless: without a body; imagined · easiness: an easygoing, relaxed manner · prating: chattering · mandate: a document giving an official instruction or command

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Gertrude's 'closet' was a private room. Hamlet finally acts but wrongly. Plot: Hamlet kills Polonius behind the arras. Characterization: Hamlet confronts Gertrude. Structure: The Ghost reappears. Watch for disease and rot: Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: "Nay, but to live / In the rank sweat of an enseamed bed, / Stew'd in corruption, honeying and making" (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 30)).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "How now! a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead" (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 17)). Hamlet kills Polonius. That is plot at work: Hamlet kills Polonius behind the arras.

> *How now! a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead* (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 17))

Think-aloud: I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "How now! a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead" (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 17)). Hamlet kills Polonius. That is plot at work: Hamlet kills Polonius behind the arras.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: He calls Polonius a fool who meddled. Expected link: action and delay. Ask: How does this line connect to corruption and the state? Expected: Gertrude's guilt. (Hamlet's epitaph for Polonius.)

> *Thou wretched, rash, intruding fool, farewell* (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 24))

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: He calls Polonius a fool who meddled. Expected link: action and delay.
Ask: How does this line connect to corruption and the state?
Expected answer: Gertrude's guilt. (Hamlet's epitaph for Polonius.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the scene for plot, characterization (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about the closet scene? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act III, Scene IV develops the idea of the closet scene. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of plot and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. When the text says "Thou wretched, rash, intruding fool, farewell" (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 24)), it shows this directly. He stabs at "a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead!" and dismisses Polonius as a "wretched, rash, intruding fool," before making Gertrude cry "O Hamlet, speak no more."
Task: Annotate the scene for plot, characterization (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about the closet scene? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act III, Scene IV develops the idea of the closet scene. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of plot and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. When the text says "Thou wretched, rash, intruding fool, farewell" (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 24)), it shows this directly. He stabs at "a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead!" and dismisses Polonius as a "wretched, rash, intruding fool," before making Gertrude cry "O Hamlet, speak no more."

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: What happens when anger takes over? Is Gertrude guilty?
Anchor question: What happens when anger takes over?
Facilitation: Is Gertrude guilty?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about the closet scene? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. ("Thou wretched, rash, intruding fool, farewell", Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 24)). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about the closet scene? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. ("Thou wretched, rash, intruding fool, farewell", Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 24)). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how plot shapes the closet scene. Key takeaway: Gertrude's guilt.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Plot:** Hamlet kills Polonius behind the arras.
- **Characterization:** Hamlet confronts Gertrude.
- **Structure:** The Ghost reappears.

Themes and how they develop

- **corruption and the state:** Gertrude's guilt.

Symbols and motifs

- **disease and rot:** Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: "Nay, but to live / In the rank sweat of an enseamed bed, / Stew'd in corruption, honeying and making" (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 30)).
- **poison and ears:** Old Hamlet was poisoned through the ear; lies poured into ears, and poison returns at the end. In this scene: "now, what follows: / Here is your husband; like a mildew'd ear, / Blasting his wholesome brother. Have you eyes? / Could you on this" (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 28)).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- "How now! a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead" (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 17)) Hamlet kills Polonius.
- "Thou wretched, rash, intruding fool, farewell" (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 24)) Hamlet's epitaph for Polonius.
- "O Hamlet, speak no more" (Act III, Scene IV, Queen (speech 29)) Gertrude's shame.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man.
Evidence: "Thou wretched, rash, intruding fool, farewell" (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 24))
Reasoning: He stabs at "a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead!" and dismisses Polonius as a "wretched, rash, intruding fool," before making Gertrude cry "O Hamlet, speak no more."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
cutpurse (noun)	a thief; pickpocket	*A murderer and a villain; A slave that is not twentieth part the tithe Of your precedent lord; a vice of kings; A cutpurse of the empire and the rule, That from a shelf the precious diadem stole, And put it in his pocket!*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
bodiless (adjective)	without a body; imagined	*This the very coinage of your brain: This bodiless creation ecstasy Is very cunning in.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
easiness (noun)	an easygoing, relaxed manner	*Refrain to-night, And that shall lend a kind of easiness To the next abstinence: the next more easy; For use almost can change the stamp of nature, And either master the devil, or throw him out With wondrous potency.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
prating (adjective)	chattering	*Indeed this counsellor Is now most still, most secret and most grave, Who was in life a foolish prating knave.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
mandate (noun)	a document giving an official instruction or command	*There's letters seal'd: and my two schoolfellows, Whom I will trust as I will adders fang'd, They bear the mandate; they must sweep my way, And marshal me to knavery.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
intruding (verb)	coming in where one is not wanted	*Thou wretched, rash, intruding fool, farewell!*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
trespass (verb)	to take advantage of; to intrude on	*Mother, for love of grace, Lay not that flattering unction to your soul, That not your trespass, but my madness speaks: It will but skin and film the ulcerous place, Whilst rank corruption, mining all within, Infects unseen.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
	deliver a sermon		

preaching (verb)		*His form and cause conjoin'd, preaching to stones, Would make them capable.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
secrecy (noun)	the trait of keeping things secret	*No, in despite of sense and secrecy, Unpeg the basket on the house's top, Let the birds fly, and, like the famous ape, To try conclusions, in the basket creep, And break your own neck down.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
ecstasy (noun)	madness; frenzy	*Sense, sure, you have, Else could you not have motion; but sure, that sense Is apoplex'd; for madness would not err, Nor sense to ecstasy was ne'er so thrall'd But it reserved some quantity of choice, To serve in such a difference.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. What happens when anger takes over?
2. Where does plot appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with action and delay?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What does Hamlet think Polonius is at first? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: A rat, or the king.
2. Where does Polonius hide? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Behind the arras
3. Whom does Hamlet kill? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Polonius
4. What does Hamlet compare? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Two portraits
5. Who sees the Ghost this time? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Only Hamlet
6. What does Hamlet urge Gertrude? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Avoid Claudius's bed
7. Retell the three most important events of "Act III, Scene IV" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Polonius hides behind the arras in Gertrude's room. Hamlet's violence frightens Gertrude; Polonius cries out and Hamlet stabs through the arras, killing him. Hamlet compares portraits of the two kings and condemns Gertrude. The Ghost appears to Hamlet alone. Hamlet urges Gertrude to avoid Claudius's bed, and drags out Polonius's body.
8. Who is on stage in "Act III, Scene IV", and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.

9. Where and when does “Act III, Scene IV” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: “A murderer and a villain; A slave that is not twentieth part the tithe Of your precedent lord; a vice of kings; A cutpurse of the empire and the rule, That from a shelf the precious diadem stole, And put it in his…” What does “cutpurse” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: cutpurse: a thief; pickpocket.

Inferential / analytical

1. Why can't Gertrude see the Ghost? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: It may be Hamlet's mind or the Ghost's choice.
2. What does “Act III, Scene IV” suggest about the closet scene? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: Hamlet finally acts but wrongly.
3. Find one example of plot in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Look for key events and the causes linking them.
4. How does the characterization in this scene shape what we understand about the closet scene? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. Useful evidence: “How now! a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 17)): Hamlet kills Polonius. On characterization: Hamlet confronts Gertrude. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. In the passage that begins “Ay, lady, ’twas my word.”, why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in “Act III, Scene IV”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Polonius hides behind the arras in Gertrude's room. Hamlet's violence frightens Gertrude; Polonius cries out and Hamlet stabs through the arras, killing him. Hamlet compares portraits of the two kings and condemns Gertrude. The Ghost appears to Hamlet alone. Hamlet urges Gertrude to avoid…
7. How does “Act III, Scene IV” build on “Act III, Scene III”? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. Useful evidence: “Thou wretched, rash, intruding fool, farewell” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 24)): Hamlet's epitaph for Polonius. On structure: The Ghost reappears. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. Useful evidence: “O Hamlet, speak no more” (Act III, Scene IV, Queen (speech 29)): Gertrude's shame. On characterization: Hamlet confronts Gertrude. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. The bell-ringer asked: “What happens when anger takes over?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does structure appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with action and delay? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: Look for how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. Useful evidence: “How now! a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 17)): Hamlet kills Polonius. On structure: The Ghost reappears. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Is Gertrude guilty of Claudius's crime? [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A reasoned view.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. Useful evidence: “Thou wretched, rash, intruding fool, farewell” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 24)): Hamlet's epitaph for Polonius. Theme link: Gertrude's guilt. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: “Hamlet finally acts but wrongly.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. Useful evidence: “O Hamlet, speak no more” (Act III, Scene IV, Queen (speech 29)): Gertrude's shame. Theme link: Gertrude's guilt. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. Useful evidence: “How now! a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 17)): Hamlet kills Polonius. On characterization: Hamlet confronts Gertrude. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. You are directing “Act III, Scene IV”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of the closet scene. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. Useful evidence: “Thou wretched, rash, intruding fool, farewell” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 24)): Hamlet's epitaph for Polonius. On structure: The Ghost reappears. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. Write three questions of your own about “Act III, Scene IV”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. Useful evidence: “O Hamlet, speak no more” (Act III, Scene IV, Queen (speech 29)): Gertrude's shame.

Theme link: Gertrude's guilt. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Connect this scene to appearance and reality: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. Useful evidence: “How now! a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 17)): Hamlet kills Polonius. Theme link: Gertrude's guilt. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. Is the plot in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. Useful evidence: “Thou wretched, rash, intruding fool, farewell” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 24)): Hamlet's epitaph for Polonius. On plot: Hamlet kills Polonius behind the arras. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. Compare how “Act III, Scene IV” treats the closet scene with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. Useful evidence: “O Hamlet, speak no more” (Act III, Scene IV, Queen (speech 29)): Gertrude's shame. Theme link: Gertrude's guilt. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. Predict what “Act IV, Scene I” will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. Useful evidence: “How now! a rat? Dead, for a ducat, dead” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 17)): Hamlet kills Polonius. Theme link: Gertrude's guilt. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about the closet scene? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet acts rashly at last but kills the wrong man. Useful evidence: “Thou wretched, rash, intruding fool, farewell” (Act III, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 24)): Hamlet's epitaph for Polonius. Theme link: Gertrude's guilt. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Plot:** look for key events and the causes linking them (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Characterization**: what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them
- Also notice **Structure**: how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does

Chapter quiz

1. Where does Polonius hide?
   A. Behind the arras
   B. In the hall
   C. Under the bed
   D. In a closet
2. Whom does Hamlet kill?
   A. Rosencrantz
   B. Polonius
   C. Claudius
   D. Laertes
3. What does Hamlet compare?
   A. Two crowns
   B. Two swords
   C. Two letters
   D. Two portraits
4. Who sees the Ghost this time?
   A. Only Hamlet
   B. Both
   C. Gertrude
   D. Polonius
5. What does Hamlet urge Gertrude?
   A. Confess publicly
   B. Kill Claudius
   C. Avoid Claudius's bed
   D. Leave Denmark
6. In the line "A murderer and a villain; A slave that is not twentieth part the tithe Of your precedent lord; a vice of kings; A cutpurse of the empire and the rule, That from a shelf the precious diadem stole, And put it in his pocket!", what does "cutpurse" most nearly mean?
   A. without a body; imagined
   B. a thief; pickpocket
   C. chattering
   D. an easygoing, relaxed manner
7. In the line "This the very coinage of your brain: This bodiless creation ecstasy Is very cunning in.", what does "bodiless" most nearly mean?
   A. without a body; imagined
   B. an easygoing, relaxed manner
   C. chattering
   D. a thief; pickpocket

Answer key: 1. A (Behind the arras); 2. B (Polonius); 3. D (Two portraits); 4. A (Only Hamlet); 5. C (Avoid Claudius's bed); 6. B (a thief; pickpocket); 7. A (without a body; imagined)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.3, W.7.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this play is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In "Act III, Scene IV," how does Shakespeare show the closet scene? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the plot you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In Act III, Scene IV, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of the closet scene? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the plot in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act III, Scene IV develops the idea of the closet scene. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of plot and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act III, Scene IV (where it begins, turns and ends) and its plot shape the reader's understanding of the closet scene. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act III, Scene IV suggests about the closet scene. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's plot and characterization), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses plot in Act III, Scene IV to complicate the reader's understanding of the closet scene. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate Act III, Scene IV within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of the closet scene responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read Act III, Scene IV alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of the closet scene follows or bends those conventions, using the plot as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act III, Scene IV and its treatment

of the closet scene. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's plot and characterization, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads Act III, Scene IV as evidence for a larger claim about the closet scene in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads Act III, Scene IV as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of the closet scene. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *Refrain to-night, And that shall lend a kind of easiness To the next abstinence: the next more easy; For use almost can change the stamp of nature, And either master the devil, or throw him out With wondrous potency.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “easiness” most nearly mean?

   A. the trait of keeping things secret

   B. madness; frenzy

   C. deliver a sermon

   D. an easygoing, relaxed manner

2. *Ay, lady, 'twas my word. Lifts up the arras and discovers Polonius. Thou wretched, rash, intruding fool, farewell! I took thee for thy better: take thy fortune; Thou find'st to be too busy is some danger. Leave wringing of your hands: peace! sit you down, And let me wring your heart; for so I shall, If it be made of penetrable stuff, If damned custom have not brass'd it so That it be proof and bulwark against sense.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “Act III, Scene IV”?

   A. Claudius at prayer

   B. The closet scene

   C. The Ghost on the battlements

   D. Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief

SAT key: 1. D (an easygoing, relaxed manner); 2. B (The closet scene)

Lesson 14: Act IV, Scene I

Focus: Claudius hears of Polonius's death

Teacher only · spoilers

Gertrude tells Claudius that Hamlet, mad, killed Polonius. Claudius realizes it could have been him and resolves to ship Hamlet away at once, and to manage public opinion.

Background: Kings feared public unrest.

Significance: Claudius's self-interest.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
How do leaders handle bad news? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to corruption and the state because....
Prompt: How do leaders handle bad news?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to corruption and the state because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: Claudius worries about public opinion.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: mineral — a mine of ore; lawless — uncontrolled; discord — conflict; distress; apprehension — fear; perception; knavish — villainous; sly.
Words: mineral: a mine of ore · lawless: uncontrolled · discord: conflict; distress · apprehension: fear; perception · knavish: villainous; sly

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Kings feared public unrest. Claudius's self-interest. Characterization: Gertrude reports Hamlet's madness. Plot: Claudius plans to send Hamlet away. Diction / vocabulary: "Mad as the sea and wind." Watch for disease and rot: Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: "was most fit; / But, like the owner of a foul disease, / To keep it from divulging, let it feed / Even on the" (Act IV, Scene I, King (speech 5)).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "Mad as the sea and wind, when both contend / Which is the mightier" (Act IV, Scene I, Queen (speech 4)). Gertrude's description. That is characterization at work: Gertrude reports Hamlet's madness.

> *Mad as the sea and wind, when both contend / Which is the mightier* (Act IV, Scene I, Queen (speech 4))

Think-aloud: I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "Mad as the sea and wind, when both contend / Which is the mightier" (Act IV, Scene I, Queen (speech 4)). Gertrude's description. That is characterization at work: Gertrude reports Hamlet's madness.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Claudius's anxiety. Look at the craft: Claudius plans to send Hamlet away. Ask: How does this line connect to corruption and the state? Expected: Claudius worries about public opinion. (Claudius's anxiety.)

> *My soul is full of discord and dismay* (Act IV, Scene I, speech (speech 7))

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Claudius's anxiety. Look at the craft: Claudius plans to send Hamlet away.
Ask: How does this line connect to corruption and the state?
Expected answer: Claudius worries about public opinion. (Claudius's anxiety.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the scene for characterization, plot (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Claudius hears of Polonius's death? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act IV, Scene I develops the idea of Claudius hears of Polonius's death. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and plot shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. When the text says "My soul is full of discord and dismay" (Act IV, Scene I, speech (speech 7)), it shows this directly. Gertrude describes Hamlet "Mad as the sea and wind," and Claudius admits "My soul is full of discord and dismay."
Task: Annotate the scene for characterization, plot (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Claudius hears of Polonius's death? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act IV, Scene I develops the idea of Claudius hears of Polonius's death. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and plot shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. When the text says "My soul is full of discord and dismay" (Act IV, Scene I, speech (speech 7)), it shows this directly. Gertrude describes Hamlet "Mad as the sea and wind," and Claudius admits "My soul is full of discord and dismay."

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: How do leaders handle bad news? Is Gertrude protecting Hamlet?
Anchor question: How do leaders handle bad news?
Facilitation: Is Gertrude protecting Hamlet?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Claudius hears of Polonius's death? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. ("My soul is full of discord and dismay", Act IV, Scene I, speech (speech 7)). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Claudius hears of Polonius's death? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. ("My soul is full of discord and dismay", Act IV, Scene I, speech (speech 7)). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how characterization shapes Claudius hears of Polonius's death. Key takeaway: Claudius worries about public opinion.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Characterization:** Gertrude reports Hamlet's madness.
- **Plot:** Claudius plans to send Hamlet away.
- **Diction / vocabulary:** "Mad as the sea and wind."

Themes and how they develop

- **corruption and the state:** Claudius worries about public opinion.

Symbols and motifs

- **disease and rot:** Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: "was most fit; / But, like the owner of a foul disease, / To keep it from divulging, let it feed / Even on the" (Act IV, Scene I, King (speech 5)).
- **poison and ears:** Old Hamlet was poisoned through the ear; lies poured into ears, and poison returns at the end. In this scene: "As level as the canon to his blank, / Transports his poison'd shot, may miss our name, / And hit the woundless air. O" (Act IV, Scene I, speech (speech 7)).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “Mad as the sea and wind, when both contend / Which is the mightier” (Act IV, Scene I, Queen (speech 4)) Gertrude's description.
- “My soul is full of discord and dismay” (Act IV, Scene I, speech (speech 7)) Claudius's anxiety.
- “Come, Gertrude, we’ll call up our wisest friends” (Act IV, Scene I, speech (speech 7)) Claudius's political move.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety.
Evidence: “My soul is full of discord and dismay” (Act IV, Scene I, speech (speech 7))
Reasoning: Gertrude describes Hamlet "Mad as the sea and wind," and Claudius admits "My soul is full of discord and dismay."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
mineral (noun)	a mine of ore	*To draw apart the body he hath kill’d: O’er whom his very madness, like some ore Among a mineral of metals base, Shows itself pure; he weeps for what is done.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
lawless (adjective)	uncontrolled	*Mad as the sea and wind, when both contend Which is the mightier: in his lawless fit, Behind the arras hearing something stir, Whips out his rapier, cries, “A rat, a rat!”*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
discord (noun)	conflict; distress	*My soul is full of discord and dismay.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
apprehension (noun)	fear; perception	*And, in this brainish apprehension, kills The unseen good old man.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
knavish (adjective)	villainous; sly	*I am glad of it: a knavish speech sleeps in a foolish ear.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
counsel (noun)	secret; private plan	*That I can keep your counsel and not mine own.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
appliance (noun)	remedy	*To bear all smooth and even, This sudden sending him away must seem Deliberate pause: diseases desperate grown By desperate appliance are relieved, Or not at all.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
convocation (noun)	an assembly	*Not where he eats, but where he is eaten: a certain convocation of politic worms are e’en at him.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. How do leaders handle bad news?
2. Where does characterization appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with appearance and reality?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. Whom does Claudius send to find Hamlet? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Rosencrantz and Guildenstern.
2. Who tells Claudius? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Gertrude
3. What does Gertrude say Hamlet is? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Mad
4. What does Claudius fear? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: It could have been him
5. Where will Hamlet be sent? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: England
6. How does Claudius describe his soul? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Full of discord and dismay
7. Retell the three most important events of "Act IV, Scene I" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Gertrude tells Claudius that Hamlet, mad, killed Polonius. Claudius realizes it could have been him and resolves to ship Hamlet away at once, and to manage public opinion.
8. Who is on stage in "Act IV, Scene I", and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does "Act IV, Scene I" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: "To draw apart the body he hath kill'd: O'er whom his very madness, like some ore Among a mineral of metals base, Shows itself pure; he weeps for what is done." What does "mineral" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: mineral: a mine of ore.

Inferential / analytical

1. Is Gertrude protecting Hamlet? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: She describes him as mad.
2. What does "Act IV, Scene I" suggest about Claudius hears of Polonius's death? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: Claudius's self-interest.

3. Find one example of characterization in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
4. How does the plot in this scene shape what we understand about Claudius hears of Polonius's death? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Look for key events and the causes linking them.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. Useful evidence: “Mad as the sea and wind, when both contend / Which is the mightier” (Act IV, Scene I, Queen (speech 4)): Gertrude's description. On plot: Claudius plans to send Hamlet away. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. In the passage that begins “Mad as the sea and wind, when both contend Which is the mightier: in his lawless fit, Behind the arras hearing something stir, Whips out his rapier, cries, “A rat, a rat!””, why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in “Act IV, Scene I”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Gertrude tells Claudius that Hamlet, mad, killed Polonius. Claudius realizes it could have been him and resolves to ship Hamlet away at once, and to manage public opinion.
7. How does “Act IV, Scene I” build on “Act III, Scene IV”? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. Useful evidence: “My soul is full of discord and dismay” (Act IV, Scene I, speech (speech 7)): Claudius's anxiety. Theme link: Claudius worries about public opinion. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. Useful evidence: “Come, Gertrude, we’ll call up our wisest friends” (Act IV, Scene I, speech (speech 7)): Claudius's political move. On characterization: Gertrude reports Hamlet's madness. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. The bell-ringer asked: “How do leaders handle bad news?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does diction / vocabulary appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with appearance and reality? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: Look for precise or unusual word choices and their connotations.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. Useful evidence: “Mad as the sea and wind, when both contend / Which is the mightier” (Act IV, Scene I, Queen (speech 4)): Gertrude's description. On diction / vocabulary: "Mad as the sea and wind." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. What does this show about Claudius as king? [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A judgment.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. Useful evidence: “My soul is full of discord and dismay” (Act IV, Scene I, speech (speech 7)): Claudius's anxiety. Theme link: Claudius worries about public opinion. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: “Claudius's self-interest.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. Useful evidence: “Come, Gertrude, we’ll call up our wisest friends” (Act IV, Scene I, speech (speech 7)): Claudius's political move. Theme link: Claudius worries about public opinion. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. Useful evidence: “Mad as the sea and wind, when both contend / Which is the mightier” (Act IV, Scene I, Queen (speech 4)): Gertrude's description. On characterization: Gertrude reports Hamlet's madness. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. You are directing “Act IV, Scene I”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of Claudius hears of Polonius's death. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. Useful evidence: “My soul is full of discord and dismay” (Act IV, Scene I, speech (speech 7)): Claudius's anxiety. Theme link: Claudius worries about public opinion. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. Write three questions of your own about “Act IV, Scene I”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. Useful evidence: “Come, Gertrude, we’ll call up our wisest friends” (Act IV, Scene I, speech (speech 7)): Claudius's political move. Theme link: Claudius worries about public opinion. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
6. Connect this scene to death and mortality: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. Useful evidence: “Mad as the sea and wind, when both contend / Which is the mightier” (Act IV, Scene I, Queen (speech 4)): Gertrude's description. Theme link: Claudius worries about public opinion. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Is the characterization in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. Useful evidence: “My soul is full of discord and dismay” (Act IV, Scene I, speech (speech 7)): Claudius's anxiety. On characterization: Gertrude reports Hamlet's madness. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. Compare how “Act IV, Scene I” treats Claudius hears of Polonius's death with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. Useful evidence: “Come, Gertrude, we’ll call up our wisest friends” (Act IV, Scene I, speech (speech 7)): Claudius's political move. Theme link: Claudius worries about public opinion. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. Predict what “Act IV, Scene II” will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. Useful evidence: “Mad as the sea and wind, when both contend / Which is the mightier” (Act IV, Scene I, Queen (speech 4)): Gertrude's description. Theme link: Claudius worries about public opinion. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about Claudius hears of Polonius's death? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Claudius's response shows concern for his own safety. Useful evidence: “My soul is full of discord and dismay” (Act IV, Scene I, speech (speech 7)): Claudius's anxiety. Theme link: Claudius worries about public opinion. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Characterization:** look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Plot**: key events and the causes linking them
- Also notice **Diction / vocabulary**: precise or unusual word choices and their connotations

Chapter quiz

1. Who tells Claudius?

   A. Laertes

   B. Rosencrantz

   C. Hamlet

   D. Gertrude

2. What does Gertrude say Hamlet is?
   A. Calm
   B. Asleep
   C. Mad
   D. Guilty
3. What does Claudius fear?
   A. The players
   B. Norway
   C. Laertes
   D. It could have been him
4. Where will Hamlet be sent?
   A. Norway
   B. England
   C. France
   D. Wittenberg
5. How does Claudius describe his soul?
   A. At peace
   B. Empty
   C. Joyful
   D. Full of discord and dismay
6. In the line "To draw apart the body he hath kill'd: O'er whom his very madness, like some ore Among a mineral of metals base, Shows itself pure; he weeps for what is done.", what does "mineral" most nearly mean?
   A. conflict; distress
   B. fear; perception
   C. a mine of ore
   D. uncontrolled
7. In the line "Mad as the sea and wind, when both contend Which is the mightier: in his lawless fit, Behind the arras hearing something stir, Whips out his rapier, cries, "A rat, a rat!"", what does "lawless" most nearly mean?
   A. uncontrolled
   B. a mine of ore
   C. fear; perception
   D. conflict; distress

Answer key: 1. D (Gertrude); 2. C (Mad); 3. D (It could have been him); 4. B (England); 5. D (Full of discord and dismay); 6. C (a mine of ore); 7. A (uncontrolled)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.3, W.7.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this play is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Act IV, Scene I,” how does Shakespeare show Claudius hears of Polonius's death? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the characterization you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In Act IV, Scene I, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of Claudius hears of Polonius's death? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the characterization in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act IV, Scene I develops the idea of Claudius hears of Polonius's death. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and plot shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act IV, Scene I (where it begins, turns and ends) and its characterization shape the reader's understanding of Claudius hears of Polonius's death. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act IV, Scene I suggests about Claudius hears of Polonius's death. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's characterization and plot), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses characterization in Act IV, Scene I to complicate the reader's understanding of Claudius hears of Polonius's death. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate Act IV, Scene I within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of Claudius hears of Polonius's death responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read Act IV, Scene I alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of Claudius hears of Polonius's death follows or bends those conventions, using the characterization as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act IV, Scene I and its treatment of Claudius hears of Polonius's death. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's characterization and plot, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads Act IV, Scene I as evidence for a larger claim about Claudius hears of Polonius's death in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads Act IV, Scene I as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of Claudius hears of Polonius's death. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *My soul is full of discord and dismay.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “discord” most nearly mean?

   A. an assembly

   B. remedy

   C. conflict; distress

   D. secret; private plan

2. *Mad as the sea and wind, when both contend Which is the mightier: in his lawless fit, Behind the arras hearing something stir, Whips out his rapier, cries, “A rat, a rat!” And, in this brainish apprehension, kills The unseen good old man.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “Act IV, Scene I”?

   A. Hamlet sees the Ghost

   B. Hamlet hides the body

   C. Claudius hears of Polonius's death

   D. Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia

SAT key: 1. C (conflict; distress); 2. C (Claudius hears of Polonius's death)

Lesson 15: Act IV, Scene II

Focus: Hamlet hides the body

Teacher only · spoilers

Rosencrantz and Guildenstern ask Hamlet where the body is. He mocks Rosencrantz as a sponge and answers in riddles, then runs off.

Background: Sponges soak and are squeezed dry.

Significance: Hamlet's wit as weapon.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Why use riddles? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to corruption and the state because....
Prompt: Why use riddles?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to corruption and the state because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: the courtiers serve the king.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: knavish — villainous; sly; counsel — secret; private plan; appliance — remedy; convocation — an assembly; imposthume — an abscess; internal swelling.
Words: knavish: villainous; sly · counsel: secret; private plan · appliance: remedy · convocation: an assembly · imposthume: an abscess; internal swelling

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Sponges soak and are squeezed dry. Hamlet's wit as weapon. Characterization: Hamlet mocks Rosencrantz as a sponge. Diction / vocabulary: "The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body." Plot: Hamlet hides the body. Watch for poison and ears: Old Hamlet was poisoned through the ear; lies poured into ears, and poison returns at the end. In this scene: "glad of it: a knavish speech sleeps in a foolish ear" (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 13)).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "Ay, sir, that soaks up the king's countenance" (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 11)). Rosencrantz as sponge. That is characterization at work: Hamlet mocks Rosencrantz as a sponge.

> *Ay, sir, that soaks up the king's countenance (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 11))*

Think-aloud: I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "Ay, sir, that soaks up the king's countenance" (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 11)). Rosencrantz as sponge. That is characterization at work: Hamlet mocks Rosencrantz as a sponge.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Rosencrantz absorbs the king's favour and will be squeezed dry. Expected link: corruption. Ask: How does this line connect to corruption and the state? Expected: The courtiers serve the king. (Riddle.)

> *The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 15))*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Rosencrantz absorbs the king's favour and will be squeezed dry. Expected link: corruption.
Ask: How does this line connect to corruption and the state?
Expected answer: The courtiers serve the king. (Riddle.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the scene for characterization, diction / vocabulary (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Hamlet hides the body? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act IV, Scene II develops the idea of Hamlet hides the body. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and diction / vocabulary shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Hamlet exposes Rosencrantz as a tool. When the text says "The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body" (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 15)), it shows this directly. He calls him a sponge "that soaks up the king's countenance" and riddles "The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body."
Task: Annotate the scene for characterization, diction / vocabulary (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Hamlet hides the body? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act IV, Scene II develops the idea of Hamlet hides the body. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and diction / vocabulary shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Hamlet exposes Rosencrantz as a tool. When the text says "The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body" (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 15)), it shows this directly. He calls him a sponge "that soaks up the king's countenance" and riddles "The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body."

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: Why use riddles? Why the riddles?
Anchor question: Why use riddles?
Facilitation: Why the riddles?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Hamlet hides the body? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Hamlet exposes Rosencrantz as a tool. ("The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body", Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 15)). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Hamlet hides the body? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Hamlet exposes Rosencrantz as a tool. ("The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body", Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 15)). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how characterization shapes Hamlet hides the body. Key takeaway: the courtiers serve the king.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Characterization:** Hamlet mocks Rosencrantz as a sponge.
- **Diction / vocabulary:** "The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body."
- **Plot:** Hamlet hides the body.

Themes and how they develop

- **corruption and the state:** the courtiers serve the king.

Symbols and motifs

- **poison and ears:** Old Hamlet was poisoned through the ear; lies poured into ears, and poison returns at the end. In this scene: “glad of it: a knavish speech sleeps in a foolish ear” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 13)).
- **death and the grave:** skulls, worms and dust: what all bodies come to. In this scene: “What have you done, my lord, with the dead body” (Act IV, Scene II, Rosencrantz (speech 4)).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “Ay, sir, that soaks up the king’s countenance” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 11)) Rosencrantz as sponge.
- “The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 15)) Riddle.
- “Hide fox, and all after” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 17)) Hamlet runs.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Hamlet exposes Rosencrantz as a tool.
Evidence: “The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body” (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 15))
Reasoning: He calls him a sponge "that soaks up the king's countenance" and riddles "The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
knavish (adjective)	villainous; sly	*I am glad of it: a knavish speech sleeps in a foolish ear.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
counsel (noun)	secret; private plan	*That I can keep your counsel and not mine own.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
appliance (noun)	remedy	*To bear all smooth and even, This sudden sending him away must seem Deliberate pause: diseases desperate grown By desperate appliance are relieved, Or not at all.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

convocation (noun)	an assembly	*Not where he eats, but where he is eaten: a certain convocation of politic worms are e'en at him.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
imposthume (noun)	an abscess; internal swelling	*Two thousand souls and twenty thousand ducats Will not debate the question of this straw: This is the imposthume of much wealth and peace, That inward breaks, and shows no cause without Why the man dies.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
nephews (noun)	sons of one's brother or sister	*The nephews to old Norway, Fortinbras.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
oblivion (noun)	forgetfulness	*Now, whether it be Bestial oblivion, or some craven scruple Of thinking too precisely on the event, A thought which, quarter'd, hath but one part wisdom And ever three parts coward, I do not know Why yet I live to say "This thing's to do;"*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
scruple (verb)	to hesitate because of moral doubt	*Now, whether it be Bestial oblivion, or some craven scruple Of thinking too precisely on the event, A thought which, quarter'd, hath but one part wisdom And ever three parts coward, I do not know Why yet I live to say "This thing's to do;"*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. Why use riddles?
2. Where does characterization appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with death and mortality?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What does Hamlet say about the body and king? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body.
2. Who asks where the body is? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Rosencrantz and Guildenstern
3. What does Hamlet call Rosencrantz? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: A sponge
4. How does Hamlet answer? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: In riddles

5. What does Hamlet do at the end? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Runs off
6. Whose favour does the sponge soak up? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: The king's
7. Retell the three most important events of "Act IV, Scene II" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Rosencrantz and Guildenstern ask Hamlet where the body is. He mocks Rosencrantz as a sponge and answers in riddles, then runs off.
8. Who is on stage in "Act IV, Scene II", and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does "Act IV, Scene II" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: "I am glad of it: a knavish speech sleeps in a foolish ear." What does "knavish" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: knavish: villainous; sly.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does the sponge image mean? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Courtiers are used and discarded.
2. What does "Act IV, Scene II" suggest about Hamlet hides the body? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: Hamlet's wit as weapon.
3. Find one example of characterization in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
4. How does the diction / vocabulary in this scene shape what we understand about Hamlet hides the body? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: Look for precise or unusual word choices and their connotations.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet exposes Rosencrantz as a tool. Useful evidence: "Ay, sir, that soaks up the king's countenance" (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 11)): Rosencrantz as sponge. On diction / vocabulary: "The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. In the passage that begins "Ay, sir, that soaks up the king's countenance, his rewards, his authorities.", why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in "Act IV, Scene II", and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Rosencrantz and Guildenstern ask Hamlet where the body is. He mocks Rosencrantz as a sponge and answers in riddles, then runs off.
7. How does "Act IV, Scene II" build on "Act IV, Scene I"? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet exposes Rosencrantz as a tool. Useful evidence:

"The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body" (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 15)): Riddle. Theme link: the courtiers serve the king. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet exposes Rosencrantz as a tool. Useful evidence: "Hide fox, and all after" (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 17)): Hamlet runs. On characterization: Hamlet mocks Rosencrantz as a sponge. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. The bell-ringer asked: "Why use riddles?" Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does plot appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with death and mortality? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Look for key events and the causes linking them.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet exposes Rosencrantz as a tool. Useful evidence: "Ay, sir, that soaks up the king's countenance" (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 11)): Rosencrantz as sponge. On plot: Hamlet hides the body. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Is Hamlet mad here? [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A reasoned view.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet exposes Rosencrantz as a tool. Useful evidence: "The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body" (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 15)): Riddle. Theme link: the courtiers serve the king. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: "Hamlet's wit as weapon." How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet exposes Rosencrantz as a tool. Useful evidence: "Hide fox, and all after" (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 17)): Hamlet runs. Theme link: the courtiers serve the king. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet exposes Rosencrantz as a tool. Useful evidence: "Ay, sir, that soaks up the king's countenance" (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 11)): Rosencrantz as sponge. On characterization: Hamlet mocks Rosencrantz as a sponge. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. You are directing "Act IV, Scene II". Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of Hamlet hides the body. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet exposes Rosencrantz as a tool. Useful evidence: "The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body" (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 15)): Riddle. Theme link: the courtiers serve the king. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. Write three questions of your own about "Act IV, Scene II": one recall, one "why/how", and one "should/what if". Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet exposes Rosencrantz as a tool. Useful evidence: "Hide fox, and all after" (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 17)): Hamlet runs. Theme link: the courtiers serve the king. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Connect this scene to corruption and the state: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet exposes Rosencrantz as a tool. Useful evidence: "Ay, sir, that soaks up the king's countenance" (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 11)): Rosencrantz as sponge. Theme link: the courtiers serve the king. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Is the characterization in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet exposes Rosencrantz as a tool. Useful evidence: "The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body" (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 15)): Riddle. On characterization: Hamlet mocks Rosencrantz as a sponge. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. Compare how "Act IV, Scene II" treats Hamlet hides the body with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet exposes Rosencrantz as a tool. Useful evidence: "Hide fox, and all after" (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 17)): Hamlet runs. Theme link: the courtiers serve the king. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Predict what "Act IV, Scene III" will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet exposes Rosencrantz as a tool. Useful evidence: "Ay, sir, that soaks up the king's countenance" (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 11)): Rosencrantz as sponge. Theme link: the courtiers serve the king. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about Hamlet hides the body? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet exposes Rosencrantz as a tool. Useful evidence:

"The body is with the king, but the king is not with the body" (Act IV, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 15)): Riddle. Theme link: the courtiers serve the king. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Characterization:** look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Diction / vocabulary**: precise or unusual word choices and their connotations
- Also notice **Plot**: key events and the causes linking them

Chapter quiz

1. Who asks where the body is?
   A. Horatio
   B. Claudius
   C. Rosencrantz and Guildenstern
   D. Gertrude
2. What does Hamlet call Rosencrantz?
   A. A sponge
   B. A friend
   C. A fool
   D. A rat
3. How does Hamlet answer?
   A. With a letter
   B. Silently
   C. In riddles
   D. Directly
4. What does Hamlet do at the end?
   A. Fights
   B. Weeps
   C. Runs off
   D. Confesses
5. Whose favour does the sponge soak up?
   A. Hamlet's
   B. The king's
   C. Gertrude's
   D. Polonius's
6. In the line "I am glad of it: a knavish speech sleeps in a foolish ear.", what does "knavish" most nearly mean?
   A. villainous; sly
   B. remedy

C. secret; private plan

D. an assembly

7. In the line “That I can keep your counsel and not mine own.”, what does “counsel” most nearly mean?

A. an assembly

B. villainous; sly

C. remedy

D. secret; private plan

Answer key: 1. C (Rosencrantz and Guildenstern); 2. A (A sponge); 3. C (In riddles); 4. C (Runs off); 5. B (The king's); 6. A (villainous; sly); 7. D (secret; private plan)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.3, W.7.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this play is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Act IV, Scene II,” how does Shakespeare show Hamlet hides the body? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the characterization you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In Act IV, Scene II, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of Hamlet hides the body? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the characterization in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act IV, Scene II develops the idea of Hamlet hides the body. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and diction / vocabulary shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act IV, Scene II (where it begins, turns and ends) and its characterization shape the reader's understanding of Hamlet hides the body. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act IV, Scene II suggests about Hamlet hides the body. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's characterization and diction / vocabulary), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses characterization in Act IV, Scene II to complicate the reader's understanding of Hamlet hides the body. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate Act IV, Scene II within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of Hamlet hides the body

responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read Act IV, Scene II alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of Hamlet hides the body follows or bends those conventions, using the characterization as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act IV, Scene II and its treatment of Hamlet hides the body. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's characterization and diction / vocabulary, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads Act IV, Scene II as evidence for a larger claim about Hamlet hides the body in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads Act IV, Scene II as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of Hamlet hides the body. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *To bear all smooth and even, This sudden sending him away must seem Deliberate pause: diseases desperate grown By desperate appliance are relieved, Or not at all.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “appliance” most nearly mean?

   A. remedy

   B. forgetfulness

   C. sons of one's brother or sister

   D. to hesitate because of moral doubt

2. *Ay, sir, that soaks up the king’s countenance, his rewards, his authorities. But such officers do the king best service in the end: he keeps them, like an ape, in the corner of his jaw; first mouthed, to be last swallowed: when he needs what you have gleaned, it is but squeezing you, and, sponge, you shall be dry again.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “Act IV, Scene II”?

   A. Hamlet hides the body

   B. The Ghost's revelation

   C. The closet scene

   D. Worms and kings

SAT key: 1. A (remedy); 2. A (Hamlet hides the body)

Lesson 16: Act IV, Scene III

Focus: worms and kings

Teacher only · spoilers

Claudius questions Hamlet, who says Polonius is at supper where he is eaten by worms. Claudius sends him to England, then reveals in soliloquy his letter ordering Hamlet's death.

Background: England owed Denmark tribute.

Significance: Mortality and Claudius's treachery.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
What does death do to rank? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to death and mortality because....
Prompt: What does death do to rank?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to death and mortality because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: kings and beggars.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: appliance — remedy; convocation — an assembly; imposthume — an abscess; internal swelling; nephews — sons of one's brother or sister; oblivion — forgetfulness.
Words: appliance: remedy · convocation: an assembly · imposthume: an abscess; internal swelling · nephews: sons of one's brother or sister · oblivion: forgetfulness

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
England owed Denmark tribute. Mortality and Claudius's treachery. Diction / vocabulary: Worms and kings. Plot: Claudius sends Hamlet to England with a death order. Characterization: Claudius's soliloquy. Watch for acting and seeming: "Seems, madam! nay it is": performance, the players, feigned madness and the Mousetrap. In this scene: “all smooth and even, / This sudden sending him away must seem / Deliberate pause: diseases desperate grown / By desperate appliance are relieved, / Or” (Act IV, Scene III, King (speech 1)).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "Your worm is your only emperor for diet" (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet (speech 10)). Death levels all. That is diction / vocabulary at work: Worms and kings.

> *Your worm is your only emperor for diet (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet (speech 10))*

Think-aloud: I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "Your worm is your only emperor for diet" (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet (speech 10)). Death levels all. That is diction / vocabulary at work: Worms and kings.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Mortality. Look at the craft: Claudius sends Hamlet to England with a death order. Ask: How does this line connect to death and mortality? Expected: Kings and beggars. (Mortality.)

> *a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet (speech 14))*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Mortality. Look at the craft: Claudius sends Hamlet to England with a death order.
Ask: How does this line connect to death and mortality?
Expected answer: Kings and beggars. (Mortality.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the scene for diction / vocabulary, plot (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about worms and kings? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act IV, Scene III develops the idea of worms and kings. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of diction / vocabulary and plot shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death. When the text says "a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar" (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet (speech 14)), it shows this directly. He says "Your worm is your only emperor for diet" and "a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar," while Claudius orders "Do it, England."
Task: Annotate the scene for diction / vocabulary, plot (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about worms and kings? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act IV, Scene III develops the idea of worms and kings. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of diction / vocabulary and plot shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death. When the text says "a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar" (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet (speech 14)), it shows this directly. He says "Your worm is your only emperor for diet" and "a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar," while Claudius orders "Do it, England."

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: What does death do to rank? Does Hamlet suspect Claudius's plan?
Anchor question: What does death do to rank?
Facilitation: Does Hamlet suspect Claudius's plan?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about worms and kings? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death. ("a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar", Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet (speech 14)). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about worms and kings? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death. ("a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar", Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet (speech 14)). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how diction / vocabulary shapes worms and kings. Key takeaway: kings and beggars.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Diction / vocabulary:** Worms and kings.
- **Plot:** Claudius sends Hamlet to England with a death order.
- **Characterization:** Claudius's soliloquy.

Themes and how they develop

- **death and mortality:** kings and beggars.

Symbols and motifs

- **acting and seeming:** "Seems, madam! nay it is": performance, the players, feigned madness and the Mousetrap. In this scene: "all smooth and even, / This sudden sending him away must seem / Deliberate pause: diseases desperate grown / By desperate appliance are relieved, / Or" (Act IV, Scene III, King (speech 1)).
- **death and the grave:** skulls, worms and dust: what all bodies come to. In this scene: "Where the dead body is bestow'd, my lord, / We cannot get from him" (Act IV, Scene III, Rosencrantz (speech 2)).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- "Your worm is your only emperor for diet" (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet (speech 10)) Death levels all.
- "a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar" (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet (speech 14)) Mortality.
- "Do it, England" (Act IV, Scene III, King (speech 27)) Claudius's plan.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death.
Evidence: "a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar" (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet (speech 14))
Reasoning: He says "Your worm is your only emperor for diet" and "a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar," while Claudius orders "Do it, England."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
appliance (noun)	remedy	*To bear all smooth and even, This sudden sending him away must seem Deliberate pause: diseases desperate grown By desperate appliance are relieved, Or not at all.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
convocation (noun)	an assembly	*Not where he eats, but where he is eaten: a certain convocation of politic worms are e'en at him.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
imposthume (noun)	an abscess; internal swelling	*Two thousand souls and twenty thousand ducats Will not debate the question of this straw: This is the imposthume of much wealth and peace, That inward breaks, and shows no cause without Why the man dies.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
nephews (noun)	sons of one's brother or sister	*The nephews to old Norway, Fortinbras.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
oblivion (noun)	forgetfulness	*Now, whether it be Bestial oblivion, or some craven scruple Of thinking too precisely on the event, A thought which, quarter'd, hath but one part wisdom And ever three parts coward, I do not know Why yet I live to say "This thing's to do;"*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
scruple (verb)	to hesitate because of moral doubt	*Now, whether it be Bestial oblivion, or some craven scruple Of thinking too precisely on the event, A thought which, quarter'd, hath but one part wisdom And ever three parts coward, I do not know Why yet I live to say "This thing's to do;"*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
juggled (verb)	tricked; deceived	*I'll not be juggled with: To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil!*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
cuckold (noun)	a man whose wife is unfaithful		

		That drop of blood that's calm proclaims me bastard, Cries cuckold to my father, brands the harlot Even here, between the chaste unsmirched brow Of my true mother.	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. What does death do to rank?
2. Where does diction / vocabulary appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with corruption and the state?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What will a king do through a beggar? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Go a progress through his guts.
2. Where does Hamlet say Polonius is? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: At supper, being eaten
3. What does Claudius order? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Hamlet's death in England
4. What does Hamlet say about worms? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Your worm is your only emperor for diet
5. Where is the body? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Up the stairs into the lobby
6. What does Claudius call Hamlet? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Like the hectic in my blood
7. Retell the three most important events of "Act IV, Scene III" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Claudius questions Hamlet, who says Polonius is at supper where he is eaten by worms. Claudius sends him to England, then reveals in soliloquy his letter ordering Hamlet's death.
8. Who is on stage in "Act IV, Scene III", and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does "Act IV, Scene III" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: "To bear all smooth and even, This sudden sending him away must seem Deliberate pause: diseases desperate grown By desperate appliance are relieved, Or not at all." What does "appliance" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: appliance: remedy.

Inferential / analytical

1. Why is Claudius's letter significant? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: It shows his intent to kill.
2. What does "Act IV, Scene III" suggest about worms and kings? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: Mortality and Claudius's treachery.
3. Find one example of diction / vocabulary in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: Look for precise or unusual word choices and their connotations.
4. How does the plot in this scene shape what we understand about worms and kings? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Look for key events and the causes linking them.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death. Useful evidence: "Your worm is your only emperor for diet" (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet (speech 10)): Death levels all. On plot: Claudius sends Hamlet to England with a death order. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. In the passage that begins "I have sent to seek him, and to find the body.", why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in "Act IV, Scene III", and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Claudius questions Hamlet, who says Polonius is at supper where he is eaten by worms. Claudius sends him to England, then reveals in soliloquy his letter ordering Hamlet's death.
7. How does "Act IV, Scene III" build on "Act IV, Scene II"? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death. Useful evidence: "a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar" (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet (speech 14)): Mortality. Theme link: kings and beggars. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death. Useful evidence: "Do it, England" (Act IV, Scene III, King (speech 27)): Claudius's plan. On characterization: Claudius's soliloquy. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. The bell-ringer asked: "What does death do to rank?" Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does characterization appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with corruption and the state? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death. Useful evidence: "Your worm is your only emperor for diet" (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet (speech 10)):

Death levels all. On characterization: Claudius's soliloquy. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Does Hamlet suspect the plot? [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A judgment.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death. Useful evidence: “a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar” (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet (speech 14)): Mortality. Theme link: kings and beggars. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: “Mortality and Claudius's treachery.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death. Useful evidence: “Do it, England” (Act IV, Scene III, King (speech 27)): Claudius's plan. Theme link: kings and beggars. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death. Useful evidence: “Your worm is your only emperor for diet” (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet (speech 10)): Death levels all. On characterization: Claudius's soliloquy. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. You are directing “Act IV, Scene III”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of worms and kings. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death. Useful evidence: “a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar” (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet (speech 14)): Mortality. Theme link: kings and beggars. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. Write three questions of your own about “Act IV, Scene III”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death. Useful evidence: “Do it, England” (Act IV, Scene III, King (speech 27)): Claudius's plan. Theme link: kings and beggars. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
6. Connect this scene to revenge and justice: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death. Useful evidence: “Your worm is your only emperor for diet” (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet (speech 10)): Death levels all. Theme link: kings and beggars. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Is the diction / vocabulary in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death. Useful evidence: “a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar” (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet (speech 14)): Mortality. On diction / vocabulary: Worms and kings. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. Compare how “Act IV, Scene III” treats worms and kings with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death. Useful evidence: “Do it, England” (Act IV, Scene III, King (speech 27)): Claudius's plan. Theme link: kings and beggars. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. Predict what “Act IV, Scene IV” will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death. Useful evidence: “Your worm is your only emperor for diet” (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet (speech 10)): Death levels all. Theme link: kings and beggars. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about worms and kings? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's jokes about worms hide a serious point about death. Useful evidence: “a king may go a progress through the guts of a beggar” (Act IV, Scene III, Hamlet (speech 14)): Mortality. Theme link: kings and beggars. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Diction / vocabulary:** look for precise or unusual word choices and their connotations (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Plot**: key events and the causes linking them
- Also notice **Characterization**: what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them

Chapter quiz

1. Where does Hamlet say Polonius is?

   A. In the river

   B. In heaven

   C. In England

   D. At supper, being eaten

2. What does Claudius order?
   A. Polonius's burial only
   B. Laertes's return
   C. Hamlet's crowning
   D. Hamlet's death in England
3. What does Hamlet say about worms?
   A. Your worm is your only emperor for diet
   B. Nothing
   C. Worms fear kings
   D. Worms are friends
4. Where is the body?
   A. In the garden
   B. Up the stairs into the lobby
   C. In the river
   D. In the chapel
5. What does Claudius call Hamlet?
   A. Like the hectic in my blood
   B. A friend
   C. A son
   D. A traitor
6. In the line "To bear all smooth and even, This sudden sending him away must seem Deliberate pause: diseases desperate grown By desperate appliance are relieved, Or not at all.", what does "appliance" most nearly mean?
   A. an assembly
   B. remedy
   C. an abscess; internal swelling
   D. sons of one's brother or sister
7. In the line "Not where he eats, but where he is eaten: a certain convocation of politic worms are e'en at him.", what does "convocation" most nearly mean?
   A. sons of one's brother or sister
   B. an assembly
   C. an abscess; internal swelling
   D. remedy

Answer key: 1. D (At supper, being eaten); 2. D (Hamlet's death in England); 3. A (Your worm is your only emperor for diet); 4. B (Up the stairs into the lobby); 5. A (Like the hectic in my blood); 6. B (remedy); 7. B (an assembly)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.4, W.7.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this play is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In "Act IV, Scene

III," how does Shakespeare show worms and kings? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the diction / vocabulary you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.4, W.9-10.1): In Act IV, Scene III, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of worms and kings? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the diction / vocabulary in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.4, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act IV, Scene III develops the idea of worms and kings. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of diction / vocabulary and plot shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act IV, Scene III (where it begins, turns and ends) and its diction / vocabulary shape the reader's understanding of worms and kings. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.4, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act IV, Scene III suggests about worms and kings. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's diction / vocabulary and plot), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.4, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses diction / vocabulary in Act IV, Scene III to complicate the reader's understanding of worms and kings. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate Act IV, Scene III within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of worms and kings responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read Act IV, Scene III alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of worms and kings follows or bends those conventions, using the diction / vocabulary as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act IV, Scene III and its treatment of worms and kings. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's diction / vocabulary and plot, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads Act IV, Scene III as evidence for a larger claim about worms and kings in Hamlet. Connect close reading

of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads Act IV, Scene III as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of worms and kings. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *Two thousand souls and twenty thousand ducats Will not debate the question of this straw: This is the imposthume of much wealth and peace, That inward breaks, and shows no cause without Why the man dies.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “imposthume” most nearly mean?

   A. a man whose wife is unfaithful

   B. tricked; deceived

   C. an abscess; internal swelling

   D. to hesitate because of moral doubt

2. *I have sent to seek him, and to find the body. How dangerous is it that this man goes loose! Yet must not we put the strong law on him: He’s loved of the distracted multitude, Who like not in their judgment, but their eyes: And where ’tis so, the offender’s scourge is weigh’d, But never the offence. To bear all smooth and even, This sudden sending him away must seem Deliberate pause: diseases desperate grown By desperate appliance are relieved, Or not at all.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “Act IV, Scene III”?

   A. The graveyard

   B. The duel and the deaths

   C. Worms and kings

   D. Polonius spies on Laertes

SAT key: 1. C (an abscess; internal swelling); 2. C (Worms and kings)

Lesson 17: Act IV, Scene IV

Focus: Fortinbras's army

Teacher only · spoilers

Fortinbras's army crosses Denmark to fight over a worthless patch of Poland. Hamlet contrasts their readiness to die for honour with his own delay and vows bloody thoughts.

Background: Fortinbras as foil.

Significance: A turning point in Hamlet's resolve.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Is fighting for honour admirable? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to action and delay because....
Prompt: Is fighting for honour admirable?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to action and delay because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: Hamlet resolves.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: imposthume — an abscess; internal swelling; nephews — sons of one's brother or sister; oblivion — forgetfulness; scruple — to hesitate because of moral doubt; juggled — tricked; deceived.
Words: imposthume: an abscess; internal swelling · nephews: sons of one's brother or sister · oblivion: forgetfulness · scruple: to hesitate because of moral doubt · juggled: tricked; deceived

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Fortinbras as foil. A turning point in Hamlet's resolve. Structure: Soliloquy: "How all occasions do inform against me." Characterization: Fortinbras as foil. Conflict: Thought against action: Hamlet sees twenty thousand men die "for a fantasy and trick of fame" while he does nothing. Watch for death and the grave: skulls, worms and dust: what all bodies come to. In this scene: “Exposing what is mortal and unsure / To all that fortune, death and danger dare, / Even for an egg-shell. Rightly to be great” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 17)).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. “How all occasions do inform against me” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 17)). Hamlet's self-reproach. That is structure at work: Soliloquy: "How all occasions do inform against me."

> *How all occasions do inform against me (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 17))*

Think-aloud: I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. “How all occasions do inform against me” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 17)). Hamlet's self-reproach. That is structure at work: Soliloquy: "How all occasions do inform against me."

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Greatness. Look at the craft: Fortinbras as foil. Ask: How does this line connect to action and delay? Expected: Hamlet resolves. (Greatness.)

> *Rightly to be great / Is not to stir without great argument (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 17))*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Greatness. Look at the craft: Fortinbras as foil.
Ask: How does this line connect to action and delay?
Expected answer: Hamlet resolves. (Greatness.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the scene for structure, characterization (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Fortinbras's army? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act IV, Scene IV develops the idea of Fortinbras's army. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of structure and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution. When the text says “How all occasions do inform against me” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 17)), it shows this directly. He says "How all occasions do inform against me" and vows "My thoughts be bloody, or be nothing worth!"
Task: Annotate the scene for structure, characterization (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Fortinbras's army? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act IV, Scene IV develops the idea of Fortinbras's army. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of structure and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution. When the text says “How all occasions do inform against me” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 17)), it shows this directly. He says "How all occasions do inform against me" and vows "My thoughts be bloody, or be nothing worth!"

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: Is fighting for honour admirable? Is Fortinbras admirable?
Anchor question: Is fighting for honour admirable?
Facilitation: Is Fortinbras admirable?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Fortinbras's army? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution. ("How all occasions do inform against me", Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 17)). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Fortinbras's army? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution. ("How all occasions do inform against me", Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 17)). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how structure shapes Fortinbras's army. Key takeaway: Hamlet resolves.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Structure:** Soliloquy: "How all occasions do inform against me."
- **Characterization:** Fortinbras as foil.
- **Conflict:** Thought against action: Hamlet sees twenty thousand men die "for a fantasy and trick of fame" while he does nothing.

Themes and how they develop

- **action and delay:** Hamlet resolves.

Symbols and motifs

- **death and the grave:** skulls, worms and dust: what all bodies come to. In this scene: "Exposing what is mortal and unsure / To all that fortune, death and danger dare, / Even for an egg-shell. Rightly to be great" (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 17)).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- "How all occasions do inform against me" (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 17)) Hamlet's self-reproach.

- “Rightly to be great / Is not to stir without great argument” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 17)) Greatness.
- “O, from this time forth, / My thoughts be bloody, or be nothing worth” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 17)) Resolve.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution.
Evidence: “How all occasions do inform against me” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 17))
Reasoning: He says "How all occasions do inform against me" and vows "My thoughts be bloody, or be nothing worth!"

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
imposthume (noun)	an abscess; internal swelling	*Two thousand souls and twenty thousand ducats Will not debate the question of this straw: This is the imposthume of much wealth and peace, That inward breaks, and shows no cause without Why the man dies.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
nephews (noun)	sons of one's brother or sister	*The nephews to old Norway, Fortinbras.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
oblivion (noun)	forgetfulness	*Now, whether it be Bestial oblivion, or some craven scruple Of thinking too precisely on the event, A thought which, quarter’d, hath but one part wisdom And ever three parts coward, I do not know Why yet I live to say “This thing’s to do;”*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
scruple (verb)	to hesitate because of moral doubt	*Now, whether it be Bestial oblivion, or some craven scruple Of thinking too precisely on the event, A thought which, quarter’d, hath but one part wisdom And ever three parts coward, I do not know Why yet I live to say “This thing’s to do;”*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
juggled (verb)	tricked; deceived	*I’ll not be juggled with: To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil!*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
cuckold (noun)	a man whose wife is unfaithful	*That drop of blood that’s calm proclaims me bastard, Cries cuckold to my father, brands the harlot Even here, between the chaste unsmirched brow Of my true mother.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
hatchment (noun)	a coat of arms displayed at a funeral	*Let this be so; His means of death, his obscure funeral— No trophy, sword, nor hatchment o’er his bones, No noble rite nor formal ostentation— Cry to be heard, as ’twere from heaven to earth, That I must call’t in question.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
pelican (noun)	a bird believed to feed its young with its own blood	*To his good friends thus wide I’ll ope my arms; And like the kind life-rendering pelican, Repast them with my blood.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. Is fighting for honour admirable?
2. Where does structure appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with revenge and justice?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. How many men will die? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Twenty thousand.
2. Whose army passes? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Fortinbras's
3. What are they fighting for? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: A little patch of ground
4. How does Hamlet react? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: He berates his delay
5. What does Hamlet vow? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Bloody thoughts
6. Who tells Hamlet about the war? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: A Captain
7. Retell the three most important events of "Act IV, Scene IV" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Fortinbras's army crosses Denmark to fight over a worthless patch of Poland. Hamlet contrasts their readiness to die for honour with his own delay and vows bloody thoughts.
8. Who is on stage in "Act IV, Scene IV", and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does "Act IV, Scene IV" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: "Two thousand souls and twenty thousand ducats Will not debate the question of this straw: This is the imposthume of much wealth and peace, That inward breaks, and shows no cause without Why the man dies." What does "imposthume" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: imposthume: an abscess; internal swelling.

Inferential / analytical

1. What makes Fortinbras a foil? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: He acts decisively.
2. What does "Act IV, Scene IV" suggest about Fortinbras's army? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A turning point in Hamlet's resolve.
3. Find one example of structure in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: Look for how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does.

4. How does the characterization in this scene shape what we understand about Fortinbras's army? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution. Useful evidence: “How all occasions do inform against me” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 17)): Hamlet's self-reproach. On characterization: Fortinbras as foil. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. In the passage that begins “Two thousand souls and twenty thousand ducats Will not debate the question of this straw: This is the imposthume of much wealth and peace, That inward breaks, and shows no cause…”, why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in “Act IV, Scene IV”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Fortinbras's army crosses Denmark to fight over a worthless patch of Poland. Hamlet contrasts their readiness to die for honour with his own delay and vows bloody thoughts.
7. How does “Act IV, Scene IV” build on “Act IV, Scene III”? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution. Useful evidence: “Rightly to be great / Is not to stir without great argument” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 17)): Greatness. On structure: Soliloquy: "How all occasions do inform against me." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution. Useful evidence: “O, from this time forth, / My thoughts be bloody, or be nothing worth” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 17)): Resolve. On characterization: Fortinbras as foil. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. The bell-ringer asked: “Is fighting for honour admirable?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does conflict appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with revenge and justice? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Look for the forces, people or desires pulling against each other.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution. Useful evidence: “How all occasions do inform against me” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 17)): Hamlet's self-reproach. On conflict: Thought against action: Hamlet sees twenty thousand men die "for a fantasy and trick of fame" while he does nothing. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Is Fortinbras's war admirable or absurd? [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A judgment.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution. Useful evidence: “Rightly to be great / Is not to stir without great argument” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 17)): Greatness. Theme link: Hamlet resolves. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: “A turning point in Hamlet's resolve.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution. Useful evidence: “O, from this time forth, / My thoughts be bloody, or be nothing worth” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 17)): Resolve. Theme link: Hamlet resolves. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution. Useful evidence: “How all occasions do inform against me” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 17)): Hamlet's self-reproach. On characterization: Fortinbras as foil. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. You are directing “Act IV, Scene IV”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of Fortinbras's army. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution. Useful evidence: “Rightly to be great / Is not to stir without great argument” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 17)): Greatness. On structure: Soliloquy: "How all occasions do inform against me." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. Write three questions of your own about “Act IV, Scene IV”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution. Useful evidence: “O, from this time forth, / My thoughts be bloody, or be nothing worth” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 17)): Resolve. Theme link: Hamlet resolves. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
6. Connect this scene to action and delay: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution. Useful evidence: “How all occasions do inform against me” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 17)): Hamlet's self-reproach. Theme link: Hamlet resolves. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Is the structure in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution. Useful evidence: “Rightly to be great / Is not to stir without great argument” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 17)): Greatness. On structure: Soliloquy: "How all occasions do inform against me." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. Compare how “Act IV, Scene IV” treats Fortinbras's army with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution. Useful evidence: “O, from this time forth, / My thoughts be bloody, or be nothing worth” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 17)): Resolve. Theme link: Hamlet resolves. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. Predict what “Act IV, Scene V” will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution. Useful evidence: “How all occasions do inform against me” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 17)): Hamlet's self-reproach. Theme link: Hamlet resolves. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about Fortinbras's army? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Fortinbras's army shames Hamlet into resolution. Useful evidence: “Rightly to be great / Is not to stir without great argument” (Act IV, Scene IV, Hamlet (speech 17)): Greatness. Theme link: Hamlet resolves. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Structure:** look for how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Characterization**: what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them
- Also notice **Conflict**: the forces, people or desires pulling against each other

Chapter quiz

1. Whose army passes?
   A. England's
   B. Fortinbras's
   C. Laertes's
   D. Claudius's

2. What are they fighting for?
   A. Denmark
   B. A little patch of ground
   C. Gold
   D. A princess
3. How does Hamlet react?
   A. He berates his delay
   B. He weeps
   C. He joins
   D. He laughs
4. What does Hamlet vow?
   A. To confess
   B. Peace
   C. Bloody thoughts
   D. To flee
5. Who tells Hamlet about the war?
   A. A Captain
   B. Fortinbras
   C. Horatio
   D. Rosencrantz
6. In the line "Two thousand souls and twenty thousand ducats Will not debate the question of this straw: This is the imposthume of much wealth and peace, That inward breaks, and shows no cause without Why the man dies.", what does "imposthume" most nearly mean?
   A. forgetfulness
   B. sons of one's brother or sister
   C. to hesitate because of moral doubt
   D. an abscess; internal swelling
7. In the line "The nephews to old Norway, Fortinbras.", what does "nephews" most nearly mean?
   A. forgetfulness
   B. to hesitate because of moral doubt
   C. an abscess; internal swelling
   D. sons of one's brother or sister

Answer key: 1. B (Fortinbras's); 2. B (A little patch of ground); 3. A (He berates his delay); 4. C (Bloody thoughts); 5. A (A Captain); 6. D (an abscess; internal swelling); 7. D (sons of one's brother or sister)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.3, W.7.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this play is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In "Act IV, Scene IV," how does Shakespeare show Fortinbras's army? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two

details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the structure you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.5, W.9-10.1): In Act IV, Scene IV, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of Fortinbras's army? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the structure in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.5, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act IV, Scene IV develops the idea of Fortinbras's army. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of structure and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act IV, Scene IV (where it begins, turns and ends) and its structure shape the reader's understanding of Fortinbras's army. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act IV, Scene IV suggests about Fortinbras's army. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's structure and characterization), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses structure in Act IV, Scene IV to complicate the reader's understanding of Fortinbras's army. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate Act IV, Scene IV within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of Fortinbras's army responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read Act IV, Scene IV alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of Fortinbras's army follows or bends those conventions, using the structure as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act IV, Scene IV and its treatment of Fortinbras's army. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's structure and characterization, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads Act IV, Scene IV as evidence for a larger claim about Fortinbras's army in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads Act IV, Scene IV as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of Fortinbras's army. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *Now, whether it be Bestial oblivion, or some craven scruple Of thinking too precisely on the event, A thought which, quarter'd, hath but one part wisdom And ever three parts coward, I do not know Why yet I live to say "This thing's to do;"*

   As used in the text, what does the word "oblivion" most nearly mean?

   A. a bird believed to feed its young with its own blood

   B. a man whose wife is unfaithful

   C. a coat of arms displayed at a funeral

   D. forgetfulness

2. *Two thousand souls and twenty thousand ducats Will not debate the question of this straw: This is the imposthume of much wealth and peace, That inward breaks, and shows no cause without Why the man dies. I humbly thank you, sir.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of "Act IV, Scene IV"?

   A. The plot against Hamlet

   B. The Mousetrap

   C. Hamlet sees the Ghost

   D. Fortinbras's army

SAT key: 1. D (forgetfulness); 2. D (Fortinbras's army)

Lesson 18: Act IV, Scene V

Focus: Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return

Content note (mental illness, sexual content in songs): Ophelia's madness includes bawdy songs. Present her grief with care and discuss how the court responds to her.
Student preview: A grieving character loses her mind and sings songs.
Suggested language: "What do the people around Ophelia do, or fail to do?"

Teacher only · spoilers

Ophelia, mad with grief, sings songs and distributes flowers. Laertes storms the castle demanding revenge; Claudius calms him and promises satisfaction.

Background: Flowers carried symbolic meanings.

Significance: Laertes foils Hamlet.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
How do people show grief? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to revenge and justice because.... Content note before we start: A grieving character loses her mind and sings songs.
Prompt: How do people show grief?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to revenge and justice because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: Laertes acts at once.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: juggled — tricked; deceived; cuckold — a man whose wife is unfaithful; hatchment — a coat of arms displayed at a funeral; pelican — a bird believed to feed its young with its own blood; barefaced — open and bold, without any attempt to hide.
Words: juggled: tricked; deceived · cuckold: a man whose wife is unfaithful · hatchment: a coat of arms displayed at a funeral · pelican: a bird believed to feed its young with its own blood · barefaced: open and bold, without any attempt to hide

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Flowers carried symbolic meanings. Laertes foils Hamlet. Characterization: Ophelia's madness; Laertes's return. Symbolism: Ophelia's flowers. Plot: Laertes demands revenge. Watch for disease and rot: Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: "Let her come in. Exit Horatio. / To my sick soul, as sin's true nature is, / Each toy seems prologue to" (Act IV, Scene V, Queen (speech 6)).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. “There’s rosemary, that’s for remembrance” (Act IV, Scene V, Ophelia (speech 56)). Ophelia's flowers. That is characterization at work: Ophelia's madness; Laertes's return.

> *There’s rosemary, that’s for remembrance* (Act IV, Scene V, Ophelia (speech 56))

Think-aloud: I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. “There’s rosemary, that’s for remembrance” (Act IV, Scene V, Ophelia (speech 56)). Ophelia's flowers. That is characterization at work: Ophelia's madness; Laertes's return.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Laertes. Look at the craft: Ophelia's flowers. Ask: How does this line connect to revenge and justice? Expected: Laertes acts at once. (Laertes.)

> *To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil* (Act IV, Scene V, Laertes (speech 42))

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Laertes. Look at the craft: Ophelia's flowers.
Ask: How does this line connect to revenge and justice?
Expected answer: Laertes acts at once. (Laertes.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the scene for characterization, symbolism (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act IV, Scene V develops the idea of Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and symbolism shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. When the text says “To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil” (Act IV, Scene V, Laertes (speech 42)), it shows this directly. He cries "To hell, allegiance!" while Claudius notes "sorrows come... in battalions" and Ophelia gives "rosemary, that's for remembrance."
Task: Annotate the scene for characterization, symbolism (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act IV, Scene V develops the idea of Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and symbolism shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. When the text says “To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil” (Act IV, Scene V, Laertes (speech 42)), it shows this directly. He cries "To hell, allegiance!" while Claudius notes "sorrows come... in battalions" and Ophelia gives "rosemary, that's for remembrance."

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: How do people show grief? Compare Laertes and Hamlet.
Anchor question: How do people show grief?
Facilitation: Compare Laertes and Hamlet.

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. ("To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil", Act IV, Scene V, Laertes (speech 42)). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. ("To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil", Act IV, Scene V, Laertes (speech 42)). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how characterization shapes Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return. Key takeaway: Laertes acts at once.

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Characterization:** Ophelia's madness; Laertes's return.
- **Symbolism:** Ophelia's flowers.
- **Plot:** Laertes demands revenge.

Themes and how they develop

- **revenge and justice:** Laertes acts at once.

Symbols and motifs

- **disease and rot:** Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: "Let her come in. Exit Horatio. / To my sick soul, as sin's true nature is, / Each toy seems prologue to" (Act IV, Scene V, Queen (speech 6)).
- **poison and ears:** Old Hamlet was poisoned through the ear; lies poured into ears, and poison returns at the end. In this scene: "watch, I pray you. Exit Horatio. / O, this is the poison of deep grief; it springs / All from her father's death. O" (Act IV, Scene V, King (speech 24)).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- "There's rosemary, that's for remembrance" (Act IV, Scene V, Ophelia (speech 56)) Ophelia's flowers.
- "To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil" (Act IV, Scene V, Laertes (speech 42)) Laertes.
- "When sorrows come, they come not single spies, / But in battalions" (Act IV, Scene V, King (speech 24)) Claudius.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite.
Evidence: "To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil" (Act IV, Scene V, Laertes (speech 42))
Reasoning: He cries "To hell, allegiance!" while Claudius notes "sorrows come... in battalions" and Ophelia gives "rosemary, that's for remembrance."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
juggled (verb)	tricked; deceived	*I'll not be juggled with: To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil!*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
cuckold (noun)	a man whose wife is unfaithful	*That drop of blood that's calm proclaims me bastard, Cries cuckold to my father, brands the harlot Even here, between the chaste unsmirched brow Of my true mother.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
hatchment (noun)	a coat of arms displayed at a funeral	*Let this be so; His means of death, his obscure funeral— No trophy, sword, nor hatchment o'er his bones, No noble rite nor formal ostentation— Cry to be heard, as 'twere from heaven to earth, That I must call't in question.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
pelican (noun)	a bird believed to feed its young with its own blood	*To his good friends thus wide I'll ope my arms; And like the kind life-rendering pelican, Repast them with my blood.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
barefaced (adjective)	open and bold, without any attempt to hide	*They bore him barefaced on the bier; Hey non nonny, nonny, hey nonny; And in his grave rain'd many a tear:— Fare you well, my dove!*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
rosemary (noun)	an herb symbolizing remembrance	*There's rosemary, that's for remembrance; pray, love, remember: and there is pansies, that's for thoughts.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
riotous (adjective)	wild; rebellious	*Save yourself, my lord: The ocean, overpeering of his list, Eats not the flats with more impetuous haste Than young Laertes, in a riotous head, O'erbears your officers.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
battalions (noun)	armies; large groups	*O Gertrude, Gertrude, When sorrows come, they come not single spies, But in battalions.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

impetuous (adjective)	characterized by undue haste and lack of thought or deliberation	*Save yourself, my lord: The ocean, overpeering of his list, Eats not the flats with more impetuous haste Than young Laertes, in a riotous head, O'erbears your officers.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
breeding (noun)	manners shown by one's upbringing	*'Twere good she were spoken with; for she may strew Dangerous conjectures in ill-breeding minds.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. How do people show grief?
2. Where does characterization appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with action and delay?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What does Claudius say about sorrows? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: They come in battalions.
2. What does Ophelia hand out? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Flowers
3. Who storms the castle? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Laertes
4. What does rosemary mean? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Remembrance
5. Who calms Laertes? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Claudius
6. What do the people cry? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Laertes shall be king
7. Retell the three most important events of "Act IV, Scene V" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Ophelia, mad with grief, sings songs and distributes flowers. Laertes storms the castle demanding revenge; Claudius calms him and promises satisfaction.
8. Who is on stage in "Act IV, Scene V", and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does "Act IV, Scene V" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: "I'll not be juggled with: To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil!" What does "juggled" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: juggled: tricked; deceived.

Inferential / analytical

1. Why does Ophelia go mad? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Father's death and Hamlet's rejection.
2. What does "Act IV, Scene V" suggest about Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: Laertes foils Hamlet.
3. Find one example of characterization in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
4. How does the symbolism in this scene shape what we understand about Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: Look for objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. Useful evidence: "There's rosemary, that's for remembrance" (Act IV, Scene V, Ophelia (speech 56)): Ophelia's flowers. On symbolism: Ophelia's flowers. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. In the passage that begins "Save yourself, my lord: The ocean, overpeering of his list, Eats not the flats with more impetuous haste Than young Laertes, in a riotous head, O'erbears your officers.", why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in "Act IV, Scene V", and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Ophelia, mad with grief, sings songs and distributes flowers. Laertes storms the castle demanding revenge; Claudius calms him and promises satisfaction.
7. How does "Act IV, Scene V" build on "Act IV, Scene IV"? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. Useful evidence: "To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil" (Act IV, Scene V, Laertes (speech 42)): Laertes. Theme link: Laertes acts at once. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. Useful evidence: "When sorrows come, they come not single spies, / But in battalions" (Act IV, Scene V, King (speech 24)): Claudius. On characterization: Ophelia's madness; Laertes's return. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. The bell-ringer asked: "How do people show grief?" Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does plot appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with action and delay? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Look for key events and the causes linking them.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. Useful evidence: "There's

rosemary, that's for remembrance" (Act IV, Scene V, Ophelia (speech 56)): Ophelia's flowers. On plot: Laertes demands revenge. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Compare Laertes and Hamlet. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A judgment.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. Useful evidence: "To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil" (Act IV, Scene V, Laertes (speech 42)): Laertes. Theme link: Laertes acts at once. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: "Laertes foils Hamlet." How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. Useful evidence: "When sorrows come, they come not single spies, / But in battalions" (Act IV, Scene V, King (speech 24)): Claudius. Theme link: Laertes acts at once. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. Useful evidence: "There's rosemary, that's for remembrance" (Act IV, Scene V, Ophelia (speech 56)): Ophelia's flowers. On characterization: Ophelia's madness; Laertes's return. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. You are directing "Act IV, Scene V". Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. Useful evidence: "To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil" (Act IV, Scene V, Laertes (speech 42)): Laertes. Theme link: Laertes acts at once. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. Write three questions of your own about "Act IV, Scene V": one recall, one "why/how", and one "should/what if". Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. Useful evidence: "When sorrows come, they come not single spies, / But in battalions" (Act IV, Scene V, King (speech 24)): Claudius. Theme link: Laertes acts at once. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
6. Connect this scene to appearance and reality: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. Useful evidence: "There's rosemary, that's for remembrance" (Act IV, Scene V, Ophelia (speech 56)): Ophelia's flowers. Theme link:

Laertes acts at once. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Is the characterization in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. Useful evidence: “To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil” (Act IV, Scene V, Laertes (speech 42)): Laertes. On characterization: Ophelia's madness; Laertes's return. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. Compare how “Act IV, Scene V” treats Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. Useful evidence: “When sorrows come, they come not single spies, / But in battalions” (Act IV, Scene V, King (speech 24)): Claudius. Theme link: Laertes acts at once. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. Predict what “Act IV, Scene VI” will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. Useful evidence: “There’s rosemary, that’s for remembrance” (Act IV, Scene V, Ophelia (speech 56)): Ophelia's flowers. Theme link: Laertes acts at once. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes is Hamlet's opposite. Useful evidence: “To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil” (Act IV, Scene V, Laertes (speech 42)): Laertes. Theme link: Laertes acts at once. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Characterization:** look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Symbolism**: objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas
- Also notice **Plot**: key events and the causes linking them

Chapter quiz

1. What does Ophelia hand out?
   A. Flowers
   B. Rings
   C. Coins

D. Letters

2. Who storms the castle?
   A. Laertes
   B. Fortinbras
   C. Horatio
   D. Hamlet
3. What does rosemary mean?
   A. Love
   B. Remembrance
   C. Peace
   D. Hate
4. Who calms Laertes?
   A. Polonius
   B. Ophelia
   C. Claudius
   D. Gertrude
5. What do the people cry?
   A. Laertes shall be king
   B. Long live Hamlet
   C. Peace
   D. Death to Claudius
6. In the line "I'll not be juggled with: To hell, allegiance! vows, to the blackest devil!", what does "juggled" most nearly mean?
   A. tricked; deceived
   B. a coat of arms displayed at a funeral
   C. a man whose wife is unfaithful
   D. a bird believed to feed its young with its own blood
7. In the line "That drop of blood that's calm proclaims me bastard, Cries cuckold to my father, brands the harlot Even here, between the chaste unsmirched brow Of my true mother.", what does "cuckold" most nearly mean?
   A. a coat of arms displayed at a funeral
   B. a bird believed to feed its young with its own blood
   C. a man whose wife is unfaithful
   D. tricked; deceived

Answer key: 1. A (Flowers); 2. A (Laertes); 3. B (Remembrance); 4. C (Claudius); 5. A (Laertes shall be king); 6. A (tricked; deceived); 7. C (a man whose wife is unfaithful)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.3, W.7.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this play is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Act IV, Scene V,” how does Shakespeare show Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the characterization you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In Act IV, Scene V, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the characterization in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act IV, Scene V develops the idea of Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and symbolism shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act IV, Scene V (where it begins, turns and ends) and its characterization shape the reader's understanding of Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act IV, Scene V suggests about Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's characterization and symbolism), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses characterization in Act IV, Scene V to complicate the reader's understanding of Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate Act IV, Scene V within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read Act IV, Scene V alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return follows or bends those conventions, using the characterization as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act IV, Scene V and its treatment of Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's characterization and symbolism, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads Act IV, Scene V as evidence for a larger claim about Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads Act IV, Scene V as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *Let this be so; His means of death, his obscure funeral— No trophy, sword, nor hatchment o'er his bones, No noble rite nor formal ostentation— Cry to be heard, as 'twere from heaven to earth, That I must call't in question.*

   As used in the text, what does the word "hatchment" most nearly mean?

   A. characterized by undue haste and lack of thought or deliberation

   B. a coat of arms displayed at a funeral

   C. manners shown by one's upbringing

   D. armies; large groups

2. *Save yourself, my lord: The ocean, overpeering of his list, Eats not the flats with more impetuous haste Than young Laertes, in a riotous head, O'erbears your officers. The rabble call him lord; And, as the world were now but to begin, Antiquity forgot, custom not known, The ratifiers and props of every word, They cry "Choose we: Laertes shall be king:" Caps, hands, and tongues, applaud it to the clouds: "Laertes shall be king, Laertes king!"*

   Which choice best states a central concern of "Act IV, Scene V"?

   A. Worms and kings

   B. Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia

   C. Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return

   D. Hamlet sees the Ghost

SAT key: 1. B (a coat of arms displayed at a funeral); 2. C (Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return)

Lesson 19: Act IV, Scene VI

Focus: Hamlet's letter from the sea

Teacher only · spoilers

Sailors bring Horatio a letter: pirates attacked Hamlet's ship; Hamlet boarded them and was taken prisoner, but they treated him kindly. Rosencrantz and Guildenstern continue to England.

Background: Piracy was common.

Significance: Chance returns Hamlet.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
What role does luck play? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to action and delay because....
Prompt: What role does luck play?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to action and delay because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: chance, not planning, returns Hamlet to Denmark and to his revenge.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: boarded — forced their way onto (a ship); ambassador — an official messenger between states; overlooked — look past, fail to notice; conjunctive — closely united; acquittance — release; acquittal.
Words: boarded: forced their way onto (a ship) · ambassador: an official messenger between states · overlooked: look past, fail to notice · conjunctive: closely united · acquittance: release; acquittal

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Piracy was common. Chance returns Hamlet. Plot: Hamlet's letter to Horatio reports that pirates attacked his ship to England and brought him back to Denmark alone. Characterization: Hamlet acted at once in the sea fight ("I alone became their prisoner"), the decisiveness he lacked at court. Structure: The adventure is reported, not shown: the play keeps its focus on Elsinore. Watch for poison and ears: Old Hamlet was poisoned through the ear; lies poured into ears, and poison returns at the end. In this scene: "wouldst fly death. I have words to speak in thine ear will make thee dumb; yet are they much too light for" (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio (speech 7)).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "Ere we were two days old at sea, a pirate of very warlike appointment gave us chase" (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio (speech 7)). The pirate attack. That is plot at work: Hamlet's letter to Horatio reports that pirates attacked his ship to England and brought him back to Denmark alone.

> *Ere we were two days old at sea, a pirate of very warlike appointment gave us chase* (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio (speech 7))

Think-aloud: I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "Ere we were two days old at sea, a pirate of very warlike appointment gave us chase" (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio (speech 7)). The pirate attack. That is plot at work: Hamlet's letter to Horatio reports that pirates attacked his ship to England and brought him back to Denmark alone.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: The pirates were merciful thieves: they spared Hamlet because they expect him to repay them. Expected link: action and delay; compare Hamlet's later "divinity that shapes our ends." Ask: How does this line connect to action and delay? Expected: Chance, not planning, returns Hamlet to Denmark and to his revenge. (The pirates treat Hamlet well, expecting a reward.)

> *They have dealt with me like thieves of mercy* (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio (speech 7))

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: The pirates were merciful thieves: they spared Hamlet because they expect him to repay them. Expected link: action and delay; compare Hamlet's later "divinity that shapes our ends."
Ask: How does this line connect to action and delay?
Expected answer: Chance, not planning, returns Hamlet to Denmark and to his revenge. (The pirates treat Hamlet well, expecting a reward.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the scene for plot, characterization (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Hamlet's letter from the sea? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act IV, Scene VI develops the idea of Hamlet's letter from the sea. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of plot and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence. When the text says “I have words to speak in thine ear will make thee dumb” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio (speech 7)), it shows this directly. A pirate "of very warlike appointment gave us chase," and the pirates "dealt with me like thieves of mercy," so Hamlet comes home not by plan but by accident, carrying "words" that "will make thee dumb."
Task: Annotate the scene for plot, characterization (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about Hamlet's letter from the sea? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act IV, Scene VI develops the idea of Hamlet's letter from the sea. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of plot and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence. When the text says “I have words to speak in thine ear will make thee dumb” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio (speech 7)), it shows this directly. A pirate "of very warlike appointment gave us chase," and the pirates "dealt with me like thieves of mercy," so Hamlet comes home not by plan but by accident, carrying "words" that "will make thee dumb."

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: What role does luck play? Ask: is the pirate rescue too convenient? What does Shakespeare gain by reporting it in a letter?
Anchor question: What role does luck play?
Facilitation: Ask: is the pirate rescue too convenient? What does Shakespeare gain by reporting it in a letter?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Hamlet's letter from the sea? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence. (“I have words to speak in thine ear will make thee dumb”, Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio (speech 7)). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about Hamlet's letter from the sea? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence. (“I have words to speak in thine ear will make thee dumb”, Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio (speech 7)). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

> **87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)**
> Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
> *Today we saw how plot shapes Hamlet's letter from the sea. Key takeaway: chance, not planning, returns Hamlet to Denmark and to his revenge.*

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Plot:** Hamlet's letter to Horatio reports that pirates attacked his ship to England and brought him back to Denmark alone.
- **Characterization:** Hamlet acted at once in the sea fight ("I alone became their prisoner"), the decisiveness he lacked at court.
- **Structure:** The adventure is reported, not shown: the play keeps its focus on Elsinore.

Themes and how they develop

- **action and delay:** chance, not planning, returns Hamlet to Denmark and to his revenge.

Symbols and motifs

- **poison and ears:** Old Hamlet was poisoned through the ear; lies poured into ears, and poison returns at the end. In this scene: “wouldst fly death. I have words to speak in thine ear will make thee dumb; yet are they much too light for” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio (speech 7)).
- **death and the grave:** skulls, worms and dust: what all bodies come to. In this scene: “to me with as much speed as thou wouldst fly death. I have words to speak in thine ear will make thee” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio (speech 7)).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “Ere we were two days old at sea, a pirate of very warlike appointment gave us chase” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio (speech 7)) The pirate attack.
- “They have dealt with me like thieves of mercy” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio (speech 7)) The pirates treat Hamlet well, expecting a reward.
- “I have words to speak in thine ear will make thee dumb” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio (speech 7)) Hamlet hints at what he discovered on the ship.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence.
Evidence: “I have words to speak in thine ear will make thee dumb” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio (speech 7))
Reasoning: A pirate "of very warlike appointment gave us chase," and the pirates "dealt with me like thieves of mercy," so Hamlet comes home not by plan but by accident, carrying "words" that "will make thee dumb."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
boarded (verb)	forced their way onto (a ship)	*Finding ourselves too slow of sail, we put on a compelled valour, and in the grapple I boarded them: on the instant they got clear of our ship; so I alone became their prisoner.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
ambassador (noun)	an official messenger between states	*There's a letter for you, sir; it comes from the ambassador that was bound for England; if your name be Horatio, as I am let to know it is.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
overlooked (verb)	look past, fail to notice	*"Horatio, when thou shalt have overlooked this, give these fellows some means to the king: they have letters for him.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
conjunctive (adjective)	closely united	*The queen his mother Lives almost by his looks; and for myself— My virtue or my plague, be it either which— She's so conjunctive to my life and soul, That, as the star moves not but in his sphere, I could not but by her.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
acquittance (noun)	release; acquittal	*Now must your conscience my acquittance seal, And you must put me in your heart for friend, Sith you have heard, and with a knowing ear, That he which hath your noble father slain Pursued my life.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
envenom (verb)	poison	*Sir, this report of his Did Hamlet so envenom with his envy That he could nothing do but wish and beg Your sudden coming o'er, to play with him.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
postscript (noun)	a note added at the end of a letter	*And in a postscript here, he says "alone."*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
pastime (noun)	a sport; diversion	*Break not your sleeps for that: you must not think That we are made of stuff so flat and dull That we can let our beard be shook with danger And think it pastime.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. What role does luck play?
2. Where does plot appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with appearance and reality?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22,

23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. How many days at sea? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Two.
2. Who brings the letter? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Sailors
3. Who attacked Hamlet's ship? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Pirates
4. How did pirates treat Hamlet? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Like thieves of mercy
5. Where did Rosencrantz and Guildenstern go? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: England
6. Who receives the letter? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Horatio
7. Retell the three most important events of "Act IV, Scene VI" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Sailors bring Horatio a letter: pirates attacked Hamlet's ship; Hamlet boarded them and was taken prisoner, but they treated him kindly. Rosencrantz and Guildenstern continue to England.
8. Who is on stage in "Act IV, Scene VI", and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does "Act IV, Scene VI" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: "Finding ourselves too slow of sail, we put on a compelled valour, and in the grapple I boarded them: on the instant they got clear of our ship; so I alone became their prisoner." What does "boarded" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: boarded: forced their way onto (a ship).

Inferential / analytical

1. Why is Hamlet's return important? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: He comes back to complete revenge.
2. What does "Act IV, Scene VI" suggest about Hamlet's letter from the sea? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: Chance returns Hamlet.
3. Find one example of plot in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Look for key events and the causes linking them.
4. How does the characterization in this scene shape what we understand about Hamlet's letter from the sea? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence. Useful evidence: "Ere we were two days old at sea, a pirate of very warlike appointment gave us chase" (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio (speech 7)): The pirate attack. On characterization: Hamlet acted at once in the sea fight ("I alone became their prisoner"), the decisiveness he lacked at court. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. In the passage that begins “He shall, sir, an’t please him.”, why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in “Act IV, Scene VI”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Sailors bring Horatio a letter: pirates attacked Hamlet's ship; Hamlet boarded them and was taken prisoner, but they treated him kindly. Rosencrantz and Guildenstern continue to England.
7. How does “Act IV, Scene VI” build on “Act IV, Scene V”? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence. Useful evidence: “They have dealt with me like thieves of mercy” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio (speech 7)): The pirates treat Hamlet well, expecting a reward. On structure: The adventure is reported, not shown: the play keeps its focus on Elsinore. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence. Useful evidence: “I have words to speak in thine ear will make thee dumb” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio (speech 7)): Hamlet hints at what he discovered on the ship. On characterization: Hamlet acted at once in the sea fight ("I alone became their prisoner"), the decisiveness he lacked at court. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. The bell-ringer asked: “What role does luck play?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does structure appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with appearance and reality? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: Look for how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence. Useful evidence: “Ere we were two days old at sea, a pirate of very warlike appointment gave us chase” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio (speech 7)): The pirate attack. On structure: The adventure is reported, not shown: the play keeps its focus on Elsinore. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Is the pirate episode convincing? [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A judgment.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence. Useful evidence: “They have dealt with me like thieves of mercy” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio (speech 7)): The pirates treat Hamlet well, expecting a reward. Theme link: chance, not planning, returns Hamlet to Denmark and to his revenge. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

2. A critic might argue: “Chance returns Hamlet.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence. Useful evidence: “I have words to speak in thine ear will make thee dumb” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio (speech 7)): Hamlet hints at what he discovered on the ship. Theme link: chance, not planning, returns Hamlet to Denmark and to his revenge. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence. Useful evidence: “Ere we were two days old at sea, a pirate of very warlike appointment gave us chase” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio (speech 7)): The pirate attack. On characterization: Hamlet acted at once in the sea fight ("I alone became their prisoner"), the decisiveness he lacked at court. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. You are directing “Act IV, Scene VI”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of Hamlet's letter from the sea. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence. Useful evidence: “They have dealt with me like thieves of mercy” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio (speech 7)): The pirates treat Hamlet well, expecting a reward. On structure: The adventure is reported, not shown: the play keeps its focus on Elsinore. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. Write three questions of your own about “Act IV, Scene VI”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence. Useful evidence: “I have words to speak in thine ear will make thee dumb” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio (speech 7)): Hamlet hints at what he discovered on the ship. Theme link: chance, not planning, returns Hamlet to Denmark and to his revenge. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
6. Connect this scene to death and mortality: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence. Useful evidence: “Ere we were two days old at sea, a pirate of very warlike appointment gave us chase” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio (speech 7)): The pirate attack. Theme link: chance, not planning, returns Hamlet to Denmark and to his revenge. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. Is the plot in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his

later trust in providence. Useful evidence: “They have dealt with me like thieves of mercy” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio (speech 7)): The pirates treat Hamlet well, expecting a reward. On plot: Hamlet's letter to Horatio reports that pirates attacked his ship to England and brought him back to Denmark alone. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. Compare how “Act IV, Scene VI” treats Hamlet's letter from the sea with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence. Useful evidence: “I have words to speak in thine ear will make thee dumb” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio (speech 7)): Hamlet hints at what he discovered on the ship. Theme link: chance, not planning, returns Hamlet to Denmark and to his revenge. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. Predict what “Act IV, Scene VII” will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence. Useful evidence: “Ere we were two days old at sea, a pirate of very warlike appointment gave us chase” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio (speech 7)): The pirate attack. Theme link: chance, not planning, returns Hamlet to Denmark and to his revenge. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about Hamlet's letter from the sea? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Hamlet's return depends on chance, which prepares his later trust in providence. Useful evidence: “They have dealt with me like thieves of mercy” (Act IV, Scene VI, Horatio (speech 7)): The pirates treat Hamlet well, expecting a reward. Theme link: chance, not planning, returns Hamlet to Denmark and to his revenge. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Plot:** look for key events and the causes linking them (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Characterization**: what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them
- Also notice **Structure**: how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does

Chapter quiz

1. Who brings the letter?
   A. A messenger
   B. Rosencrantz
   C. Osric
   D. Sailors

2. Who attacked Hamlet's ship?
   A. Pirates
   B. English soldiers
   C. Norwegians
   D. Danes
3. How did pirates treat Hamlet?
   A. Like thieves of mercy
   B. Cruelly
   C. As a slave
   D. As a king
4. Where did Rosencrantz and Guildenstern go?
   A. England
   B. Poland
   C. Norway
   D. Denmark
5. Who receives the letter?
   A. Claudius
   B. Laertes
   C. Gertrude
   D. Horatio
6. In the line "Finding ourselves too slow of sail, we put on a compelled valour, and in the grapple I boarded them: on the instant they got clear of our ship; so I alone became their prisoner.", what does "boarded" most nearly mean?
   A. an official messenger between states
   B. look past, fail to notice
   C. closely united
   D. forced their way onto (a ship)
7. In the line "There's a letter for you, sir; it comes from the ambassador that was bound for England; if your name be Horatio, as I am let to know it is.", what does "ambassador" most nearly mean?
   A. an official messenger between states
   B. closely united
   C. look past, fail to notice
   D. forced their way onto (a ship)

Answer key: 1. D (Sailors); 2. A (Pirates); 3. A (Like thieves of mercy); 4. A (England); 5. D (Horatio); 6. D (forced their way onto (a ship)); 7. A (an official messenger between states)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.3, W.7.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this play is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In "Act IV, Scene

VI," how does Shakespeare show Hamlet's letter from the sea? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the plot you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In Act IV, Scene VI, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of Hamlet's letter from the sea? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the plot in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act IV, Scene VI develops the idea of Hamlet's letter from the sea. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of plot and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act IV, Scene VI (where it begins, turns and ends) and its plot shape the reader's understanding of Hamlet's letter from the sea. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act IV, Scene VI suggests about Hamlet's letter from the sea. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's plot and characterization), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses plot in Act IV, Scene VI to complicate the reader's understanding of Hamlet's letter from the sea. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate Act IV, Scene VI within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of Hamlet's letter from the sea responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read Act IV, Scene VI alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of Hamlet's letter from the sea follows or bends those conventions, using the plot as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act IV, Scene VI and its treatment of Hamlet's letter from the sea. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's plot and characterization, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads Act IV, Scene VI as evidence for a larger claim about Hamlet's letter from the sea in Hamlet. Connect

close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads Act IV, Scene VI as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of Hamlet's letter from the sea. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *"Horatio, when thou shalt have overlooked this, give these fellows some means to the king: they have letters for him.*

   As used in the text, what does the word "overlooked" most nearly mean?

   A. a sport; diversion

   B. poison

   C. a note added at the end of a letter

   D. look past, fail to notice

2. *He shall, sir, an't please him. There's a letter for you, sir; it comes from the ambassador that was bound for England; if your name be Horatio, as I am let to know it is.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of "Act IV, Scene VI"?

   A. Claudius's court and Hamlet's grief

   B. Claudius at prayer

   C. The duel and the deaths

   D. Hamlet's letter from the sea

SAT key: 1. D (look past, fail to notice); 2. D (Hamlet's letter from the sea)

Lesson 20: Act IV, Scene VII

Focus: the plot against Hamlet

Content note (suicide (implied)): Gertrude reports Ophelia's drowning; whether it was suicide is debated later. Use the safe-messaging script.
Student preview: This scene reports a young woman's death by drowning. Support is available if this is hard to read.
Suggested language: "Why does Gertrude describe the death so gently?"
Safe messaging: Discuss the character's despair and what the text does with it; do not dwell on methods. Before the lesson, remind students that support is available and how to reach the counselor. Check in privately with any student who seems affected and follow your school's referral protocol. **Share with students:** If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today. Let a counselor know in advance that this scene is being taught.

Teacher only · spoilers

Claudius explains to Laertes why he did not punish Hamlet publicly. News arrives that Hamlet has returned. They plot a fencing match with an unbated, poisoned sword and a poisoned cup. Gertrude reports Ophelia drowned.

Background: Fencing was an aristocratic sport.

Significance: The trap is set.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
When does revenge become crime? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to revenge and justice because.... Content note before we start: This scene reports a young woman's death by drowning. Support is available if this is hard to read. If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today.
Prompt: When does revenge become crime?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to revenge and justice because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds."

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: conjunctive — closely united; acquittance — release; acquittal; envenom — poison; postscript — a note added at the end of a letter; pastime — a sport; diversion.
Words: conjunctive: closely united · acquittance: release; acquittal · envenom: poison · postscript: a note added at the end of a letter · pastime: a sport; diversion

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Fencing was an aristocratic sport. The trap is set. Plot: Claudius and Laertes plot a fencing match: an unblunted foil, poison on the point and a poisoned cup as backup. Characterization: Laertes agrees to poison his blade; his rage makes him Claudius's tool. Imagery: Gertrude's report of Ophelia's drowning: willow, flowers, her clothes "spread wide," singing as she sinks. Watch for disease and rot: Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: "my lord. But let him come; / It warms the very sickness in my heart, / That I shall live and tell him to" (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes (speech 12)).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "I will do't: / And, for that purpose, I'll anoint my sword" (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes (speech 32)). Laertes adds poison to the plan. That is plot at work: Claudius and Laertes plot a fencing match: an unblunted foil, poison on the point and a poisoned cup as backup.

> *I will do't: / And, for that purpose, I'll anoint my sword (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes (speech 32))*

Think-aloud: I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "I will do't: / And, for that purpose, I'll anoint my sword" (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes (speech 32)). Laertes adds poison to the plan. That is plot at work: Claudius and Laertes plot a fencing match: an unblunted foil, poison on the point and a poisoned cup as backup.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Laertes would kill Hamlet even in church, a holy place of sanctuary. Expected link: revenge and justice; contrast Hamlet sparing Claudius at prayer. Ask: How does this line connect to revenge and justice? Expected: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds." (Laertes's answer when asked what he would do to Hamlet.)

> *To cut his throat i' the church (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes (speech 30))*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Laertes would kill Hamlet even in church, a holy place of sanctuary. Expected link: revenge and justice; contrast Hamlet sparing Claudius at prayer.
Ask: How does this line connect to revenge and justice?
Expected answer: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds." (Laertes's answer when asked what he would do to Hamlet.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)

Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).

Annotate the scene for plot, characterization (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about the plot against Hamlet? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act IV, Scene VII develops the idea of the plot against Hamlet. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of plot and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. When the text says “There is a willow grows aslant a brook” (Act IV, Scene VII, Queen (speech 36)), it shows this directly. Asked what he would do, he would "cut his throat i' the church," and he volunteers "I'll anoint my sword" with poison, while news of Ophelia's death ("There is a willow grows aslant a brook") feeds his fury.

Task: Annotate the scene for plot, characterization (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about the plot against Hamlet? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act IV, Scene VII develops the idea of the plot against Hamlet. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of plot and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)

Exemplar: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. When the text says “There is a willow grows aslant a brook” (Act IV, Scene VII, Queen (speech 36)), it shows this directly. Asked what he would do, he would "cut his throat i' the church," and he volunteers "I'll anoint my sword" with poison, while news of Ophelia's death ("There is a willow grows aslant a brook") feeds his fury.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)

Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.

Anchor question: When does revenge become crime? Ask: how does Gertrude know so much about Ophelia's death? Was it accident or suicide? Look ahead to the gravediggers' debate.

Anchor question: When does revenge become crime?

Facilitation: Ask: how does Gertrude know so much about Ophelia's death? Was it accident or suicide? Look ahead to the gravediggers' debate.

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)

Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).

Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about the plot against Hamlet? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. (“There is a willow grows aslant a brook”, Act IV, Scene VII, Queen (speech 36)). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about the plot against Hamlet? Support it with one short quotation.

Answer: Model answer: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. (“There is a willow grows aslant a brook”, Act IV, Scene VII, Queen (speech 36)). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

> **87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)**
> Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
> *Today we saw how plot shapes the plot against Hamlet. Key takeaway: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds."*

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Plot:** Claudius and Laertes plot a fencing match: an unblunted foil, poison on the point and a poisoned cup as backup.
- **Characterization:** Laertes agrees to poison his blade; his rage makes him Claudius's tool.
- **Imagery:** Gertrude's report of Ophelia's drowning: willow, flowers, her clothes "spread wide," singing as she sinks.

Themes and how they develop

- **revenge and justice:** Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds."

Symbols and motifs

- **disease and rot:** Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: “my lord. But let him come; / It warms the very sickness in my heart, / That I shall live and tell him to” (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes (speech 12)).
- **poison and ears:** Old Hamlet was poisoned through the ear; lies poured into ears, and poison returns at the end. In this scene: “for friend, / Sith you have heard, and with a knowing ear, / That he which hath your noble father slain / Pursued my life” (Act IV, Scene VII, King (speech 1)).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “To cut his throat i’ the church” (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes (speech 30)) Laertes's answer when asked what he would do to Hamlet.
- “I will do’t: / And, for that purpose, I’ll anoint my sword” (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes (speech 32)) Laertes adds poison to the plan.
- “There is a willow grows aslant a brook” (Act IV, Scene VII, Queen (speech 36)) Gertrude's account of Ophelia's death begins.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits.
Evidence: “There is a willow grows aslant a brook” (Act IV, Scene VII, Queen (speech 36))
Reasoning: Asked what he would do, he would "cut his throat i' the church," and he volunteers "I'll anoint my sword" with poison, while news of Ophelia's death ("There is a willow grows aslant a brook") feeds his fury.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
conjunctive (adjective)	closely united	*The queen his mother Lives almost by his looks; and for myself— My virtue or my plague, be it either which— She's so conjunctive to my life and soul, That, as the star moves not but in his sphere, I could not but by her.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
acquittance (noun)	release; acquittal	*Now must your conscience my acquittance seal, And you must put me in your heart for friend, Sith you have heard, and with a knowing ear, That he which hath your noble father slain Pursued my life.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
envenom (verb)	poison	*Sir, this report of his Did Hamlet so envenom with his envy That he could nothing do but wish and beg Your sudden coming o'er, to play with him.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
postscript (noun)	a note added at the end of a letter	*And in a postscript here, he says "alone."*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
pastime (noun)	a sport; diversion	*Break not your sleeps for that: you must not think That we are made of stuff so flat and dull That we can let our beard be shook with danger And think it pastime.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
needful (adjective)	necessary	*A very riband in the cap of youth, Yet needful too; for youth no less becomes The light and careless livery that it wears Than settled age his sables and his weeds, Importing health and graveness.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
outface (verb)	outdo; defy	*To outface me with leaping in her grave?*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
equivocation (noun)	ambiguity; word-play	*How absolute the knave is! we must speak by the card, or equivocation will undo us.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. When does revenge become crime?
2. Where does plot appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with death and mortality?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22,

23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. Where would Laertes cut Hamlet's throat? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: In the church.
2. What will Laertes's sword have? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Poison on an unblunted tip
3. What is the backup plan? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: A poisoned cup
4. How does Ophelia die? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Drowning
5. Who reports her death? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Gertrude
6. Why didn't Claudius act openly against Hamlet? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Gertrude and the people love him
7. Retell the three most important events of "Act IV, Scene VII" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Claudius explains to Laertes why he did not punish Hamlet publicly. News arrives that Hamlet has returned. They plot a fencing match with an unbated, poisoned sword and a poisoned cup. Gertrude reports Ophelia drowned.
8. Who is on stage in "Act IV, Scene VII", and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does "Act IV, Scene VII" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: "The queen his mother Lives almost by his looks; and for myself— My virtue or my plague, be it either which— She's so conjunctive to my life and soul, That, as the star moves not but in his sphere, I could not but by her." What does "conjunctive" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: conjunctive: closely united.

Inferential / analytical

1. Why does Laertes add poison? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: He bought an unction from a mountebank.
2. What does "Act IV, Scene VII" suggest about the plot against Hamlet? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: The trap is set.
3. Find one example of plot in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Look for key events and the causes linking them.
4. How does the characterization in this scene shape what we understand about the plot against Hamlet? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. Useful evidence: "To cut his throat i' the church" (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes (speech 30)): Laertes's answer when asked what he would do to Hamlet. On characterization: Laertes agrees to poison his blade; his rage makes him Claudius's tool. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. In the passage that begins “O, for two special reasons; Which may to you, perhaps, seem much unsinew’d, But yet to me they are strong.”, why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in “Act IV, Scene VII”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Claudius explains to Laertes why he did not punish Hamlet publicly. News arrives that Hamlet has returned. They plot a fencing match with an unbated, poisoned sword and a poisoned cup. Gertrude reports Ophelia drowned.
7. How does “Act IV, Scene VII” build on “Act IV, Scene VI”? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. Useful evidence: “I will do’t: / And, for that purpose, I’ll anoint my sword” (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes (speech 32)): Laertes adds poison to the plan. Theme link: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. Useful evidence: “There is a willow grows aslant a brook” (Act IV, Scene VII, Queen (speech 36)): Gertrude's account of Ophelia's death begins. On characterization: Laertes agrees to poison his blade; his rage makes him Claudius's tool. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. The bell-ringer asked: “When does revenge become crime?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does imagery appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with death and mortality? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: Look for sensory details (sight, sound, cold, light) and what mood they create.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. Useful evidence: “To cut his throat i’ the church” (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes (speech 30)): Laertes's answer when asked what he would do to Hamlet. On imagery: Gertrude's report of Ophelia's drowning: willow, flowers, her clothes "spread wide," singing as she sinks. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Is Laertes more honourable than Hamlet? [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A judgment.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. Useful evidence: “I will do’t: / And, for that purpose, I’ll anoint my sword” (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes (speech 32)): Laertes adds poison to the plan. Theme link: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the

church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

2. A critic might argue: “The trap is set.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. Useful evidence: “There is a willow grows aslant a brook” (Act IV, Scene VII, Queen (speech 36)): Gertrude's account of Ophelia's death begins. Theme link: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. Useful evidence: “To cut his throat i’ the church” (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes (speech 30)): Laertes's answer when asked what he would do to Hamlet. On characterization: Laertes agrees to poison his blade; his rage makes him Claudius's tool. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

4. You are directing “Act IV, Scene VII”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of the plot against Hamlet. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. Useful evidence: “I will do’t: / And, for that purpose, I’ll anoint my sword” (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes (speech 32)): Laertes adds poison to the plan. Theme link: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. Write three questions of your own about “Act IV, Scene VII”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. Useful evidence: “There is a willow grows aslant a brook” (Act IV, Scene VII, Queen (speech 36)): Gertrude's account of Ophelia's death begins. Theme link: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Connect this scene to corruption and the state: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. Useful evidence: “To cut his throat i’ the church” (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes (speech 30)): Laertes's answer when asked what he would do to Hamlet. Theme link: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Is the plot in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. Useful evidence: “I will do’t: / And, for that purpose, I’ll anoint my sword” (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes (speech 32)): Laertes adds poison to the plan. On plot: Claudius and Laertes plot a fencing match: an unblunted foil, poison on the point and a poisoned cup as backup. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. Compare how “Act IV, Scene VII” treats the plot against Hamlet with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. Useful evidence: “There is a willow grows aslant a brook” (Act IV, Scene VII, Queen (speech 36)): Gertrude's account of Ophelia's death begins. Theme link: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Predict what “Act V, Scene I” will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. Useful evidence: “To cut his throat i’ the church” (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes (speech 30)): Laertes's answer when asked what he would do to Hamlet. Theme link: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about the plot against Hamlet? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: Laertes's readiness for revenge, unlike Hamlet's, has no moral limits. Useful evidence: “I will do’t: / And, for that purpose, I’ll anoint my sword” (Act IV, Scene VII, Laertes (speech 32)): Laertes adds poison to the plan. Theme link: Laertes would "cut his throat i' the church"; Claudius says revenge "should have no bounds." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Plot:** look for key events and the causes linking them (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Characterization**: what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them
- Also notice **Imagery**: sensory details (sight, sound, cold, light) and what mood they create

Chapter quiz

1. What will Laertes's sword have?

   A. Poison on an unblunted tip

   B. A curse

   C. A jewel

   D. Nothing special

2. What is the backup plan?
    A. A second sword
    B. An ambush
    C. A false letter
    D. A poisoned cup
3. How does Ophelia die?
    A. Drowning
    B. Poison
    C. A fall
    D. Fever
4. Who reports her death?
    A. Laertes
    B. Horatio
    C. Gertrude
    D. Claudius
5. Why didn't Claudius act openly against Hamlet?
    A. Gertrude and the people love him
    B. He forgot
    C. He feared Laertes
    D. He liked Hamlet
6. In the line "The queen his mother Lives almost by his looks; and for myself— My virtue or my plague, be it either which— She's so conjunctive to my life and soul, That, as the star moves not but in his sphere, I could not but by her.", what does "conjunctive" most nearly mean?
    A. release; acquittal
    B. poison
    C. a note added at the end of a letter
    D. closely united
7. In the line "Now must your conscience my acquittance seal, And you must put me in your heart for friend, Sith you have heard, and with a knowing ear, That he which hath your noble father slain Pursued my life.", what does "acquittance" most nearly mean?
    A. a note added at the end of a letter
    B. release; acquittal
    C. poison
    D. closely united

Answer key: 1. A (Poison on an unblunted tip); 2. D (A poisoned cup); 3. A (Drowning); 4. C (Gertrude); 5. A (Gertrude and the people love him); 6. D (closely united); 7. B (release; acquittal)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.3, W.7.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this play is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In “Act IV, Scene VII,” how does Shakespeare show the plot against Hamlet? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the plot you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In Act IV, Scene VII, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of the plot against Hamlet? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the plot in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act IV, Scene VII develops the idea of the plot against Hamlet. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of plot and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act IV, Scene VII (where it begins, turns and ends) and its plot shape the reader's understanding of the plot against Hamlet. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act IV, Scene VII suggests about the plot against Hamlet. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's plot and characterization), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses plot in Act IV, Scene VII to complicate the reader's understanding of the plot against Hamlet. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate Act IV, Scene VII within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of the plot against Hamlet responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read Act IV, Scene VII alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of the plot against Hamlet follows or bends those conventions, using the plot as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act IV, Scene VII and its treatment of the plot against Hamlet. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's plot and characterization, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads Act IV, Scene VII as evidence for a larger claim about the plot against Hamlet in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads Act IV, Scene VII as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of the plot against Hamlet. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *Sir, this report of his Did Hamlet so envenom with his envy That he could nothing do but wish and beg Your sudden coming o'er, to play with him.*

   As used in the text, what does the word "envenom" most nearly mean?

   A. outdo; defy

   B. necessary

   C. ambiguity; word-play

   D. poison

2. *O, for two special reasons; Which may to you, perhaps, seem much unsinew'd, But yet to me they are strong. The queen his mother Lives almost by his looks; and for myself— My virtue or my plague, be it either which — She's so conjunctive to my life and soul, That, as the star moves not but in his sphere, I could not but by her. The other motive, Why to a public count I might not go, Is the great love the general gender bear him; Who, dipping all his faults in their affection, Would, like the spring that turneth wood to stone, Convert his gyves to graces; so that my arrows, Too slightly timber'd for so loud a wind, Would have reverted to my bow again, And not where I had aim'd them.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of "Act IV, Scene VII"?

   A. Hamlet hides the body

   B. The graveyard

   C. Laertes and Polonius advise Ophelia

   D. The plot against Hamlet

SAT key: 1. D (poison); 2. D (The plot against Hamlet)

Lesson 21: Act V, Scene I

Focus: the graveyard

Content note (suicide (discussed), human remains): Gravediggers debate whether Ophelia took her own life; skulls are handled. Use the safe-messaging script; keep focus on mortality and on how the Church and court treat her.
Student preview: Characters discuss a death that may have been suicide. Support is available if this is hard to read.
Suggested language: "What does the debate over her burial show about this society?"
Safe messaging: Discuss the character's despair and what the text does with it; do not dwell on methods. Before the lesson, remind students that support is available and how to reach the counselor. Check in privately with any student who seems affected and follow your school's referral protocol. **Share with students:** If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today. Let a counselor know in advance that this scene is being taught.

Teacher only · spoilers

Gravediggers joke as they dig Ophelia's grave. Hamlet and Horatio watch; Hamlet holds Yorick's skull and reflects on death. Ophelia's funeral procession arrives; Laertes leaps into the grave; Hamlet confronts him and they grapple.

Background: Suicides were denied full Christian burial.

Significance: Hamlet's view of death matures.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
What does death mean to you? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to death and mortality because.... Content note before we start: Characters discuss a death that may have been suicide. Support is available if this is hard to read. If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today.
Prompt: What does death mean to you?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to death and mortality because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: outface — outdo; defy; equivocation — ambiguity; word-play; shipwright — a builder of ships; gentlewoman — a woman of good family and manners; ingenious — showing inventiveness and skill.
Words: outface: outdo; defy · equivocation: ambiguity; word-play · shipwright: a builder of ships · gentlewoman: a woman of good family and manners · ingenious: showing inventiveness and skill

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Suicides were denied full Christian burial. Hamlet's view of death matures. Characterization: The gravediggers' jokes and Hamlet's reflections on Yorick's skull show a calmer Hamlet facing death. Diction / vocabulary: Prose wit among the graves: the clowns debate whether Ophelia deserves Christian burial. Plot: Ophelia's funeral; Laertes leaps into the grave and Hamlet grapples with him. Watch for disease and rot: Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: "I' faith, if he be not rotten before he die—as we have many pocky corses now-a-days, that will" (Act V, Scene I, First Clown (speech 67)).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio" (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet (speech 76)). Hamlet holds the skull of the jester he loved as a child. That is characterization at work: The gravediggers' jokes and Hamlet's reflections on Yorick's skull show a calmer Hamlet facing death.

> *Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio* (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet (speech 76))

Think-aloud: I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio" (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet (speech 76)). Hamlet holds the skull of the jester he loved as a child. That is characterization at work: The gravediggers' jokes and Hamlet's reflections on Yorick's skull show a calmer Hamlet facing death.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Hamlet means even Caesar's body became clay, perhaps used to patch a wall. Expected link: death and mortality. Ask: How does this line connect to death and mortality? Expected: Every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor. (Death levels the mighty.)

> *Imperious Caesar, dead and turn'd to clay* (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet (speech 84))

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Hamlet means even Caesar's body became clay, perhaps used to patch a wall. Expected link: death and mortality.
Ask: How does this line connect to death and mortality?
Expected answer: Every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor. (Death levels the mighty.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)

Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).

Annotate the scene for characterization, diction / vocabulary (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about the graveyard? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act V, Scene I develops the idea of the graveyard. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and diction / vocabulary shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. When the text says "Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio" (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet (speech 76)), it shows this directly. Holding Yorick's skull ("Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio"), Hamlet traces "Imperious Caesar, dead and turn'd to clay," then at the grave insists "I loved Ophelia: forty thousand brothers / Could not... Make up my sum."

Task: Annotate the scene for characterization, diction / vocabulary (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about the graveyard? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act V, Scene I develops the idea of the graveyard. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and diction / vocabulary shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)

Exemplar: The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. When the text says "Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio" (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet (speech 76)), it shows this directly. Holding Yorick's skull ("Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio"), Hamlet traces "Imperious Caesar, dead and turn'd to clay," then at the grave insists "I loved Ophelia: forty thousand brothers / Could not... Make up my sum."

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)

Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.

Anchor question: What does death mean to you? Ask: is Hamlet's outburst at the grave sincere grief or competition with Laertes?

Anchor question: What does death mean to you?

Facilitation: Ask: is Hamlet's outburst at the grave sincere grief or competition with Laertes?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)

Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).

Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about the graveyard? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. ("Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio", Act V, Scene I, Hamlet (speech 76)). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about the graveyard? Support it with one short quotation.

Answer: Model answer: The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. ("Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio", Act V, Scene I, Hamlet (speech 76)). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

> **87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)**
> Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
> *Today we saw how characterization shapes the graveyard. Key takeaway: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor.*

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Characterization:** The gravediggers' jokes and Hamlet's reflections on Yorick's skull show a calmer Hamlet facing death.
- **Diction / vocabulary:** Prose wit among the graves: the clowns debate whether Ophelia deserves Christian burial.
- **Plot:** Ophelia's funeral; Laertes leaps into the grave and Hamlet grapples with him.

Themes and how they develop

- **death and mortality:** every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor.

Symbols and motifs

- **disease and rot:** Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: “I’ faith, if he be not rotten before he die—as we have many pocky corses now-a-days, that will” (Act V, Scene I, First Clown (speech 67)).
- **acting and seeming:** "Seems, madam! nay it is": performance, the players, feigned madness and the Mousetrap. In this scene: “the point: if I drown myself wittingly, it argues an act: and an act hath three branches; it is, to act, to” (Act V, Scene I, First Clown (speech 5)).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet (speech 76)) Hamlet holds the skull of the jester he loved as a child.
- “Imperious Caesar, dead and turn’d to clay” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet (speech 84)) Death levels the mighty.
- “I loved Ophelia: forty thousand brothers / Could not, with all their quantity of love, / Make up my sum” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet (speech 104)) Hamlet's claim at the grave.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone.
Evidence: “Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet (speech 76))
Reasoning: Holding Yorick's skull ("Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio"), Hamlet traces "Imperious Caesar, dead and turn'd to clay," then at the grave insists "I loved Ophelia: forty thousand brothers / Could not... Make up my sum."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
outface (verb)	outdo; defy	*To outface me with leaping in her grave?*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
equivocation (noun)	ambiguity; word-play	*How absolute the knave is! we must speak by the card, or equivocation will undo us.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
shipwright (noun)	a builder of ships	*What is he that builds stronger than either the mason, the shipwright, or the carpenter?*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
gentlewoman (noun)	a woman of good family and manners	*If this had not been a gentlewoman, she should have been buried out o' Christian burial.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
ingenious (adjective)	showing inventiveness and skill	*O, treble woe Fall ten times treble on that cursed head, Whose wicked deed thy most ingenious sense Deprived thee of!*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
doomsday (noun)	the day of final judgment	*Cudgel thy brains no more about it, for your dull ass will not mend his pace with beating; and, when you are asked this question next, say "a grave-maker:" the houses that he makes last till doomsday.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
easiness (noun)	an easygoing, relaxed manner	*Custom hath made it in him a property of easiness.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
breeding (noun)	manners shown by one's upbringing	*Did these bones cost no more the breeding, but to play at loggats with 'em? mine ache to think on't.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. What does death mean to you?
2. Where does characterization appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with corruption and the state?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. How long has the gravedigger worked? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Since the day Hamlet was born, thirty years.
2. Whose skull does Hamlet hold? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Yorick's
3. Who was Yorick? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: The king's jester
4. Whose grave is being dug? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Ophelia's
5. Who leaps into the grave? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Laertes and Hamlet
6. What does Hamlet say of Caesar? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Turned to clay
7. Retell the three most important events of "Act V, Scene I" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Gravediggers joke as they dig Ophelia's grave. Hamlet and Horatio watch; Hamlet holds Yorick's skull and reflects on death. Ophelia's funeral procession arrives; Laertes leaps into the grave; Hamlet confronts him and they grapple.
8. Who is on stage in "Act V, Scene I", and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does "Act V, Scene I" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: "To outface me with leaping in her grave?" What does "outface" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: outface: outdo; defy.

Inferential / analytical

1. Why does the priest limit the rites? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Her death was doubtful.
2. What does "Act V, Scene I" suggest about the graveyard? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: Hamlet's view of death matures.
3. Find one example of characterization in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.
4. How does the diction / vocabulary in this scene shape what we understand about the graveyard? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: Look for precise or unusual word choices and their connotations.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. Useful evidence: "Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio" (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet (speech 76)): Hamlet holds the skull of the jester he loved as a child. On diction / vocabulary: Prose wit among the graves: the clowns debate whether Ophelia deserves Christian burial. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. In the passage that begins "Cudgel thy brains no more about it, for your dull ass will not mend his pace with beating; and, when you are asked this question next, say "a grave-maker:"", why might Shakespeare

have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.

6. What causes the main turn in "Act V, Scene I", and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Gravediggers joke as they dig Ophelia's grave. Hamlet and Horatio watch; Hamlet holds Yorick's skull and reflects on death. Ophelia's funeral procession arrives; Laertes leaps into the grave; Hamlet confronts him and they grapple.
7. How does "Act V, Scene I" build on "Act IV, Scene VII"? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. Useful evidence: "Imperious Caesar, dead and turn'd to clay" (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet (speech 84)): Death levels the mighty. Theme link: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. Useful evidence: "I loved Ophelia: forty thousand brothers / Could not, with all their quantity of love, / Make up my sum" (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet (speech 104)): Hamlet's claim at the grave. On characterization: The gravediggers' jokes and Hamlet's reflections on Yorick's skull show a calmer Hamlet facing death. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. The bell-ringer asked: "What does death mean to you?" Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does plot appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with corruption and the state? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Look for key events and the causes linking them.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. Useful evidence: "Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio" (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet (speech 76)): Hamlet holds the skull of the jester he loved as a child. On plot: Ophelia's funeral; Laertes leaps into the grave and Hamlet grapples with him. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Is Hamlet's grief sincere? [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A judgment.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. Useful evidence: "Imperious Caesar, dead and turn'd to clay" (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet (speech 84)): Death levels the mighty. Theme link: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: "Hamlet's view of death matures." How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A defended

position with evidence and one counterpoint.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. Useful evidence: “I loved Ophelia: forty thousand brothers / Could not, with all their quantity of love, / Make up my sum” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet (speech 104)): Hamlet's claim at the grave. Theme link: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. Useful evidence: “Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet (speech 76)): Hamlet holds the skull of the jester he loved as a child. On characterization: The gravediggers' jokes and Hamlet's reflections on Yorick's skull show a calmer Hamlet facing death. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

4. You are directing “Act V, Scene I”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of the graveyard. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. Useful evidence: “Imperious Caesar, dead and turn’d to clay” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet (speech 84)): Death levels the mighty. Theme link: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. Write three questions of your own about “Act V, Scene I”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. Useful evidence: “I loved Ophelia: forty thousand brothers / Could not, with all their quantity of love, / Make up my sum” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet (speech 104)): Hamlet's claim at the grave. Theme link: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Connect this scene to revenge and justice: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. Useful evidence: “Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet (speech 76)): Hamlet holds the skull of the jester he loved as a child. Theme link: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Is the characterization in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. Useful evidence: “Imperious Caesar, dead and turn’d to clay” (Act V,

Scene I, Hamlet (speech 84)): Death levels the mighty. On characterization: The gravediggers' jokes and Hamlet's reflections on Yorick's skull show a calmer Hamlet facing death. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. Compare how “Act V, Scene I” treats the graveyard with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. Useful evidence: “I loved Ophelia: forty thousand brothers / Could not, with all their quantity of love, / Make up my sum” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet (speech 104)): Hamlet's claim at the grave. Theme link: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Predict what “Act V, Scene II” will bring, using two clues from this scene. After reading, evaluate your prediction. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. Useful evidence: “Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him, Horatio” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet (speech 76)): Hamlet holds the skull of the jester he loved as a child. Theme link: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about the graveyard? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The graveyard scene makes death physical and universal, and changes Hamlet's tone. Useful evidence: “Imperious Caesar, dead and turn’d to clay” (Act V, Scene I, Hamlet (speech 84)): Death levels the mighty. Theme link: every body comes to dust, from jester to emperor. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Characterization:** look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Diction / vocabulary**: precise or unusual word choices and their connotations
- Also notice **Plot**: key events and the causes linking them

Chapter quiz

1. Whose skull does Hamlet hold?

   A. Polonius's

   B. Caesar's

   C. His father's

   D. Yorick's

2. Who was Yorick?

   A. A soldier

B. A gravedigger

C. A priest

D. The king's jester

3. Whose grave is being dug?

A. Hamlet's

B. Polonius's

C. Ophelia's

D. Gertrude's

4. Who leaps into the grave?

A. Laertes and Hamlet

B. Gertrude

C. Claudius

D. Only Horatio

5. What does Hamlet say of Caesar?

A. A coward

B. Turned to clay

C. A god

D. A hero

6. In the line "To outface me with leaping in her grave?", what does "outface" most nearly mean?

A. a woman of good family and manners

B. ambiguity; word-play

C. a builder of ships

D. outdo; defy

7. In the line "How absolute the knave is! we must speak by the card, or equivocation will undo us.", what does "equivocation" most nearly mean?

A. a builder of ships

B. a woman of good family and manners

C. outdo; defy

D. ambiguity; word-play

Answer key: 1. D (Yorick's); 2. D (The king's jester); 3. C (Ophelia's); 4. A (Laertes and Hamlet); 5. B (Turned to clay); 6. D (outdo; defy); 7. D (ambiguity; word-play)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.3, W.7.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this play is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In "Act V, Scene I," how does Shakespeare show the graveyard? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the characterization you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In Act V, Scene I, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of the graveyard? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the characterization in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act V, Scene I develops the idea of the graveyard. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of characterization and diction / vocabulary shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act V, Scene I (where it begins, turns and ends) and its characterization shape the reader's understanding of the graveyard. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act V, Scene I suggests about the graveyard. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's characterization and diction / vocabulary), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses characterization in Act V, Scene I to complicate the reader's understanding of the graveyard. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate Act V, Scene I within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of the graveyard responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read Act V, Scene I alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of the graveyard follows or bends those conventions, using the characterization as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act V, Scene I and its treatment of the graveyard. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's characterization and diction / vocabulary, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads Act V, Scene I as evidence for a larger claim about the graveyard in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads Act V, Scene I as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of the graveyard. Position your reading within

a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *What is he that builds stronger than either the mason, the shipwright, or the carpenter?*

   As used in the text, what does the word "shipwright" most nearly mean?

   A. manners shown by one's upbringing

   B. a builder of ships

   C. an easygoing, relaxed manner

   D. the day of final judgment

2. *Cudgel thy brains no more about it, for your dull ass will not mend his pace with beating; and, when you are asked this question next, say "a grave-maker:" the houses that he makes last till doomsday. Go, get thee to Yaughan: fetch me a stoup of liquor. Exit Second Clown. He digs and sings. In youth, when I did love, did love, Methought it was very sweet, To contract, O, the time, for, ah, my behove, O, methought, there was nothing meet.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of "Act V, Scene I"?

   A. Ophelia's madness and Laertes's return

   B. The Ghost's revelation

   C. The Ghost on the battlements

   D. The graveyard

SAT key: 1. B (a builder of ships); 2. D (The graveyard)

Lesson 22: Act V, Scene II

Focus: the duel and the deaths

Content note (poisoning, multiple deaths): Four principal characters die on stage. Focus on justice and responsibility, not methods.
Student preview: The ending shows several deaths.
Suggested language: "Is the ending just?"

Teacher only · spoilers

Hamlet tells Horatio how he rewrote Claudius's letter so that Rosencrantz and Guildenstern were executed. Osric brings Laertes's challenge. In the duel Gertrude drinks the poisoned cup; Laertes wounds Hamlet; they exchange swords and Hamlet wounds Laertes. Gertrude dies; Laertes confesses; Hamlet kills Claudius. Laertes and Hamlet forgive each other; Hamlet dies; Fortinbras claims the throne.

Background: Royal successions were often decided by force.

Significance: The tragedy's resolution.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Is the ending just? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to death and mortality because.... Content note before we start: The ending shows several deaths.
Prompt: Is the ending just?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to death and mortality because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: disclaiming — denial; lapwing — a plover; bird thought to run with shell on its head; rapiers — light slender swords; woodcock — a bird easily caught; a fool; conceited — characteristic of false pride; having an exaggerated sense of self-importance.
Words: disclaiming: denial · lapwing: a plover; bird thought to run with shell on its head · rapiers: light slender swords · woodcock: a bird easily caught; a fool · conceited: characteristic of false pride; having an exaggerated sense of self-importance

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Royal successions were often decided by force. The tragedy's resolution. Plot: Hamlet tells how he sent Rosencrantz and Guildenstern to their deaths; Osric brings the challenge; in the duel Gertrude, Laertes, Claudius and Hamlet die; Fortinbras arrives. Characterization: Hamlet accepts whatever comes: "the readiness is all." Structure: Fortinbras, the foil introduced in the cast list, inherits Denmark. Watch for disease and rot: Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: "Aside. It is the poison'd cup: it is too late" (Act V, Scene II, King (speech 108)).

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "There's a divinity that shapes our ends, / Rough-hew them how we will" (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 3)). Hamlet's new trust in providence. That is plot at work: Hamlet tells how he sent Rosencrantz and Guildenstern to their deaths; Osric brings the challenge; in the duel Gertrude, Laertes, Claudius and Hamlet die; Fortinbras arrives.

> *There's a divinity that shapes our ends, / Rough-hew them how we will (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 3))*

Think-aloud: I read the line once for meaning and once for craft. "There's a divinity that shapes our ends, / Rough-hew them how we will" (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 3)). Hamlet's new trust in providence. That is plot at work: Hamlet tells how he sent Rosencrantz and Guildenstern to their deaths; Osric brings the challenge; in the duel Gertrude, Laertes, Claudius and Hamlet die; Fortinbras arrives.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: Acceptance before the duel. Look at the craft: Hamlet accepts whatever comes: "the readiness is all." Ask: How does this line connect to death and mortality? Expected: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story. (Acceptance before the duel.)

> *the readiness is all (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 77))*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: Acceptance before the duel. Look at the craft: Hamlet accepts whatever comes: "the readiness is all."
Ask: How does this line connect to death and mortality?
Expected answer: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story. (Acceptance before the duel.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).
Annotate the scene for plot, characterization (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about the duel and the deaths? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act V, Scene II develops the idea of the duel and the deaths. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of plot and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. When the text says “the readiness is all” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 77)), it shows this directly. He tells Horatio "There's a divinity that shapes our ends," says "the readiness is all," kills Claudius only after the poison is revealed, and dies with "The rest is silence."
Task: Annotate the scene for plot, characterization (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this scene suggest about the duel and the deaths? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how Act V, Scene II develops the idea of the duel and the deaths. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of plot and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)
Exemplar: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. When the text says “the readiness is all” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 77)), it shows this directly. He tells Horatio "There's a divinity that shapes our ends," says "the readiness is all," kills Claudius only after the poison is revealed, and dies with "The rest is silence."

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.
Anchor question: Is the ending just? Ask: is the ending just? Who deserved to die, and who did not?
Anchor question: Is the ending just?
Facilitation: Ask: is the ending just? Who deserved to die, and who did not?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Scene quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).
Scene quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about the duel and the deaths? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. (“the readiness is all”, Act V, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 77)). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.
Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this scene suggest about the duel and the deaths? Support it with one short quotation.
Answer: Model answer: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. (“the readiness is all”, Act V, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 77)). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the scene; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

> **87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)**
> Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
> *Today we saw how plot shapes the duel and the deaths. Key takeaway: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story.*

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Plot:** Hamlet tells how he sent Rosencrantz and Guildenstern to their deaths; Osric brings the challenge; in the duel Gertrude, Laertes, Claudius and Hamlet die; Fortinbras arrives.
- **Characterization:** Hamlet accepts whatever comes: "the readiness is all."
- **Structure:** Fortinbras, the foil introduced in the cast list, inherits Denmark.

Themes and how they develop

- **death and mortality:** Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story.

Symbols and motifs

- **disease and rot:** Denmark is sick: "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark"; corruption spreads like poison and ulcers. In this scene: “Aside. It is the poison’d cup: it is too late” (Act V, Scene II, King (speech 108)).
- **poison and ears:** Old Hamlet was poisoned through the ear; lies poured into ears, and poison returns at the end. In this scene: “Aside. It is the poison’d cup: it is too late” (Act V, Scene II, King (speech 108)).

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- “There’s a divinity that shapes our ends, / Rough-hew them how we will” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 3)) Hamlet's new trust in providence.
- “the readiness is all” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 77)) Acceptance before the duel.
- “The rest is silence” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 138)) Hamlet's last words.
- “Good night, sweet prince; / And flights of angels sing thee to thy rest” (Act V, Scene II, Horatio (speech 139)) Horatio's farewell.

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone.
Evidence: “the readiness is all” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 77))
Reasoning: He tells Horatio "There's a divinity that shapes our ends," says "the readiness is all," kills Claudius only after the poison is revealed, and dies with "The rest is silence."

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
disclaiming (noun)	denial	*Sir, in this audience, Let my disclaiming from a purposed evil Free me so far in your most generous thoughts, That I have shot mine arrow o'er the house, And hurt my brother.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
lapwing (noun)	a plover; bird thought to run with shell on its head	*This lapwing runs away with the shell on his head.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
rapiers (noun)	light slender swords	*Laertes wounds Hamlet; then, in scuffling, they change rapiers, and Hamlet wounds Laertes.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
woodcock (noun)	a bird easily caught; a fool	*Why, as a woodcock to mine own springe, Osric; I am justly kill'd with mine own treachery.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
conceited (adjective)	characteristic of false pride; having an exaggerated sense of self-importance	*But, on: six Barbary horses against six French swords, their assigns, and three liberal-conceited carriages; that's the French bet against the Danish.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
readiness (noun)	quickness and ease	*If it be now, 'tis not to come; if it be not to come, it will be now; if it be not now, yet it will come: the readiness is all: since no man has aught of what he leaves, what is't to leave betimes?*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
ordnance (noun)	cannons	*Exeunt, bearing off the dead bodies; after which a peal of ordnance is shot off.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
methinks (verb)	it seems to me	*But yet methinks it is very sultry and hot for my complexion.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
entertainment (noun)	an activity that is diverting and that holds the attention	*The queen desires you to use some gentle entertainment to Laertes before you fall to play.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. Is the ending just?
2. Where does plot appear in this scene, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this scene connect to the book's larger concern with revenge and justice?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1,

2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What happened to Rosencrantz and Guildenstern? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: They were executed in England.
2. Who drinks the poisoned cup? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Gertrude
3. How does Hamlet kill Claudius? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Poisoned sword and drink
4. Who confesses the plot? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Laertes
5. Who becomes king? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Fortinbras
6. What are Hamlet's last words? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: The rest is silence
7. Retell the three most important events of "Act V, Scene II" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Hamlet tells Horatio how he rewrote Claudius's letter so that Rosencrantz and Guildenstern were executed. Osric brings Laertes's challenge. In the duel Gertrude drinks the poisoned cup; Laertes wounds Hamlet; they exchange swords and Hamlet wounds Laertes. Gertrude dies; Laertes confesses; Hamlet kills Claudius. Laertes and Hamlet forgive each other; Hamlet dies; Fortinbras claims the throne.
8. Who is on stage in "Act V, Scene II", and who speaks the most? Name two characters and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the scene; check against the teacher summary.
9. Where and when does "Act V, Scene II" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the scene.
10. Reread: "Sir, in this audience, Let my disclaiming from a purposed evil Free me so far in your most generous thoughts, That I have shot mine arrow o'er the house, And hurt my brother." What does "disclaiming" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.1] Look for: disclaiming: denial.

Inferential / analytical

1. Why does Hamlet ask Horatio to live? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: To tell his story.
2. What does "Act V, Scene II" suggest about the duel and the deaths? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: The tragedy's resolution.
3. Find one example of plot in this scene. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Look for key events and the causes linking them.
4. How does the characterization in this scene shape what we understand about the duel and the deaths? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Look for what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. Useful evidence: "There's a

divinity that shapes our ends, / Rough-hew them how we will" (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 3)): Hamlet's new trust in providence. On characterization: Hamlet accepts whatever comes: "the readiness is all." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. In the passage that begins “The king, sir, hath wagered with him six Barbary horses: against the which he has imponed, as I take it, six French rapiers and poniards, with their assigns, as girdle, hangers,…”, why might Shakespeare have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
6. What causes the main turn in “Act V, Scene II”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: Hamlet tells Horatio how he rewrote Claudius's letter so that Rosencrantz and Guildenstern were executed. Osric brings Laertes's challenge. In the duel Gertrude drinks the poisoned cup; Laertes wounds Hamlet; they exchange swords and Hamlet wounds Laertes. Gertrude dies; Laertes confesses; Hamlet…
7. How does “Act V, Scene II” build on “Act V, Scene I”? Name one link of cause and effect. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous scene.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. Useful evidence: “the readiness is all” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 77)): Acceptance before the duel. On structure: Fortinbras, the foil introduced in the cast list, inherits Denmark. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say on stage here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. Useful evidence: “The rest is silence” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 138)): Hamlet's last words. On characterization: Hamlet accepts whatever comes: "the readiness is all." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. The bell-ringer asked: “Is the ending just?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
10. Where does structure appear, and how does it connect this scene to the larger concern with revenge and justice? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: Look for how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. Useful evidence: “Good night, sweet prince; / And flights of angels sing thee to thy rest” (Act V, Scene II, Horatio (speech 139)): Horatio's farewell. On structure: Fortinbras, the foil introduced in the cast list, inherits Denmark. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. Who is most responsible for the deaths? [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A judgment.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. Useful evidence: “There’s a divinity that shapes our ends, / Rough-hew them how we will” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 3)): Hamlet's new trust in providence. Theme link: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
2. A critic might argue: “The tragedy's resolution.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the scene. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. Useful evidence: “the readiness is all” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 77)): Acceptance before the duel. Theme link: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
3. Which character in this scene acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. Useful evidence: “The rest is silence” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 138)): Hamlet's last words. On characterization: Hamlet accepts whatever comes: "the readiness is all." Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. You are directing “Act V, Scene II”. Make two staging choices (a line delivery, a movement, a light or sound cue) and explain how each shapes the audience's view of the duel and the deaths. [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. Useful evidence: “Good night, sweet prince; / And flights of angels sing thee to thy rest” (Act V, Scene II, Horatio (speech 139)): Horatio's farewell. On structure: Fortinbras, the foil introduced in the cast list, inherits Denmark. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
5. Write three questions of your own about “Act V, Scene II”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. Useful evidence: “There’s a divinity that shapes our ends, / Rough-hew them how we will” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 3)): Hamlet's new trust in providence. Theme link: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Connect this scene to action and delay: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Shakespeare need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. Useful evidence: “the readiness is all” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 77)): Acceptance before the duel. Theme link: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. Is the plot in this scene effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. Useful evidence: “The rest is silence” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 138)): Hamlet's last words. On plot: Hamlet tells how he sent Rosencrantz and Guildenstern to their deaths; Osric brings the challenge; in the duel Gertrude, Laertes, Claudius and Hamlet die; Fortinbras arrives. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. Compare how “Act V, Scene II” treats the duel and the deaths with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Hamlet see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. Useful evidence: “Good night, sweet prince; / And flights of angels sing thee to thy rest” (Act V, Scene II, Horatio (speech 139)): Horatio's farewell. Theme link: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
9. As the final scene, does this ending resolve revenge and justice? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. Useful evidence: “There’s a divinity that shapes our ends, / Rough-hew them how we will” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 3)): Hamlet's new trust in providence. Theme link: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this scene (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about the duel and the deaths? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, RL.9-10.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: In the final scene Hamlet acts not by planning but by accepting providence, and the revenge comes at the cost of nearly everyone. Useful evidence: “the readiness is all” (Act V, Scene II, Hamlet (speech 77)): Acceptance before the duel. Theme link: Hamlet dies asking Horatio to tell his story. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Plot:** look for key events and the causes linking them (anchor passage in the We do segment)

- Also notice **Characterization**: what characters say, do and think, and how others react to them
- Also notice **Structure**: how the scene is ordered and why it begins and ends where it does

Chapter quiz

1. Who drinks the poisoned cup?
   A. Gertrude
   B. Laertes
   C. Claudius
   D. Hamlet
2. How does Hamlet kill Claudius?
   A. A pistol
   B. Strangling
   C. A fall
   D. Poisoned sword and drink
3. Who confesses the plot?
   A. Laertes
   B. Gertrude
   C. Horatio
   D. Osric
4. Who becomes king?
   A. Horatio
   B. Osric
   C. Fortinbras
   D. Laertes
5. What are Hamlet's last words?
   A. Good night
   B. Remember me
   C. The rest is silence
   D. Farewell
6. In the line “Sir, in this audience, Let my disclaiming from a purposed evil Free me so far in your most generous thoughts, That I have shot mine arrow o’er the house, And hurt my brother.”, what does “disclaiming” most nearly mean?
   A. a bird easily caught; a fool
   B. a plover; bird thought to run with shell on its head
   C. light slender swords
   D. denial
7. In the line “This lapwing runs away with the shell on his head.”, what does “lapwing” most nearly mean?
   A. a bird easily caught; a fool
   B. light slender swords

C. denial

D. a plover; bird thought to run with shell on its head

Answer key: 1. A (Gertrude); 2. D (Poisoned sword and drink); 3. A (Laertes); 4. C (Fortinbras); 5. C (The rest is silence); 6. D (denial); 7. D (a plover; bird thought to run with shell on its head)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.3, W.7.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this play is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In "Act V, Scene II," how does Shakespeare show the duel and the deaths? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the plot you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): In Act V, Scene II, how does Shakespeare develop the idea of the duel and the deaths? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the plot in the scene helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.3, W.9-10.1): Analyze how Act V, Scene II develops the idea of the duel and the deaths. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of plot and characterization shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1): Analyze how the structure of Act V, Scene II (where it begins, turns and ends) and its plot shape the reader's understanding of the duel and the deaths. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Two readers disagree about what Act V, Scene II suggests about the duel and the deaths. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the scene's plot and characterization), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.3, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how William Shakespeare uses plot in Act V, Scene II to complicate the reader's understanding of the duel and the deaths. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate Act V, Scene II within its historical and literary context and argue how the scene's treatment of the duel and the deaths responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read Act V, Scene II alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the scene's handling of the duel and the deaths

follows or bends those conventions, using the plot as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Act V, Scene II and its treatment of the duel and the deaths. State your method, show what it reveals in the scene's plot and characterization, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads Act V, Scene II as evidence for a larger claim about the duel and the deaths in Hamlet. Connect close reading of the scene to the whole play, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads Act V, Scene II as a hinge in the play's larger treatment of the duel and the deaths. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Hamlet.

SAT-style questions

1. *Laertes wounds Hamlet; then, in scuffling, they change rapiers, and Hamlet wounds Laertes.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “rapiers” most nearly mean?

   A. an activity that is diverting and that holds the attention

   B. light slender swords

   C. cannons

   D. it seems to me

2. *The king, sir, hath wagered with him six Barbary horses: against the which he has imponed, as I take it, six French rapiers and poniards, with their assigns, as girdle, hangers, and so: three of the carriages, in faith, are very dear to fancy, very responsive to the hilts, most delicate carriages, and of very liberal conceit.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “Act V, Scene II”?

   A. The duel and the deaths

   B. Polonius spies on Laertes

   C. 'To be, or not to be' and the nunnery scene

   D. Hamlet hides the body

SAT key: 1. B (light slender swords); 2. A (The duel and the deaths)

Whole-book test

Hamlet: whole-book test · 90 minutes

Part I: Multiple choice

1. Who is king of Denmark at the start?
   A. Fortinbras
   B. Polonius
   C. Claudius
   D. Old Hamlet
2. Where does the scene take place?
   A. A ship
   B. A graveyard
   C. The battlements at Elsinore
   D. The throne room
3. Whom has Claudius married?
   A. Ophelia
   B. A Norwegian princess
   C. Gertrude
   D. Hamlet's sister
4. Where is Laertes going?
   A. England
   B. Norway
   C. France
   D. Wittenberg
5. What is Claudius doing below?
   A. Praying
   B. Drinking and revelling
   C. Holding council
   D. Sleeping
6. How was Old Hamlet killed?
   A. Poison in the ear
   B. In battle
   C. Stabbed
   D. Drowned
7. Where is Reynaldo sent?
   A. Paris

B. Wittenberg

C. London

D. Norway

8. Who summoned Rosencrantz and Guildenstern?

A. Polonius

B. Claudius and Gertrude

C. Horatio

D. Hamlet

9. Who hides to watch?

A. Gertrude and Horatio

B. Laertes

C. Claudius and Polonius

D. Rosencrantz

10. What is the play's name?

A. The Ghost

B. The Revenge

C. The King's Fall

D. The Mousetrap

11. What does Claudius try to do?

A. Pray

B. Escape

C. Fight

D. Sleep

12. Where does Polonius hide?

A. Behind the arras

B. In the hall

C. Under the bed

D. In a closet

13. Who tells Claudius?

A. Laertes

B. Rosencrantz

C. Hamlet

D. Gertrude

14. Who asks where the body is?

A. Horatio

B. Claudius

C. Rosencrantz and Guildenstern

D. Gertrude

15. Where does Hamlet say Polonius is?
    A. In the river
    B. In heaven
    C. In England
    D. At supper, being eaten
16. Whose army passes?
    A. England's
    B. Fortinbras's
    C. Laertes's
    D. Claudius's
17. What does Ophelia hand out?
    A. Flowers
    B. Rings
    C. Coins
    D. Letters
18. Who brings the letter?
    A. A messenger
    B. Rosencrantz
    C. Osric
    D. Sailors
19. What will Laertes's sword have?
    A. Poison on an unblunted tip
    B. A curse
    C. A jewel
    D. Nothing special
20. Whose skull does Hamlet hold?
    A. Polonius's
    B. Caesar's
    C. His father's
    D. Yorick's
21. Who drinks the poisoned cup?
    A. Gertrude
    B. Laertes
    C. Claudius
    D. Hamlet

Part II: Short answer

1. Explain how revenge and justice develops from the beginning of the play to the end. Use two scenes.
2. Explain how action and delay develops from the beginning of the play to the end. Use two scenes.

3. Explain how appearance and reality develops from the beginning of the play to the end. Use two scenes.

Part III: Essay

Choose one of the play's central concerns (revenge and justice, action and delay, appearance and reality, death and mortality, corruption and the state) and argue how the ending reframes it.

Answer key

Answer key: 1. C (Claudius); 2. C (The battlements at Elsinore); 3. C (Gertrude); 4. C (France); 5. B (Drinking and revelling); 6. A (Poison in the ear); 7. A (Paris); 8. B (Claudius and Gertrude); 9. C (Claudius and Polonius); 10. D (The Mousetrap); 11. A (Pray); 12. A (Behind the arras); 13. D (Gertrude); 14. C (Rosencrantz and Guildenstern); 15. D (At supper, being eaten); 16. B (Fortinbras's); 17. A (Flowers); 18. D (Sailors); 19. A (Poison on an unblunted tip); 20. D (Yorick's); 21. A (Gertrude)

Essay assignments

Essay: Revenge and justice

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Hamlet teaches about revenge and justice. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how William Shakespeare develops revenge and justice in Hamlet. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how William Shakespeare develops revenge and justice across Hamlet. Trace the idea through at least three scenes and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Hamlet (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of revenge and justice. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of revenge and justice in Hamlet. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how William Shakespeare's choices in Hamlet (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of revenge and justice, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Hamlet's treatment of revenge and justice in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on revenge and justice in Hamlet that reads the play against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on revenge and justice in Hamlet. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about revenge and justice in Hamlet, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on revenge and justice in Hamlet, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Action and delay

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Hamlet teaches about action and delay. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how William Shakespeare develops action and delay in Hamlet. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how William Shakespeare develops action and delay across Hamlet. Trace the idea through at least three scenes and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Hamlet (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of action and delay. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of action and delay in Hamlet. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how William Shakespeare's choices in Hamlet (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of action and delay, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Hamlet's treatment of action and delay in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on action and delay in Hamlet that reads the play against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on action and delay in Hamlet. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about action and delay in Hamlet, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on action and delay in Hamlet, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Appearance and reality

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Hamlet teaches about appearance and reality. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how William Shakespeare develops appearance and reality in Hamlet. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how William Shakespeare develops appearance and reality across Hamlet. Trace the idea through at least three scenes and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Hamlet (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of appearance and reality. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of appearance and reality in Hamlet. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how William Shakespeare's choices in Hamlet (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of appearance and reality, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Hamlet's treatment of appearance and reality in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on appearance and reality in Hamlet that reads the play against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on appearance and reality in Hamlet. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about appearance and reality in Hamlet, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on appearance and reality in Hamlet, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Death and mortality

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Hamlet teaches about death and mortality. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how William Shakespeare develops death and mortality in Hamlet. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how William Shakespeare develops death and mortality across Hamlet. Trace the idea through at least three scenes and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Hamlet (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of death and mortality. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of death and mortality in Hamlet. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how William Shakespeare's choices in Hamlet (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of death and mortality, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Hamlet's treatment of death and mortality in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on death and mortality in Hamlet that reads the play against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on death and mortality in Hamlet. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about death and mortality in Hamlet, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on death and mortality in Hamlet, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Corruption and the state

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Hamlet teaches about corruption and the state. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how William Shakespeare develops corruption and the state in Hamlet. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how William Shakespeare develops corruption and the state across Hamlet. Trace the idea through at least three scenes and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Hamlet (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of corruption and the state. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of corruption and the state in Hamlet. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how William Shakespeare's choices in Hamlet (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of corruption and the state, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Hamlet's treatment of corruption and the state in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on corruption and the state in Hamlet that reads the play against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on corruption and the state in Hamlet. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about corruption and the state in Hamlet, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on corruption and the state in Hamlet, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

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